

The early rain had given way to what could only be described as a spectacular mid-morning. Warm and humid, as expected for this world, the pier smelled of sea—salt and algae carried inland by a steady breeze moving over old concrete baked smooth by decades of sun.

Caleb Mosby sat in a beach chair beneath the shadow of Farther Star's nose, the canvas stretched low enough to be comfortable and just inconvenient enough to discourage getting up. In one hand he held a fishing pole, the line trailing lazily into the water below. In the other was a bottle of beer that would not stay cold for long, condensation tracing slow paths down the glass. From a datapad tucked into the pocket of his sun-faded, brightly colored shirt, music drifted out in a tinny, cheerful murmur.

There were more bottles in the battered cooler beside him, nested in ice scavenged earlier from the Star's galley.

The Star was his ship. Supposedly a relic from the last war—surplus—but she was his, battered though she was. An assault shuttle once used to put men and steel into places the other side did not want them. Both the forward and aft loading ramps were down, clamshell doors open wide, letting the salt breeze roll through the cargo bay and out the far end, keeping the interior from turning into an oven beneath the tropical sun.

Brightwater was still being terraformed—nearly finished—but that had not stopped people from settling early. Shallow seas and chains of small islands drew them. Originally planned as a leisure world, it had been something else once the war shifted borders and priorities. The pier had anchored a massive terraforming processor, long since stripped and hauled away.

The war had turned the world into a backwater. Few wanted to vacation so close to somewhere another conflict might ignite at any time. The people who came anyway called it home and, in time, developed their own unhurried way of living. They had taken Mosby in as one of their own, even if he never thought of it in quite those terms.

The song drifted to its end. A bright, professional voice followed.

“Time for news from around the galaxy. Kestralis officials remain baffled by the failure of the Veylara transit gate. Khar’Vess Dominion interference has been ruled out. Council Transit Authority investigators report no evidence yet of mechanical fault. Solarian and Astraeum negotiators have reached an impasse over the disputed system from the last war. Minister—”

Mosby reached up and tapped the pad.

The quiet returned with the sound of water against pilings and distant seabirds. He rubbed the scar over his left eye with one finger, slow and absentminded, and let out a breath that might have been a sigh.

He leaned over, pushed his hand into the cooler's meltwater, and fished out another bottle. Droplets ran down his wrist as he turned it in his hand, thumb worrying the label until it peeled away in damp strips.

The slap of wood against metal broke the quiet, followed by the hollow clink of a paint can.

Mosby did not need to look.

But he did.

Manny was at it again.

Every so often the old man appeared without warning and began painting the hull of the Star as if it were the most natural thing in the world. Bright, unapologetic colors had long since claimed the once-drab plating—saints with solemn eyes, icons Mosby half-recognized, symbols and fragments of scripture from faiths and stories he could not begin to name. Somewhere along the port side, grinning beneath a careful halo of gold paint, was a portrait Manny called The King.

Elvis, whoever that was.

On cargo runs, reentry heat and hard vacuum blistered the paint and burned sections away. Manny never complained. He returned with fresh cans and added more—new faces, new symbols, new blessings layered over the old.

Early on, Mosby had tried to stop it.

The old man had been halfway through a saint's face, brush poised delicately at the curve of an eyelid, when Mosby stepped toward the hull with practical objections ready—maintenance, resale value, not wanting his ship turned into a traveling shrine.

He never spoke them.

A local boy—no more than eight or nine, skinny and sun-baked—darted in front of him and grabbed his wrist with both hands.

“No, Mister Mosby,” the boy said, eyes wide and solemn. “Bad juma if you don't let him. Ship need blessing. You don't stop.”

Before Mosby could answer, the boy crossed himself with exaggerated care and ran back toward town without looking back, as if the matter had already been decided by higher authority.

Mosby had stood there a moment, caught between irritation and confusion. By the time he looked up again, Manny had not paused once. The old man continued painting—unbothered, precise—as if boys issuing spiritual ultimatums were simply part of the working day.

Mosby let him finish.

Manny himself was thin and wiry, like most who were born here or had lived long enough to belong. He perched near the top rung of a ladder leaned against the hull, paint pails hanging from

bent-wire hooks, brush moving as though it knew the path without instruction. The ladder swayed gently, threatening to tip with every shift of weight, yet never quite doing so.

“What are you painting this time?” Mosby called, lifting a hand to shade his eyes.

“Eyes,” Manny replied without looking down. “Ship needs eyes. Needs to see, bring you back safe.”

Mosby leaned back.

He never understood the need to decorate nearly every vehicle on the islands in an explosion of color. Traffic through town was an endless parade of painted machines—bright panels, hand-drawn symbols, names in curling scripts. Smaller bikes, with no room for paint, wore tassels and streamers instead, ribbons snapping in the wind like festival banners that had forgotten the festival.

At first he had tried to persuade Manny not to touch the ship.

He had been politely ignored.

“The ship,” Manny had said once, tapping the hull with a paint-spattered knuckle, “she has a home now. And we want her know she belongs.”

“Most of that’ll burn off next reentry,” Mosby called up now.

Manny smiled at the hull rather than at Mosby. “Ship take care of town, take care of people. I take care of ship. She good ship. I don’t mind.”

A bottle later, Manny had changed sides and was nearly finished. The hull looked louder now—the new eyes bright and watchful, lines sharpened, final strokes added where Manny felt they were needed.

Then the sound reached them.

Engines. Low and deliberate. Tires grinding gravel down the road toward the pier.

Mosby noticed immediately.

Most people walked the beach instead—shorter, easier, cooler under bare feet. Vehicles meant purpose.

These meant outsiders.

Manny did not look up. He finished the line he was painting, leaned back slightly to study it.

“People come see you,” he said in the local pidgin, voice casual. “They arrive spaceport yesterday. Stay government house last night.”

Mosby frowned and took another drink. His fingers drifted to the scar over his eye.

“What do they want with me?”

Manny climbed down the ladder, knees giving a quiet pop as he descended. He sealed the paint cans, wiped his hands on a rag long past redemption, and settled a battered hat onto his greying head.

“Not for me say.”

He looked at Mosby then—just once—and something in his eyes was different.

Concern.

He slung the cans into a netted carrier and started up the beach toward his house, bare feet leaving dark prints in damp sand.

Mosby watched him go.

He had no doubt Manny knew exactly who they were and why they had come.

The vehicles rolled to a stop where the road ended and gravel gave way to sand. Engines idled, then died.

Six people stepped out.

Two were local police—uniforms faded by sun and salt, posture relaxed but alert. Two more wore neutrality like armor: deliberate movements, eyes always working, hands resting near hips that concealed weapons.

The next to step out was a woman.

Her dark hair was pulled back with precise care. Clothing matched the security detail in tone but not in purpose—tailored rather than practical. She paused, letting her eyes adjust to the light off the water.

But it was the last man who held Mosby’s attention.

Lieutenant Colonel Alastair Korrin.

No uniform. No insignia. Yet authority clung to him like humidity.

His gaze swept the scene: Mosby in the chair, the beer bottle, the fishing pole. Then it reached the ship.

It stopped.

A brief, unguarded grimace crossed his face.

He took a folder from one of the security men and walked toward the pier with clipped, purposeful strides. The woman followed.

Mosby noticed she did not react to the ship's appearance. Her eyes moved differently—cataloging hull, ramps, breeze, shoreline—as if mapping the place in a single pass.

She looked human.

Something about her did not quite settle.

They stopped a few meters away.

“Captain Caleb Mosby,” Korrin said, voice flat.

Mosby did not stand.

“Lieutenant Colonel Alastair Korrin,” he replied just as flat. “Last I heard, you were denied promotion.”

Korrin's jaw tightened. “We are both no longer in the Marines. I have a new position—Sector Subdirector, Solarian Intelligence. I have an assignment for you—”

“No.”

Mosby did not raise his voice.

“I'm not in your unit. I'm not part of your intelligence. You don't get to order me.”

Korrin's eyes flicked briefly to the Star, then back.

“I'm out,” Mosby added. “That's what discharged means.”

Color crept up Korrin's neck.

Before he could respond, the woman stepped smoothly into the space between them, altering the shape of the moment without challenging either man directly.

“We're not asking you to enlist,” she said calmly. “We just need you to fly.”

“It’s never that simple,” Mosby said. “Why me?”

“We need someone who can go where others can’t,” Korrin said. “And a ship that can get him there.”

His mouth tightened.

“And because I don’t like you.”

The woman did not react.

“That’s not the whole of it,” she said. “But it’s close enough to be honest.”

She turned fully toward Mosby.

“You have a ship that can enter contested space without announcing itself. You have clearance histories that still resolve in the gate system. You have experience flying without support, without oversight, and without expectation of rescue.”

“And,” she added, “you are here.”

Korrin folded his arms. “Don’t flatter him.”

“I’m not.”

She stepped closer.

“We’re not asking you to rejoin anything. No uniform. No command structure. No flag on your hull.”

“For now,” Korrin said.

She did not contradict him.

“We’re asking you to take the Farther Star somewhere we cannot officially go, and come back with what is found.”

“And if I say no?”

“You don’t,” Korrin snapped. “You can be recalled to service and ordered.”

“And your ship,” he added, gesturing toward the painted hull, “how it was released as surplus—that can be reviewed. Government property reclaimed.”

“You try that,” Mosby said calmly, “and half your paperwork eats the other half.”

For a moment, silence.

“You always thought you knew better,” Korrin said.

“I did,” Mosby replied. “At least once.”

The woman stepped forward again.

“If you say no, you remain free,” she said evenly. “It will simply take more effort to stay that way. Licenses take longer. Fuel costs more. Gate access stops resolving cleanly.”

Mosby smiled faintly. “That’s what you call not ordering me around.”

“It’s what I call describing the world you’re already in.”

He studied her.

“You are worse than that bastard.”

A faint twitch at the corner of her mouth.

“May I have a moment alone with Mr. Mosby?” she asked.

Korrin hesitated, then handed her the folder and withdrew.

When they were alone, Mosby finally took in the details.

She was tall, balanced, arranged for efficiency rather than display. Humidity did not touch her. No jewelry. No visible tech. Nothing unnecessary.

Her eyes were steady.

Not curiosity.

Assessment.

“But he’s not wrong about one thing,” she said. “This situation exists whether you participate or not. We need a man of your talents.”

“Who are you?”

She slid a single sheet from the folder and set it between them.

“My name is Sael, Thalean Ministry of Security,” she said. “And I’ll be going with you.”

“That wasn’t the question.”

“It’s the part that matters.”

“You don’t look like cargo.”

“I’m not. I’m there to make sure this does not become something it shouldn’t.”

Mosby stood and reached for the folder.

She did not hand it to him immediately.

She watched him—measuring something unrelated to paper.

Then she closed the folder.

“All right.”

She handed it to him.

“I’ll be back this evening. After you’ve looked things over.”

She turned and walked back toward the vehicles. Engines started. Gravel crunched. They disappeared beyond the rise.

Mosby stood with the folder in his hand, the Star breathing behind him, paint drying in the sun.

Later, Manny returned.

He climbed the ladder and rested his hand near one of the newly painted eyes. The paint was still tacky. His lips moved—words too soft to hear.

He drew his hand back.

“They coming back,” Manny said.

“Yes.”

“You going with them?”

“I don’t know yet.”

Manny nodded. “She got eyes now. That helps.”

He gathered his things and walked back toward town.

Mosby did not open the folder.

As the afternoon wore on, Mosby read the dossier in the folder.

Then he read it again.

It was thin. Almost insultingly so.

Fly to the Ael-Runn system.

Wait.

Then return.

No contingencies. No timelines beyond soon. No explanation of what they were supposed to be waiting for.

The problem wasn't the instructions.

The problem was Ael-Runn.

He leaned back in the chair, folder resting on his chest, eyes drifting to the bright line where sky met sea.

Ael-Runn sat inside the Astraeum Protectorate.

Four years ago, the Protectorate had been at war, firing on ships that flew under the same flags Mosby used to wear.

Officially neutral now. Publicly reconciled. Diplomats smiling for cameras.

But space didn't forget as quickly as press releases did.

A patrol boat had once held Mosby's transport group in a targeting grid for seven full minutes after the ceasefire, "confirming transponder validity." Nobody fired. Nobody spoke. They all just waited, knowing exactly how little it would take to start things again.

That was the sort of place Ael-Runn was.

Most Astraeum citizens weren't fanatics — not loud ones, anyway. They didn't rant.

They believed.

Deeply. Quietly. Structurally.

The Luminoti wasn't decoration to them. It wasn't something you practiced on weekends.

It was how law was justified. How strangers were judged. How wars were explained afterward.

Mosby scratched at the scar over his eye.

That alone would have made the job delicate.

Doing it in a Solarian-built ship, with a Thalean operative on board, in a system that had buried people because of both of those governments...

That made it something else entirely.

He looked down at the folder again.

Wait, it said.

In Astraeum space.

Uninvited.

He closed it.

As he considered his options, his stomach reminded him he hadn't eaten yet that day. Judging by the angle of the sun lowering toward the water, he could expect company soon, too.

With a sigh, he set the folder aside and pulled out a small grill from the cargo bay. After a moment's hesitation, he added a narrow table and two chairs.

If they were going to ask him to do something stupid, they could at least do it over decent food.

As the sun touched the ocean and the local prawns neared the end of their time on the grill, Mosby heard footsteps on the rear ramp.

He didn't turn.

Sael came up into the cargo bay with an easy, unhurried grace, as if the ship had already agreed to her presence. She paused just inside, her attention drawn to the built-in equipment racks along the bulkhead — scarred mounts, lock points polished by use, the quiet geometry of things meant to survive hard landings.

Then she continued forward, passing through the bay and out toward the open ramp that faced the pier.

“I didn’t hear you drive up,” Mosby observed.

“I walked down the beach,” she said. “I don’t get to enjoy the sights often.”

She had changed. The field jacket was gone. In its place was a simple local dress — light fabric, muted color, cut for the heat. Her hair was loose now, falling around her shoulders instead of pulled back with military neatness.

“That smells good,” she added. “I didn’t know you could cook.”

Mosby flipped one of the prawns, watching the shell darken and split over the coals.

“Ship rations get old after a while,” he said. “So I learned to cook whatever the local economy has to offer.” He turned the next one with practiced care. “Folks in town can’t always pay in credits. I take trade — whatever they can spare.”

“They rely on you, then.”

“Not many traders come this way,” Mosby replied. “I run a regular circuit every month — Aureline, Kallamar, **Parallax**, a few nearby systems. I was due to bring back microbiome stabilizers and some other supplies for the hospital on this run.”

He began transferring the prawns to a plate. Steam curled upward into the cooling evening air.

“It doesn’t make much more than fuel and maintenance,” he added, “but I don’t need much more. It helps people out. Medicine. Mail. Things we don’t have locally.”

Sael studied him for a moment. Not his face — his hands, the careful economy of his movements, the way the ship stood open behind him like part of the conversation.

“Mind if I sit?” she asked.

“Go ahead.”

She took the chair across from him. As he set the plate down and reached for the wine, Mosby caught the faintest trace of something unfamiliar when she shifted in the breeze.

Not perfume, exactly. Something warmer. Cinnamon, maybe. Cloves. Sweet, sharp, and out of place against salt air and grilled shellfish.

He didn’t comment on it.

But he noticed.

“You’ve had time to read the dossier,” she said as he poured the wine and handed her a glass.

“I did.”

Mosby sat and served a portion onto each plate. The prawns steamed faintly between them. He didn’t rush to eat.

“There wasn’t much to it,” he went on. “We leave here, head to the Ael-Runn system, land, wait while you do whatever it is you’re there to do, then come back.” He glanced at her over the rim of his glass. “If that’s really all there is, you could’ve booked passage on a commercial liner. Would’ve been cheaper. Quieter, too.”

Sael took a sip of wine and held the glass for a moment before setting it down. Her movements were unhurried, precise. Composed.

“You know it isn’t that simple,” she said.

Mosby gave a short, humorless snort. “Yeah. I do.” He leaned back slightly. “And it’s going to be rougher than you’re letting on.”

She didn’t interrupt.

“Ael-Runn sits inside the Protectorate,” he continued. “They’re touchy about who comes into their space on a good day. After the war?” He shook his head. “They don’t see outsiders as visitors. They see them as problems.”

He finally picked up his fork, more out of habit than appetite.

“And that’s before you factor in the Luminoti.”

Sael’s expression didn’t change — but something behind her eyes did.

“Of course,” she said. “That’s why you’re flying me in.”

She took a bite, then paused. Her expression shifted — not surprise, but genuine pleasure.

“Oh,” she said quietly. “This is good.”

She ate another bite before continuing, as if the food had earned her patience.

“You flew into worse places during the war,” she went on. “I read your file. Even the classified parts.” Her gaze held his. Steady. Present. “At least no one is shooting at you this time.”

Mosby set his fork down.

The sound was soft. Deliberate.

“We won’t have a team of operators backing us up either,” he said. “No overwatch. No extraction window. Just you, me, and the Star.”

Sael didn’t argue.

“I can fly her,” Mosby continued. “I can keep us out of trouble most days. But if this goes sideways — and it will — I’m going to need someone who can keep the ship working while I’m busy doing something else.”

He watched her carefully now.

“Engineering,” he said. “And it wouldn’t hurt if they knew how to move in places where questions come with consequences.”

Sael took another bite, slower this time. Thoughtful.

“You already have someone in mind,” she said.

Mosby picked up his glass, took a sip, then nodded once. “An old contact.”

She didn’t ask more.

“Two hundred thousand credits,” Mosby said after a moment. “Half up front. And another hundred thousand to cover the engineer.”

Sael didn’t blink.

She set her glass down and extended her hand across the table.

“Agreed.”

The word came too quickly.

Mosby didn’t take her hand.

“You didn’t even ask why.”

“I don’t need to,” she replied. “That number tells me how dangerous you think this is. And how much you’re willing to tolerate being lied to.”

A faint breath left him. Not quite a laugh.

“You’re not even pretending this is a negotiation.”

She met his eyes. Calm. Certain. “You weren’t pretending either.”

For a moment they sat there, the sound of the tide moving beneath the pier filling the space between them. Behind them, the Star's cooling systems ticked softly as metal adjusted to the night air.

Finally, Mosby took her hand.

Her grip was firm. Not dominant. Not tentative. Just sure.

The evening settled in around them, warm and salt-heavy, while the ship loomed quiet and watchful behind her — eyes freshly painted, staring out toward a future neither of them fully trusted.

The next two days started early.

When the Relay office opened, Mosby was already waiting outside with a cup of bitter station coffee and a list of names he hadn't had to use in a while. He sent messages to traders he knew and trusted — people who understood quiet work and didn't ask more questions than necessary. He estimated it would take at least a day before any replies came back.

After that he arranged for cargo to be ready for loading in two days' time, then returned to the Star and began moving through her methodically, securing anything loose that might rattle free under hard thrust.

The afternoon and the next day were spent checking and double-checking every system: power relays, cooling loops, hull seams along the forward flanks where Black Irons always took stress on violent entries. He worked with a light clamped between his teeth more often than not, collecting minor cuts on each hand and grease up to his elbows as he pulled open maintenance hatches that hadn't been touched in months.

The ship smelled different when she was opened up like this — metal, insulation, the faint sharp tang of coolant.

Sael appeared at some point without announcement.

He found her in the forward systems bay, sleeves rolled, diagnostic slate open, quietly recalibrating a sensor cluster that had been drifting off true for longer than he liked to admit.

"You don't have to do that," he said, leaning against the hatch frame.

"It was wrong," she replied without looking up. "If I'm risking my life in this ship, I want it right."

There was no accusation in it. Just fact.

He watched a moment longer, then nodded once and moved on.

The next morning, when the haulers arrived with the cargo, she took charge of the loading without asking permission.

Most of it was seafood packed in insulated crates and a small amount of local produce bound for markets farther along Mosby's usual route. The beach road filled with the smell of brine and engine exhaust as the haulers idled with their ramps down.

Sael moved through the cargo bay with the easy competence of someone who understood weight before theory. She balanced loads across the deck without being told how, keeping heavier crates low and forward, leaving the centerline clear. Nothing went near the access hatches. Nothing where it might shift under lateral thrust.

When she noticed Mosby watching, she said simply, "I worked logistics. Started as a loader. Moved up from there before getting into government work."

Mosby shrugged. That tracked. He let her continue.

By noon most of the cargo had been secured, netting cinched tight, tie-downs checked twice. The last hauler rolled away down the beach road, leaving tire tracks that would be gone by morning tide.

Manny came walking along the sand as if this were any other day.

Trousers rolled. Hat in hand. The slow, patient stride of a man who had never once hurried for someone else's schedule.

He carried a small envelope pouch tucked under his arm. Inside were printed relay texts — the replies to the messages Mosby had sent the morning before. Short, practical ones. A woman on Aureline who owed him a favor. A retired courier on Kallamar who still liked to feel useful. Each had agreed to cover the route Mosby normally ran until he returned.

After reading them, Mosby handed the messages back to Manny.

"Things'll be fine till I get back," he said. "Jacobson might overcharge a bit, but I can cover that later."

"Town good to know," Manny said, eyes moving over the ship, taking in the change in her usual relaxed, open feel. The ramps were still down, but the air around her had shifted. Less harbor. More departure.

Then Manny brought out what he'd been carrying in his other hand.

A necklace of bright braided cord, strung with small shells and a carved turtle of dark driftwood, worn smooth from handling.

Without ceremony, Manny slipped it over Mosby's head and let it settle against his chest.

“What’s this for?” Mosby asked, lifting the turtle between thumb and forefinger.

Manny shrugged. “For the journey. Turtle knows. Comes back to same shore.” He nodded once toward the ship. “Figure you should too.”

He didn’t wait for thanks. He simply turned and started back toward town.

“Hey,” Mosby called after him, “how do you know about turtles? Terraformers haven’t brought any in yet!”

Manny raised a hand without looking back.

“Don’t need to see them,” he called. “I know.”

Sael was tightening the last cargo strap when Mosby came up the aft ramp, boots ringing softly on the metal decking.

“We good to go?” he asked.

“Last one,” she said, giving the strap a final pull. “Doesn’t shift under lateral thrust now.”

“Good.” He glanced toward the stack of cases near the bulkhead. “Got all your gear?”

She pointed. “Everything I need.”

“Fine. You’ve got the copilot’s bunk. Stow your gear there. Any firearms go in the weapons locker,” Mosby said, reaching past her to thumb the control panel. The aft ramp began to rise, hydraulics whining as the clamshell doors folded inward and sealed with a heavy, final thud.

“Why is that?” she asked.

“My ship, my rules.” He gave her a level look. “I don’t want anything loose that could be trouble once we’re underway. You don’t like it, we can call this off right now.”

Sael held his gaze a moment longer than necessary. Then she nodded once. “Fine. But I want the access code.”

“I figured as much,” Mosby said, already turning away toward the forward passage.

Twenty minutes later, Mosby sat in the cockpit, running through preflight. The boards glowed in layered colors, status bars creeping steadily toward green as systems came online. He moved through the checklist by habit, fingers flipping guarded switches, eyes skimming readouts that had become as familiar as his own hands.

Sael entered quietly and slid into the copilot’s seat, fastening her harness with efficient, practiced motions.

“Are we ready?” she asked.

“Just about,” Mosby said. He keyed the transmitter.

“Brightwater Port Control, trader vessel Farther Star, requesting flight plan activation.”

A moment passed. Then an out-of-breath voice came back, slightly distorted by the old relay equipment. “Farther Star, Brightwater Control, go ahead.”

Mosby smiled faintly and continued working. The ship’s systems deepened in tone as the reactors shifted from standby to flight readiness. A low vibration built through the deck — not loud, but full of restrained promise, like a big animal thinking about running.

“Filed outbound to Aureline via direct burn,” he said. “Two souls aboard, cargo secured. Request plan activation and departure clearance.”

Sael raised an eyebrow. “Being a bit officious, aren’t you?”

“They don’t get much traffic,” Mosby said. “Makes ’em feel important. Keeps me in practice too.”

The voice came back. “Plan activated at 13:12 local. No other departures scheduled. You’re clear whenever ready, Mosby.”

“Brightwater Traffic, Farther Star lifting in two minutes.”

“Copy that. Surface corridor clear. Winds light out of the west. You mind if my cousin uses your pier while you’re gone?”

Mosby chuckled. “Sure. Tell him just don’t scuff anything.”

“No promises,” the voice replied.

Mosby eased the throttles forward.

The Farther Star lifted fast and clean, rising off the pier in a column of shimmering heat. The water below flattened under the thrust wash, ripples racing outward from the pilings as the ship clawed for altitude. The pier, the town, and the bright scatter of painted rooftops dropped away beneath them.

Blue faded to indigo, then to deepening violet. The horizon curved, subtle at first, then undeniable. Clouds thinned below like torn gauze, their tops catching sunlight that no longer reached the ground.

The vibration shifted as the atmosphere thickened against the hull, then began to fall away. A shudder ran through the frame as they punched through a band of rough air.

Sael's fingers tightened around the armrests.

"You all right?" Mosby asked, not looking away from the instruments.

She nodded once, too quickly. "Not used to this much turbulence."

Mosby's mouth twitched. "Lady, you ain't seen nothing yet."

Her head snapped toward him, eyes widening just a fraction.

His grin deepened, but his hands never stopped moving.

"Brightwater Traffic, Farther Star passing six-zero thousand meters, transitioning to orbital climb," he transmitted.

A moment later the reply crackled through. "Logged, Farther Star. Safe flight, Mosby. Relay office will forward any messages."

The sky darkened toward black ahead of them, and the first hard stars began to burn through.

Behind them, Brightwater turned slowly beneath a wash of afternoon light — already looking farther away than Mosby liked to admit.

Clearing the planet's gravity well took longer than most people expected, and Mosby wasn't pushing the engines hard. Their power came as a steady vibration through the ship — a low tremor in the deck and up through the seat frame. The climb was deliberate, efficient, unhurried, wasting no fuel as the Farther Star curved away and Brightwater fell behind.

Sael said little during ascent. Her hands stayed on the armrests, though the death grip she'd started with had eased. As violet faded to black and the world slipped out of view, she settled back and took several slow breaths.

"You okay?" Mosby asked, adjusting course, his hands moving easily across the controls.

"I..." She grimaced. "That felt rougher than I'm used to."

"You're used to civilian craft. They run heavier stabilizers and dampeners than what the Star was built with," he said. "I should apologize, though. Assault pilots turn the dampeners down to get a better feel for the ship going in on a run. Rides rougher, but that's what I'm used to." He glanced over, sincere. "I'll reset them to full next time."

Sael closed her eyes and let out a slow breath. "No... I'll manage. You do what you need to get us there."

Two hours later Mosby began the FTL checklist, eyes moving across displays and instruments as his hands worked the controls by habit. Sael had relaxed once they were clear of the planet. She returned from the galley with two mugs and offered one across the console.

"Coffee?"

"Oh, no thanks," Mosby said. "Four and a half years in the Marines and I never could get used to the nasty stuff."

Sael settled into the copilot's seat, cupping the mug in both hands. "It doesn't grow on Astrin, and we couldn't afford it anyway." She took a sip, closing her eyes briefly as she savored it. "I learned to like it working logistics on a station in Orenai."

"Orenai?" Mosby glanced at her. "That's Solarian."

Sael lowered the mug to her lap, still holding it. A faint crease formed between her brows. "I'm the fourth daughter of a minor house. There wasn't much prospect for me, so I took a government post. They assigned me to Orenai as a logistics liaison."

"So you were a Lady stacking boxes," Mosby observed, continuing down the checklist.

"Yes," she said, straightening in her seat, chin lifting a fraction. "But it got me to where I am now — and where I will be soon."

Mosby paused at that, one hand resting lightly on the console. Then, as if nothing of weight had just been spoken, he said, “Well, do you mind checking the cargo before we go to FTL?”

Sael studied him for a moment, then her expression softened. “Certainly.” She set the mug into its holder, unstrapped, and moved aft.

Mosby watched her go, gave a small shake of his head, and turned back to the instruments.

“All good?” he asked when she returned.

“Everything secure,” she said, settling into her seat. “But the ship’s going to smell like fish soon.”

He sighed. “Can’t be helped. Not much else comes off Brightwater until the harvest comes in. I’ll get new filters at Aureline Transit, but it’ll linger for a month.” He tapped the final confirmation. “All right — let’s go to FTL.”

Sael tightened her straps.

“Don’t overdo it,” Mosby said. “This won’t be like leaving atmo. This’ll be... different. Smooth, but different.”

She looked relieved. “I’ve been through jumps before, but always in liners or cargo haulers. I’m a rated pilot, you know. Those ships flew almost entirely by instruments.” She gestured toward the forward ports. “You couldn’t see a thing outside.”

Mosby leaned back slightly. “Okay... here we go.”

The FTL drive began to spool up, and the ship filled with a low, steady hum.

The world outside changed.

FTL wasn’t a flash or a streak of stars. Instead, space ahead softened, like heat haze over a desert road. A faint shimmer gathered before the bow, then spread, blooming outward until it swallowed the view and even the Farther Star seemed dim beside it.

Outside, the universe stretched.

Stars did not streak — they bent, smeared into impossible geometries, long curved distortions like light seen through rippling water. Shapes lingered at the edge of perception: threads, arcs, deep wells of shadow that seemed to slide past without ever quite moving.

Inside, a low harmonic vibration filled the ship — not loud, but present everywhere at once. Now and then came the subtle sensation of turning, though no thrusters fired and no course change showed on the board.

Sael exhaled slowly. “It looks different than I expected. It feels like we’re inside something.”

“We are,” Mosby replied. “Just don’t ask me to explain what.”

After that there was little to do once the navigation computer took over. Mosby stayed near the cockpit, dozing in short stretches, waking often to scan the instruments or when a subtle shift in the ship’s motion stirred him.

When the second watch cycle would normally begin, Sael appeared with food and two cups.

“You sleep like a man expecting problems,” she said, setting the tray down.

Mosby’s eyes opened partway. “I sleep like a man who’s had problems,” he said. “Another old habit from flying alone so long. There isn’t anyone else.” He pushed himself upright and began eating. “Pretty good,” he added.

“Thanks.” She checked the instruments. “It isn’t good for you. You should get proper sleep. I can handle things, and you won’t be any use worn out if something happens.”

“Alright,” Mosby said, standing and stretching. “Let’s see what you can do.”

Sael slid into the seat. He stood behind her, watching — smooth inputs, no overcorrection, her eyes traveling steadily across the board.

“What do you think?” he asked.

“Transit’s faster than a hauler, but nothing I can’t handle. Not much to do, really.”

“Wake me if drift exceeds point-zero-three.”

“It won’t.”

“That wasn’t a suggestion,” he growled.

She waited until he’d gone. “I know,” she said softly, smiling.

The next day passed in the quiet rhythm of ship life. One of them always in or near the cockpit. Meals shared, watches rotated, systems checked and rechecked. As Sael had said, there wasn’t much to do.

On the third day, a chime sounded.

“FTL exit approach in twenty,” Sael said over the intercom.

“I’ll be there in a minute,” came Mosby’s reply.

He entered the cockpit, stretching. “How are things?”

“Everything within parameters,” she said, starting to rise.

Mosby put a hand on her shoulder. “You ever piloted an exit?”

“Once. It was a while back. Mostly automated.”

“Well this is a quiet system. No better time to do it manually.” He slid into the copilot’s seat.

Sael took a breath and began the transition. Slowly, space outside clarified. The stretched impressions of stars tightened back into points. A pale system primary bloomed ahead.

“Easy,” Mosby murmured. “Don’t rush the transition.”

“I’m not. Sensors show no obstructions at exit point.”

The field peeled away like water shedding from a hull. Normal space settled around them with a subtle shudder.

Sael let out a breath.

“Welcome back to the slow universe,” Mosby said.

Traffic lanes resolved. Civilian transponders pinged lazily — haulers, couriers, a bulk transport crawling in-system.

Routine. Orderly.

Mosby keyed the comm. “Aureline Traffic, independent trader Farther Star inbound from outer vector. Request approach corridor and docking assignment.”

“Farther Star, wait one at the outer marker.”

“Mosby,” Sael said, a note of concern in her voice, “transient return on the scope.”

“Where?” he said, leaning to get a better look.

She marked the vector, but it now showed empty space. “Sensor echo from the transition?” she asked, not sounding certain.

Mosby didn’t answer.

A second later the contact returned — closer this time, still outside visual range, profile too thin for a freighter, too steady for debris.

And matching their vector.

Mosby's jaw tightened. "That's not traffic."

The contact shifted again, sliding just far enough off their sensor edge to make a clean lock impossible.

Sael's voice stayed level, but her hands were very still on the controls. "It's pacing us."

"Yeah," Mosby said quietly. "It is."

He checked the sensors and the comm. No registry string. No trade ID. Just a clean, blank return where data ought to have been.

He stiffened.

Sael noticed the change in his posture. "Problem?"

"Maybe nothing," he said. "Got a ghost out there."

He magnified the contact. The return was thin, almost too neat — not quite a hull so much as **a void cut from space where a hull ought to be.**

"Military?" she asked.

"Not broadcasting like one," Mosby said. "Not broadcasting like anything."

He keyed a polite, low-power ping on standard trader frequencies. "Unidentified traffic, this is independent trader Farther Star inbound from Brightwater. You showing passive only, or you got something to say?"

No response.

The contact held its course for several minutes more, then made a shallow burn adjustment. Not toward them. Not away. Just... sideways, as if stepping out of a line only it could see.

A minute later it disappeared from the scanner display, gone as cleanly as it had appeared.

Sael kept her eyes on the screen even after the marker vanished. "Could be a survey craft," she said. "Or a courier running dark."

"Could be," Mosby agreed.

He didn't add what he was thinking. Survey craft filed notices. Couriers running dark did not drift that close to a known trade lane without at least a token hello.

“What do you think?” Sael asked, more quietly now.

“Don’t know,” Mosby said. “I’m just a pilot. This is more your world than mine.”

She watched him for a moment, calculating, lips pressed tight, then looked back at the scanner. “It’s probably nothing to worry about.”

Mosby still didn’t answer.

Then the comm came to life. “Farther Star, Aureline Control. You’re cleared Dock Ring C, Berth Twelve. Vector two-seven-eight mark zero-zero-three. Watch your drift — we’ve got a tanker cycling thrusters on the inner lane.”

“Copy that,” Mosby said, switching seats with Sael.

He made the course corrections smoothly and guided the Star through the traffic lanes. Small adjustments brought them into alignment with the berth. A soft shudder ran through the hull as the docking clamps took hold. Mosby powered down the engines and let the station’s handling system ease the Star the rest of the way in.

Sael watched as he completed the docking sequence. “You make that look easy.”

“It is,” he said. “Right up until it isn’t.”

The smell reached the dockworkers before the ramp had finished lowering.

One of them wrinkled his nose, then grinned. “Brightwater catch again?”

“Fresh this time,” Mosby called down.

The air in the cargo bay was still cool from transit, but the sharp brine of packed fish cut through insulation and cold metal alike. The workers came aboard with practiced efficiency, boots ringing on the deck plates as they rolled in pallet jacks and shoulder braces. Crates of insulated seafood went first, their lids beaded with condensation. Then came the smaller bins — leafy island greens wrapped in damp cloth, knobby root vegetables still carrying a trace of red soil in their creases.

Payment transferred in small, practical numbers. No ceremony. No bargaining theater. Just figures reviewed on a handheld slate, a nod, and a confirmation tap. Not enough to make anyone rich, but enough to keep routes alive and names remembered.

Sael handled the manifests without being asked. She stood just off the main flow of traffic, slate in hand, cross-checking weights against declared loads and verifying signatures with quick, precise motions. Her expression stayed neutral, but she worked with the quiet intensity of someone who did not like leaving loose ends behind.

Across the bay, Mosby leaned against a bulkhead, speaking with the dock receiver while two workers pried open the lid of a seafood crate.

A breath of cold brine rolled out as the seal cracked.

The receiver prodded one of the inner packs with a gloved finger, then frowned. "Ice is softer than it should be."

"It always is by the time it gets here," Mosby said. "Your loading bay sat open half the transfer window."

The man pressed a thumb against a gel pack, watching it deform. "Might have to mark this as partial temperature compromise."

"Might," Mosby agreed. "If you want the paperwork headache. Or you can call it within tolerance and move it while it's still good."

The receiver glanced at him sideways. He knew the dance as well as Mosby did. Mark it spoiled and the forms multiplied. Mark it usable and everyone kept their day simple.

"How far over do you think you are?" the man asked.

"Less than two percent," Mosby said. "Same as every other time your dock runs behind schedule."

A pause.

The receiver grunted. "Call it acceptable loss."

"Thought you might."

By the time the last Brightwater crate rolled down the ramp, the cargo bay was already filling again. Machine parts in reinforced cases. Medical supplies with tamper seals and temperature tags blinking steady green. A row of sealed containers marked for Karamar and further along the line, their destination codes stenciled in faded blue.

Routine. Ordinary. Safe.

Which made Mosby more uneasy than he liked.

He stood at the top of the ramp a moment longer than necessary, watching the dock beyond the workers' backs. Cranes moved. Cargo floated between guide beams. Station traffic drifted in its slow, deliberate patterns.

Nothing there.

He rubbed the scar over his eye with his thumb. The shadow contact lingered in his mind, wrong in a way he couldn't name.

He had seen **a shape** once, out in open space — black against black, a hull line that didn't reflect starlight the way it should have. Just a presence where no presence ought to be, sliding across his sensors and then gone.

Nothing he could point to. Nothing he could prove.

And that was what he didn't like.

Behind him, paperwork finished cycling through the dock net, confirmations chiming softly from the cargo office console. Sael stepped up beside him.

"Want to get something to eat that isn't ship rations?" Mosby asked.

"Know any place that's good?"

"Maybe. I want to check for messages on the way."

Inside the station, gravity felt wrong after three days under steady thrust.

The deck didn't move, didn't hum with the faint, reassuring vibration of engines working. It just sat there, solid and indifferent. Mosby's stride shortened without his permission, knees flexing a little more than needed as if the floor might shift. He didn't bother trying to hide it.

Sael adjusted within a dozen steps. Her balance settled, shoulders squaring as though she had changed environments by choice rather than necessity.

They stopped first at the relay office, a narrow room tucked between a supply depot and a fuel broker. The air smelled faintly of hot circuitry and old paper.

The clerk behind the counter barely looked up. "Name?"

"Mosby. Trader."

She tapped a key, reached into a tray without turning her head, and slid a thin stack of printed slips across the counter. "Three inbound. Two pending transmission confirmation."

Mosby picked them up and stepped aside. The slips were thin, cheap paper — something about physical copies still made people feel better when signals went bad.

Short notes. Route confirmations. A polite complaint about a pickup delay he would have to smooth over later.

If later came, he reminded himself.

Nothing else.

Sael watched him read, her hands folded loosely behind her back. “You were expecting something?”

“Not really,” he said, folding the slips once and tucking them into his jacket. “Just checking who’s still talking.”

They ate in a dockside restaurant that specialized in food meant to remind travelers of somewhere else.

The lighting was warm and low, the walls decorated with faded prints of coastlines and farms from half a dozen worlds. The air carried a blend of spices that didn’t quite belong together but tried very hard to pretend they did.

Sael tried a local stew and decided, after two careful bites, that it was attempting three cuisines at once and succeeding at none of them. She ate it anyway, methodically, as though it were a task that required completion.

Mosby stuck with bread, roasted meat, and something that claimed to be beer. He drank it without comment, which was comment enough.

They sat near a wide panoramic viewport overlooking one of the outer docking arms. Traffic drifted past in slow, deliberate motion: tugs nudging cargo modules, a shuttle rotating on thrusters before easing toward a berth, running lights sliding across the glass like distant stars that had forgotten how to stay still.

Mosby’s gaze kept straying back to the port.

Not staring. Just... checking.

Sael noticed on the third time. “You’re expecting someone to wave?”

“Wouldn’t mind a friendly face,” he said.

His eyes shifted again, tracking a vessel easing out from behind a lattice of gantries. For a moment all he saw was reflected glare — then a dark hull line, angular, unadorned, slipping sideways under maneuvering jets.

It might have been the same ship.

Might not.

By the time he leaned forward slightly, trying to catch a registry mark, a fuel tender drifted between it and the viewport. When the view cleared, the ship was already turning away, vanishing behind the curve of the station’s outer ring.

He sat back.

Sael set her spoon down quietly. “Problem?”

“Next stop is Karamar,” he said, as if she had asked something else. “Then New Horizon. Traffic will be heavier there. Good place to disappear in a crowd.”

“Is that possible in the Star, the way she’s painted?” she asked lightly.

He gave her a sour look over the rim of his mug.

She held his gaze a moment longer, the faintest hint of a smile at the corner of her mouth. “You think we’re being followed.”

“I think something took an interest,” he said. “That’s not the same thing. Yet.”

She didn’t push further. But when she lifted her spoon again, she didn’t taste the stew. She was looking past her reflection in the viewport, into the slow dance of ships beyond the glass.

Good. We'll tune it — not rewrite it.

Per your editing protocol:

- Preserve intent and structure
- Maintain mid-century restraint
- Trim redundancy
- Avoid screenplay drift
- Keep paragraph architecture clean
- Light compression only

Below is the **revised full chapter** with:

- Evac sequence slightly tightened
- One corridor repetition removed
- “Spooks” line adjusted to be less contemporary
- Minor cadence smoothing

No emotional inflation added.

Chapter — Gate Transit

Departure from Aureline was clean. Gate traffic was steady but tightly controlled, ships spaced at precise intervals, each holding its assigned vector like freight cars in an invisible train.

Sael leaned forward slightly as the gate complex grew in the forward ports.

It was not a simple structure.

Two immense rectangular loops hung in space, joined at the middle by a thick structural spine. Trusses, emitter rails, and armored conduits laced the framework, giving the whole construct the look of industrial machinery built on a scale that dwarfed warships. One loop handled departures, the other arrivals, their fields kept separate by dense hardware at the narrow waist between them.

Faint distortions shimmered along sections of the framework, like heat haze over metal, where containment fields pressed against the vacuum. Thin bands of polarized light slid along emitter tracks as the system constantly recalibrated.

Ships ahead approached the outbound lobe one at a time. Each reached an invisible boundary, wavered in a soft gravitational shimmer—

—and vanished.

“First time through a major gate from the front seat?” Mosby asked, eyes on the approach display.

“I’ve used them,” Sael said. “Never from up here.”

“Then don’t blink.”

The flight computer chimed as it accepted the gate’s approach envelope. Thrusters whispered in short, precise bursts, trimming their vector by fractions too small for human hands to manage cleanly.

A calm voice came over the comm.

“Outbound vessel Farther Star, confirm mass profile one-one-eight thousand metric and lane assignment Delta-Seven.”

Mosby thumbed the transmit. “Farther Star confirms. Delta-Seven.”

“Lane lock verified. Maintain envelope. You are cleared to threshold on mark.”

The console tone shifted — subtle, but final. Lane confirmation pulsed green. The ship was no longer navigating toward the gate. It was being guided into alignment with it.

“Crossing threshold,” Mosby said quietly.

The forward view did not flare or flash.

Instead, the stars thinned, smeared—

—and were gone.

For an instant there was a hollow sensation, not in her body but in her sense of distance, as if the universe had quietly stepped back.

Then the tunnel resolved around them.

They were inside a corridor of structured spacetime. Layered geometries flowed past in vast, slow patterns — planes of shifting color, lattices folding through one another, curves that seemed to rotate without turning. Nothing repeated. Nothing held still long enough to be named.

Sael’s fingers tightened on the armrests before she noticed. “I thought it would be... more dramatic.”

“Be glad it isn’t,” Mosby said. “Dramatic means something’s wrong.”

Gate transit felt nothing like direct FTL. There was no engine push, no sense of acceleration. Instead, it was as if the ship had been caught in a current far larger than itself, carried along a channel carved through the fabric of space. The controls showed no meaningful authority. They were passengers now.

Ahead, faint and distant, another ship rode the same lane. Its navigation lights held at a constant separation, neither growing nor shrinking.

To their right, something flared.

A streak of blue-white light tore past in a neighboring transit stream, Doppler-shifted into a hard ultraviolet glare that left a brief afterimage on Sael's vision before it vanished into the flowing geometry.

She blinked. "What was that?"

"Another lane," Mosby said. "Different mass class, different transit rate. Gates run a lot of streams side by side. We only ever see the edges."

The Star hummed steadily, but the sound came from its own systems rather than propulsion. Field stabilizers murmured. Air fans whispered. Inside the hull, everything was ordinary.

Outside, reality had been turned into infrastructure.

"This time," Mosby added, "there's even less to do than in FTL."

The navigation computer did not steer. It merely confirmed they remained centered in their assigned flow. Deviation wasn't permitted; maneuver wasn't possible.

Transit time to the far gate: fifteen days.

Long enough for routine to settle in. Life-support filters would need changing. Mosby ran diagnostics on the secondary heat exchangers. Minor maintenance, small tasks to mark the passing days.

On the fourteenth day of transit, they sat together in the cockpit, watching the slow drift of structured light beyond the forward ports. It was like staring into a river made of mathematics.

Sael let the quiet stretch before she spoke.

"What is it between you and Korrin?" she asked. "Why do you hate each other so much?"

Mosby didn't answer right away. His eyes stayed on the instruments, though the ship required nothing from him now.

“I started out as just another assault pilot for the Marines,” he said at last. “We were on one of those planets I can’t even remember the name of anymore, flying evac. One of our battalions got cut off in a mountain valley. The Wards had the area thick with anti-air, and our people were getting picked off trying to move the wounded.”

Sael’s brow furrowed slightly. “Wards?”

Mosby didn’t look at her. “What we called them. We were Marines, Soldiers, Sailors. They called their troops Stewards.”

A small pause.

“It irritated them when we shortened it.”

The shifting light from the corridor slid across the canopy and over his face, flattening the lines there.

“I went in low and as fast as I could push the shuttle,” he went on. “Took fire on the way down, but I got the first load out. Shuttle came down hard on the second run. I swapped birds and kept going.”

He shifted slightly in his seat.

“I made three more runs. Lost two more shuttles. Took shrapnel on the last one and didn’t know it until we were clear.”

“Sounds bad,” she said.

Mosby gave a small nod. “We did what we had to. Most didn’t make it out.”

The corridor flowed on outside, indifferent.

“When I got out of the hospital, I’d been transferred. Korrin was CO of a special operations unit. Wanted me specifically because I’d been reckless enough—and good enough—for the kind of missions he was handing out.”

His mouth twitched, not quite a smile.

“I didn’t like being pulled off evac for covert ops that seemed pointless at the time. Though I did get to fly the Star.”

Sael turned toward him. “You flew this ship in the war?”

“Sure did. She was something then.” A faint smile touched his mouth, but it didn’t last. “Toward the end, the war was winding down. There was a team behind the contact line. Good people. I’d gotten them in and out of bad places more than once.”

He looked down at his hands for a moment.

“Korrin got orders to pull out. Evac the planet. The team didn’t make the list. Acceptable losses.”

Sael didn’t interrupt.

“I couldn’t do it,” Mosby said quietly. “I walked into the command post, argued with him, and when that didn’t work...” He gave a small shrug. “I decked him.”

Her eyebrows rose despite herself.

“Took the Star and went back for them. By the time I got there, Korrin had already withdrawn the unit. We were left on the planet—me, the team, and a ship that wasn’t supposed to be there anymore.”

The light beyond the canopy shifted again, slow and distant.

“I got us into orbit, found a jump point, and got us out. Me, the Star, and the team.”

“Then what?” she asked.

“The war was over by the time we reached a friendly base,” Mosby said. “They were mustering everyone out as fast as they could. The depot I processed through was also a collection point. They were selling or scrapping shuttles just as fast.”

He glanced toward the bulkhead.

“I got my mustering-out pay and saw her sitting in line for the torch. Couldn’t let that happen after all she got me through. I talked to the sergeant in charge, convinced him to mark her as surplus, and before anyone thought too hard about it... I was off-planet and gone.”

A faint, crooked smile tugged at his mouth.

“Found out later one of the guys on that team had a father in the Council. Didn’t care much for his son being written off as acceptable losses. That more or less ended Korrin’s chances at promotion in the regular service.”

He gave a small shrug.

“He found a different path after that.”

Mosby fell silent. The only sound in the cockpit was the low murmur of life-support fans and the distant whisper of field stabilizers. Sael watched him, studying the set of his shoulders, the way his gaze stayed fixed somewhere beyond the flowing light outside. None of that had been in the briefings.

“Well,” Mosby said at last, as if pushing the memory back where it belonged, “I need something to drink. You want anything?”

“No, thank you,” Sael replied.

He unstrapped and left the cockpit without another word.

It was his watch, she noticed. He never left the controls during his watch.

Sael settled back into the seat, hands resting lightly on the armrests.

The man she had been assigned was not just a surplus pilot with a stubborn streak. He was someone who disobeyed orders when lives were on the line. Someone who struck a commanding officer and flew into a warzone alone.

That kind of person was not predictable.

That kind of person was not controllable.

She found, to her surprise, that this did not make her feel safer — or entirely uneasy.

You're right — that's the right instinct. The anomaly belongs **after** the maneuver, not instead of it. It should feel procedural. Official. Almost boring.

Your addition is strong. I'll refine it slightly for cadence, tighten a few phrases, and sharpen the "Ascendant interference" undertone without overstating it.

Here is the full scene, integrated cleanly and flowing:

The next day, late in the afternoon, Sael was in the cargo bay checking the restraints on the pallets of containers when Mosby's voice came over the intercom.

"We're coming up on the exit. Everything good down there?"

"Everything's good and tight," she replied, giving one of the ratchet strap handles a final tug.

"Alright. You'll want to get up here."

Sael wiped her hands on a rag and headed for the gantry. She climbed to the second deck, boots ringing lightly on the metal steps, then moved through the corridor toward the cockpit. The ship hummed around her, the deep, steady vibration of gate transit threaded with a faint harmonic whine from the field systems.

She slid into the co-pilot's seat. "Problems?"

"No problems, yet," Mosby said with a sideways grin. "I'm guessing since you've never piloted entry into a gate, you've never piloted out."

"No..." she admitted, fastening her harness a notch tighter.

"You're in for a ride then."

"What do you mean?"

Mosby gestured toward the forward displays.

The gate corridor stretched ahead of them, a long, structured channel of shifting light. In their lane, a massive cargo hauler loomed in the distance, its running lights steady, hull broad and blocky. Even at this scale it looked less like a ship and more like a moving section of infrastructure.

"Gates are built for the big boys — bulk cruisers, capital ships," Mosby said. "They've got priority on the way out. That much mass doesn't slow down quick. You don't want to be in front of one when the corridor lets go."

Sael watched the hauler's implacable presence on the traffic overlay. "So we just... stay where we are?"

"No," Mosby said. "Gate Control hands us a vector the moment we're released. When they do, we move. Out here, you don't pick your path — you're assigned a hole and you clear it fast."

A soft chime sounded from the comm panel.

"Trader Farther Star, Gate Control. Your exit vector is zero six eight mark two eight four. Execute on threshold."

Mosby keyed the mic. "Control, Farther Star. Zero six eight mark two eight four, on threshold."

He glanced at Sael. "That's us. Right and down."

He brought the maneuvering systems fully online. The engines deepened to a waiting hum, power building through the frame without yet pushing the ship. Sael felt it through the seat — restrained strength held in check.

"We don't move early," Mosby said. "Inside the corridor, you stay in your lane. Outside... you get out of the way."

A small countdown appeared on the edge of the display, synced to the gate's internal timing.

3

The tunnel ahead brightened, geometry tightening toward the exit aperture.

2

Mosby's hands rested lightly on the controls. Sael saw the stillness in him — not relaxation, but focus drawn tight.

1

"Hold on."

The instant the Star crossed the threshold, the ship shuddered as the receiving gate's capture fields bit and released. Mosby rolled the Star smoothly onto her side, bringing the assigned vector into the canopy where he could see it, then drove the thrust in.

The corridor vanished in a flare of distorted light, replaced by the hard black of real space and the pale blaze of the system's primary.

Stars swung across the forward ports as the ship carved into its exit path. The maneuver wasn't violent, but it was firm — a clean, practiced military break away from the emergence line. The inertial compensators lagged just enough for Sael to feel the motion in her gut.

"Fucking black—" she snapped, hands clamping onto the armrests.

Mosby's mouth twitched, but his eyes never left the traffic board or the real space beyond the glass.

Traffic blossomed across the system display — established lanes, steady velocities, masses already committed to their paths. For a few seconds the projections overlapped in a tangled web of possible futures.

Then the lines separated.

They were in their slot.

Mosby eased the thrust back, rolling the ship upright again as they settled into the outbound traffic stream. The engines dropped to a steady cruise vibration.

"Didn't think a lady knew words like that," Mosby said mildly.

Sael shot him a look. "Logistics bays and cargo ships are poor places for refinement," she said. "You adapt."

Mosby nodded, a faint grin touching the corner of his mouth as his eyes stayed on the board. "Fair enough."

The comm panel chirped again.

"Farther Star," Gate Control said, voice calm and professional. "Confirm you have no escort vessel within your exit envelope."

Mosby's eyes flicked briefly toward Sael.

"Negative escort," he replied.

A pause followed.

Not static. Not confusion. A recalculation.

"Copy," Control said at last. "We're reading transient telemetry overlap during release. Likely sensor bleed between adjacent mass streams. You are clear."

The channel closed.

Sael frowned slightly. “Sensor bleed?”

Mosby didn’t answer immediately. He was already pulling up the departure log.

For a fraction of a second, their mass profile showed dual resolution — two overlapping envelopes occupying the same release vector.

Then it collapsed back to one.

0.31 seconds.

Dual-profile flag.

Unresolved origin.

He closed the log.

“That shouldn’t happen?” Sael asked.

“Not on a clean exit,” Mosby said.

His tone was neutral. Casual.

But his hand remained resting lightly on the console a moment longer than it needed to.

Outside, traffic continued in orderly lanes. Drive plumes flared and faded. Transponders chimed and sorted themselves into neat lines.

Everything official said the system was normal.

The Star continued outward on her assigned vector.

Behind them, the gate shimmered once as another vessel crossed threshold and vanished into the corridor.

Mosby did not look back.

But he did not entirely relax, either.

Docking at Kalamar went much like Aureline had.

Cargo came off. Cargo went on. Money changed hands in quiet, practical amounts that kept routes alive without drawing attention to them.

Mosby let Sael handle the manifests and the loading cycle while he disappeared into the station's supply decks in search of provisioning and maintenance parts. By the time they cast off again, the Star smelled marginally less like fish and marginally more like machinery — warm metal, lubricant, and the faint bite of solvent.

Another gate transit later, they entered the New Horizon system.

New Horizon Station announced itself first as noise — overlapping transponders, docking requests stepping on one another, yard-control chatter, and the constant murmur of ships maneuvering in crowded space. The traffic overlay thickened until it looked less like a map and more like weather.

The station itself sprawled across the inner system like something that had grown rather than been built: rings added onto older trusses, habitat drums bolted to cargo spines, fuel tanks clustered like barnacles along the shadows of larger structures. Running lights winked along its length, and drive plumes flickered in every direction as tugs hauled freight from berth to berth.

Mosby studied the approach vector, one hand resting lightly on the console as the computer trimmed their path through the traffic web. His eyes moved between the overlay and the forward ports, not searching so much as checking — a slow sweep of hull shapes, drive signatures, **pausing half a second longer on anything that held steady when it should have drifted.**

“Home of honest traders, quiet deals, and people who don't ask more than they need to,” he said.

Sael glanced at the shifting traffic display. “This is where we meet your... old contact.”

Mosby's mouth twitched. “Yeah. It is.”

For two days they had been on the station. The first day, Mosby moved the way he always did when he was looking for someone who didn't want to be found — slowly, without asking questions that echoed. He drifted through the merchants' tiers, the cafés tucked into maintenance spines, the bars that didn't advertise themselves except by the fact that the lighting never quite worked. He listened more than he spoke, bought drinks he didn't finish, and paid attention to who noticed him and who pretended not to. **He changed levels twice without using the main lifts. He doubled back once for no reason at all.**

Sael spent long stretches aboard the Star, the comm console casting a pale glow over the small alcove as she worked through public traffic records and freight filings. Most of it was routine. That was the point. She let the numbers and routes pass under her eyes, marking the few that didn't quite settle where they should. Later she walked the station's brighter corridors on

practical errands — supplies, laundry, the small tasks that kept life aboard from turning stale. Voices carried differently in the market rings. Money moved with more confidence. She noticed things without trying to: the way certain brokers stood just a little apart from their own counters, the quiet hand signals between tug crews across crowded bays, the way some ships cleared berth faster than paperwork alone should allow. None of it seemed urgent. It just... added up. **Patterns rarely announced themselves. They accumulated.**

The second morning she dressed more carefully than the station required. The fabric was travel-worn but formal in cut, the lines clean, the colors subdued in a way that translated well across species and politics. She pinned her hair back, checked the seal on her ident band, and made her way toward the Thalean Consulate tucked into a quieter ring of the habitat where the lighting held steady and the walls were free of ad panels and improvised signage. Inside, voices stayed low and movements unhurried. The meeting was brief and polite. She reported their progress in careful generalities — locations reached, routes taken, nothing that would bind the future too tightly to the present. In return she received the same measured guidance she had come to expect: reminders of scope, of discretion, of who ultimately held responsibility if things went poorly. No one raised their voice. No one said anything that would have sounded out of place in a public corridor. **No one asked a question whose answer they did not already know.** When she stepped back into the station traffic, the noise felt louder than before.

By the second afternoon, Mosby had settled into a concourse near one of the station's newer attractions — a sprawling, aggressively colorful display advertising luxury excursions that no one in this part of the station was ever going to take. The sound loop was slightly out of sync with the visuals, just enough to be irritating, which kept people from lingering too long. He sat with his back to a support column, a cup of something bitter cooling in his hand, watching reflections slide across polished metal.

He felt the presence before he heard the voice.

"Friend Mosby," it said, close and calm. "We again meet."

Mosby didn't turn right away. He took another sip, set the cup aside, then glanced over his shoulder.

The Talari stood just inside his peripheral vision, positioned where foot traffic naturally split around him. Tall and narrow, with long, fine-boned limbs and a stillness that looked chosen rather than natural. Long ears fell along the sides of his head, tapering toward narrow tips near the line of his jaw. Behind them, a fall of thin, corded tendrils lay braided back, threaded with small beads and bits of worked metal that clicked softly when he moved. His skin bore faint ridges that caught the light like worn grain in old wood. His clothing was layered and practical — a weathered jacket reinforced at the shoulders and elbows, scarves and wraps crossing the chest, tools and small instruments hanging in quiet reach along straps and loops. Nothing decorative that didn't also serve a purpose. Subtle markings traced the exposed skin of his neck and hands — scars, perhaps, or ornament. Mosby had learned not to ask.

A pair of station workers altered course without looking at him, not avoidance — accommodation.

“You always say that like it’s a surprise,” Mosby said.

“It is,” the Talari replied pleasantly. “You survive most of your habits.”

Mosby snorted. “You’re easy to find when you want to be.”

“And difficult when I do not,” the Talari agreed. “Balance is important.”

He inclined his head slightly in greeting.

“So,” the Talari said. “What has made you careless enough to come looking?”

Mosby studied him for a moment, then gestured toward the empty seat beside him. “Got a job,” he said. “Complicated. Might get loud in ways I can’t fix from the cockpit.”

The Talari did not sit. He considered the chair, then Mosby, then the surrounding space. **His gaze flicked once toward the concourse’s upper balconies before returning.**

“You require engineering,” he said. “And discretion.”

“And reach,” Mosby added. “Places I can’t ask about without someone noticing.”

A faint change crossed the Talari’s expression — calculation arriving somewhere he did not entirely like. “And you thought of me,” he said.

“You were the first,” Mosby replied.

“That is either flattering,” the Talari said, “or concerning.”

“Probably both.”

His mouth — more membrane than lips — curved in something that might have been a smile. “Friend Mosby, you are very bad at small jobs.”

Mosby met his gaze. “This isn’t one.”

Silence stretched between them, filled by the low hum of the station and the distant murmur of people pretending not to listen.

Finally, the Talari nodded once. “Very well. I will need to know where we are going.”

Mosby exhaled slowly. “Get aboard,” he said. “I’ll explain what I can.”

The Talari turned, already moving with the flow of foot traffic.

“And Mosby?” he added without looking back.

“Yeah?”

“Please do not attempt my name this time.”

Mosby smiled despite himself. “No promises.”

The Talari paused just long enough for that to register. “Then I will attempt to forgive you,” he replied.

By the time they returned to the berth, Ted already knew which ship was his.

The Farther Star wore her usual riot of color and symbol over old military plating, but Ted slowed as he reached the ramp, head tilting slightly.

Something had been added.

Along the forward flank, just below the cockpit line, the stylized eye stared outward, paint still sharp where age and dust hadn’t touched it yet.

“This was not here before,” Ted said.

Mosby glanced up from where he was checking a cargo strap near the open bay. “Manny’s been busy.”

“Manny,” Ted repeated.

“Local artist,” Mosby said. “Self-appointed.”

Ted studied the new eye a moment longer, the mineral sheen of his gaze narrowing. “He adds protection,” he said quietly.

Mosby snorted. “He adds whatever he feels like.”

Ted didn’t look away. “That is also protection.”

A soft metallic thud echoed inside the cargo bay as someone set a crate down harder than necessary.

Ted’s attention shifted.

Sael stepped into view from deeper in the bay, sleeves rolled, a datapad in one hand. She had changed since Mosby had left for the station’s upper tiers — the tailored lines she’d worn to the

Thalean consulate replaced now with muted, practical travel gear. Only the cut of the fabric, and the way she carried herself, marked her as anything other than another spacer passing through.

She took in the Talari in a single, assessing glance.

“Ted,” Mosby said, jerking his thumb in introduction. “Best engineer I know who doesn’t ask for paperwork.”

Ted inclined his head. “Mosby has low standards for documentation.”

Sael met his gaze. “I am Sael.”

Ted’s eyes shifted to her, focus sharpening slightly. “Yes,” he said. “Sael Vareni ir’Elisand.”

The datapad in her hand went still.

A fractional pause — small enough that Mosby might have missed it, large enough that Ted did not.

“I see,” she said.

Mosby looked between them. “Do you know each other?”

Ted’s gaze remained on her. “I have never seen her,” he said. “Nor has she met me.”

Another beat.

“But you know who I am,” Sael said.

“Yes,” Ted replied simply.

Mosby frowned. “How?”

Ted shifted one shoulder in a small, almost apologetic motion. “Talari notice things,” he said. “We remember. We speak to one another. Information travels.”

Sael regarded him steadily. “That leaves a great deal to interpretation.”

Ted did not look away. “No,” he said. “It leaves what was.” A pause. “We do not infer. We perceive.”

Mosby folded his arms. “Well that sounds spooky as hell.”

Ted considered this. “It is often said.”

His eyes drifted briefly past them, toward the painted eye along the Star's hull outside the open ramp.

"Sometimes," he added quietly, "it is also how things survive."

The hum of the station drifted in through the ramp. Somewhere down the dock, a cargo hauler cycled its thrusters and the deck vibrated faintly underfoot.

Mosby clapped his hands once. "Well, that's reassuring."

He jerked his head toward the interior. "Come on, Ted. I'll show you the engine compartment. Try not to insult it too loudly."

"I know the way, Friend Mosby," Ted said. "I am well aware of your failings to maintain it to my standards."

Mosby snorted. "No one could, Ted."

Sael watched them go, expression unreadable.

"That," she said quietly, "is not just an engineer."

Mosby grinned faintly. "Nope. No one better to buy, borrow, or scrounge, though. We're going to need him."

He followed Ted inside.

Sael lingered at the ramp a moment longer, looking out at the painted hull and the layered symbols that meant nothing to her.

One of the new eyes seemed to be looking back.

Inside, Ted had already opened two access panels in engineering and was explaining, with patient disapproval, why Mosby's definition of "running fine" differed significantly from his own.

"These thermal regulators," Ted was saying, one long finger tracing a faint heat scar along a conduit, "are still within tolerance. They should not be."

Mosby leaned against a bulkhead with the long-suffering expression of a man who had heard this before. "They've got personality."

"They have damage," Ted replied.

Mosby shrugged. "Same thing."

Ted made a small sound that might have been a sigh in another species. “We will need spare regulators. And a better diagnostic array than the one you pretend is adequate.”

Mosby scratched the back of his neck. “I was hoping you’d say we’re perfect and can leave tomorrow.”

Ted’s eyes shifted toward him. “I have never once said that.”

“Worth a shot,” Mosby muttered.

Ted adjusted a panel setting, then added, “There are also several components I would prefer to replace before departure.”

Mosby raised an eyebrow. “How expensive is ‘prefer’?”

Ted considered. “Moderately.”

Mosby jerked a thumb toward the cargo bay. “Put it on the mission account.”

Sael, leaning in the doorway, folded her arms. “I don’t remember authorizing—”

Mosby pointed at her. “She gets the bill.”

Ted inclined his head. “In that case, the list will be extensive.”

Sael sighed.

Mosby looked pleased. “See? Everybody wins.”

An hour later, Mosby was halfway into an access panel he'd been meaning to check for weeks when—

The knock on the hull was sharp and impatient.

He looked up. "Yeah, yeah," he muttered, wiping his hands on a rag as he headed down the cargo ramp. "Hold on."

By the time the ramp lowered the rest of the way, a skinny kid was already standing at the bottom, bouncing on the balls of his feet like the station gravity couldn't quite hold him down. His jacket had been patched so many times it had become its own design. A faded relay satchel hung crosswise over his chest.

"Delivery for the Farther Star," the kid said, chin up, voice already defensive.

Mosby looked him over. Quick eyes. Quick hands. Not scared — just measuring.

"Relay office start hiring children now?" Mosby asked.

"Cheaper than bots," the kid shot back. "You Mosby or not?"

"Depends who's asking."

The kid held up a slim pad. "Sign and I stop caring."

Mosby snorted and pressed his thumb to the pad. As he handed it back, he flicked a few extra credits onto the screen.

The kid's eyes widened for half a second before he covered it with a shrug. "Didn't see nothing," he said.

"Smart," Mosby replied. "Stay that way."

The kid jogged off.

Mosby climbed back up the ramp, flipping through the printed relay slips as he walked.

"Route coverage confirmed... parts shipment delayed... Jacobson complaining about berth fees again..." He shook his head.

Ted stepped closer. "May I see those?"

Mosby handed them over. "Anything interesting?"

Ted held two slips side by side.

“There’s two of that one,” Mosby said. “Relay office glitch.”

Ted did not answer.

Sael stepped closer. “Duplicate transmission?”

“They look identical,” Mosby said.

“They are not,” Ted replied.

He pointed to a single altered character.

Sael frowned. “It’s a transmission artifact.”

“No,” Ted said gently. “This one was altered.”

Mosby rubbed his chin. “Meaning what? Somebody snooping?”

Ted examined the text carefully.

“This is the sort of error made when something handles symbols without understanding them.”

Mosby blinked. “You’re telling me somebody read my mail and fat-fingered the alphabet?”

“In essence,” Ted said.

Sael crossed her arms. “Customs AIs scrub traffic all the time.”

“Yes,” Ted agreed. “But their systems make consistent substitutions. This is not consistent.”

Mosby took the slips back slowly. “So what does that mean?”

Ted’s eyes shifted slightly.

“It means this message passed through something that does not think in this script... but wanted to see it anyway.”

Silence pooled in the bay.

Mosby folded the slips and slid them into his jacket.

“Great,” he muttered. “Someone is taking an interest in us.”

Ted did not disagree.

Mosby looked pleased. “See? Everybody wins.”

CHAPTER START: New Horizon Departure

An hour later he was halfway into an access panel he'd been meaning to check for weeks when the knock came against the hull — sharp, metallic, and impatient.

He looked up. “Yeah, yeah,” he muttered, wiping his hands on a rag as he headed down toward the cargo ramp. “Hold on.”

By the time the ramp lowered the rest of the way, a skinny kid was already standing at the bottom, bouncing on the balls of his feet like the station gravity couldn't quite hold him down. His jacket had been patched so many times it had become its own design. A faded relay satchel hung crosswise over his chest.

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“Depends who's asking.”

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Mosby snorted and pressed his thumb to the pad. As he handed it back, he flicked a few extra credits onto the screen.

The kid's eyes widened for half a second before he covered it with a shrug. “Didn't see nothing,” he said.

“Smart,” Mosby replied. “Stay that way.”

The kid jogged off into the dock traffic.

Mosby climbed back up the ramp, flipping through the printed relay slips as he walked. “Route coverage confirmed... parts shipment delayed... Jacobson complaining about berth fees again...” He shook his head.

Sael stood near the cargo table, datapad open, reconciling outgoing load weights against the new parts Ted had stacked in neat, disapproving rows. She glanced up as Mosby came in.

Ted stepped up behind Mosby without a sound. “May I see those?”

Mosby handed them over. “Anything interesting?”

Ted held two slips side by side.

“There’s two of that one,” Mosby said. “Relay office glitch.”

Ted did not answer.

Sael stepped closer, wiping her hands on a cloth. “Duplicate transmission?”

“They look identical,” Mosby said.

“They are not,” Ted replied.

He pointed to a single altered character buried in the text.

Sael frowned. “That’s a transmission artifact.”

“No,” Ted said gently. “This one was altered.”

Mosby rubbed his chin. “Meaning what? Somebody snooping?”

Ted examined the text carefully, eyes flicking back and forth in tiny, precise movements. “This is the sort of error made when something handles symbols without understanding them.”

Mosby blinked. “You’re telling me somebody read my mail and **fat-fingered** the alphabet?”

“In essence,” Ted said.

Sael crossed her arms. “Customs AIs scrub traffic all the time.”

“Yes,” Ted agreed. “But their systems make consistent substitutions. This is not consistent.”

Mosby took the slips back slowly. “So what does that mean?”

Ted’s gaze shifted, unfocused for a moment as he considered. “It means this message passed through something that does not think in this script... but wanted to see it anyway.”

Silence pooled in the bay, thick and sudden.

Mosby looked at the slips again, then shoved them into a pocket. “All right,” he said. “That’s twice now.”

Sael’s eyes narrowed. “Twice?”

“Ship I spotted near Aureline,” Mosby said. “Didn’t track right on sensors. I told myself it was a glitch and moved on. Probably shouldn’t have.”

Ted's attention sharpened. "You did not mention this."

"Didn't have anything solid," Mosby said. "Still don't. But now somebody's skimming our traffic, and not very well."

He looked between them. "I don't like patterns I can't make sense of. So we're about to make a move that doesn't."

Sael was very still. "What are you proposing?"

Mosby turned to Ted. "Can the Star make a direct jump to Sol?"

Sael blinked. "Sol? That's not on the route."

"Yeah," Mosby said. "That's the point."

Ted did not answer immediately. His eyes shifted faintly as he ran the numbers. "There are complications."

Sael waited. "Define 'complications.'"

"The drive field was tuned for staged transits and gate alignments," Ted said. "A single independent jump of that length through that region will increase containment drift and thermal load. Field fluctuations and radiation density will be significant. Regulator wear will accelerate. We will be operating closer to tolerance than I prefer."

"Distance?" Mosby asked.

"Ten-point-five light-years," Ted replied. "Within operational limits for this hull. Smaller mass helps. The Star is... resilient." A pause. "But navigation will not be trivial. Sol space is not quiet. Radiation gradients, debris, and gravity fluctuations complicate long-range solutions."

Mosby shrugged. "We'll worry about that in transit."

Ted's gaze held on him a fraction longer. "Transit may worry about you first."

"Story of my life."

Sael looked between them. "You're talking about bypassing the gate network entirely."

"Yep," Mosby said. "If somebody's watching traffic patterns, they're watching gates. We drop off the map for a while. See who notices."

She considered that, expression tightening slightly. "And if whoever altered that message can still follow you off-grid?"

Mosby met her eyes. “Then we learn something useful.”

Ted spoke quietly. “You are choosing uncertainty over structure.”

“I’m choosing to move where they aren’t expecting,” Mosby said.

Ted inclined his head once. “Then I will need different spares. And more time than you will want to give me.”

Mosby didn’t hesitate. “Take what you need. Be quick.”

“That will be expensive,” Ted said.

“Put it on the mission account,” Mosby replied.

Sael closed her eyes briefly, then opened them. “I will want that list.”

“You will not enjoy it,” Ted said.

“I am finding that out,” she answered.

Ted moved toward engineering at once, already reprioritizing systems in his head.

Mosby pushed off the bulkhead and headed for the cockpit. “I’m **filing** flight plan for a gate hop first. Something dull and predictable. Then we go somewhere inconvenient.”

Sael lingered a moment longer, looking toward the cargo ramp where the station traffic lights blinked in orderly patterns against the dark. A system built on schedules. Registries. Predictable movement.

Mosby was about to step outside all of it.

She exhaled once, then followed him forward.

The Farther Star did not look like a ship preparing for a quiet departure.

Panels stood open along the cargo deck. Cables trailed like exposed nerves. Parts lay arranged in careful clusters that suggested urgency more than order. Somewhere below, a cargo lift whined against worn bearings.

Ted had already commandeered half a crate of components that hadn’t technically been purchased yet. Mosby was sorting through them with growing dissatisfaction. He had hoped Ted would find better, but with the time they had, this was what the station could offer.

Ted came up the ramp guiding a borrowed cargo lift stacked with more salvaged hardware.

“This is what was available,” he said, holding up a coil of gravitic mesh that had clearly survived more than one previous life. “It is not what was required.”

“It’ll do,” Mosby said, not looking up from the console where he was transmitting flight plans. “We’re not rebuilding her. Just keeping her breathing.”

Ted made a low sound that suggested breathing was an optimistic goal.

Sael stood near the forward ramp, datapad in hand, but she hadn’t looked at the screen in several minutes. Station lights shimmered across its polished surface. Her attention was somewhere else entirely. Dock announcements echoed faintly from the concourse beyond the hull.

Four hours.

That was how long until the next gate cycle.

Four hours for anyone watching to notice a change in behavior. Four hours to request priority positioning. Four hours to decide whether they were worth the trouble.

Mosby filed the first flight plan — routine trader departure, standard gate transit toward the Aurelia Gate. The safe route. The expected route.

He knew the route they would actually take would be far riskier.

He had a second set of plans ready but didn’t file them. That one remained held behind a final authorization he hadn’t yet sent.

Sael came down the gantry from the second deck. She moved quietly, stepping past them and down the ramp. Neither of them stopped her.

She crossed the docking concourse with purpose but without hurry, disappearing into a corridor toward a section marked with diplomatic insignia. She did not look back.

Work filled the next stretch of time — tools, diagnostics, half-spoken calculations. The ship hummed in uneven rhythms as systems came up one by one.

By the time Ted returned from the station markets with a final load of supplies — more parts, sealed ration packs, a crate of nutrient paste cartridges, and something labeled protein medley in optimistic lettering — the lighting in the bay had shifted toward evening tones.

“It was this,” Ted said, “or a shipment of ornamental algae.”

“Food’s food,” Mosby said.

Ted tilted his head slightly. “You have not tasted this yet.”

When Sael returned an hour later, her expression was composed.

A little too composed.

Mosby noticed — not suspicious yet, just aware something had shifted — but he didn't ask. Ted noticed as well, in the quiet, assessing way of his kind. He said nothing.

"I arranged some credits for us to have on hand," she said. "Had to get special authorization."

Mosby nodded approvingly. "Good thinking."

She moved past them into the ship and up toward the second deck.

Ted watched her go.

"Friend Mosby," he said quietly, "could she not have done this without leaving the ship?"

Mosby didn't look up from the console.

"Yeah," he said.

And that was all either of them said about it.

Departure clearance came two hours later.

Not priority. Not delayed. Just another trader slot moving through the station's patient machinery.

The docking clamps released with a deep, resonant thud that carried through the deck plating. A faint shudder passed through the hull as the Farther Star shifted from being held to holding herself. Maneuvering thrusters pulsed, gentle and controlled, easing the ship back from the berth.

"Trader vessel Farther Star," station control intoned, voice calm and disinterested, "back clear on vector three-one-seven. Maintain drift until assigned outbound lane."

Mosby acknowledged and guided her with small inputs, eyes moving between the canopy and the traffic display. Around them, ships traced slow arcs of light and motion — freighters heavy with cargo, couriers darting between lanes, a passenger liner gliding inward with stately precision. Every movement logged. Timed. Expected.

Sael sat in the copilot's chair, hands folded loosely in her lap, gaze forward. The station lights played faint reflections across the canopy glass. She had not spoken since returning. A little too composed.

Ted stood behind them, one hand braced on the bulkhead as he watched the readouts over Mosby's shoulder.

The Farther Star cleared the immediate traffic envelope and drifted outward under minimal thrust. The station fell slowly behind, its rotating arms bright against the planet's curve. Beyond it, the stars sharpened into hard points of light.

"Farther Star," control said, "you are entering navigation lane Aurelia departure. Stand by for queue assignment."

The ship slid into the outbound flow, one more icon among dozens edging toward their respective gates.

A pause. A soft carrier hiss.

"Farther Star, you are number twelve in the Aurelia Gate departure queue. Hold position and await sequencing."

"Twelve," Mosby repeated after muting the channel.

The Farther Star drifted in the navigation lane, holds full, waiting for departure clearance and its place in the outbound queue — just another ship in a system built on schedules and predictable movement.

Ted made a low, thoughtful sound. "That is enough time," he said.

"For what?" Sael asked.

Ted did not answer.

Mosby was watching the other ships as they began to queue.

Transponder icons slid into ordered lanes on the display, each tagged with registry, mass, destination. The system's quiet choreography unfolded exactly as designed — predictable, regulated, safe.

Then one contact caught his eye.

"That one." Mosby leaned forward and pointed at a marker nearing the departure threshold. "Does that look familiar to you?"

Sael leaned closer to his display. For a moment she said nothing. Then her breath caught.

"At Aureline," she said softly.

Mosby nodded once. "Yeah. Thought so."

The contact tag resolved as the system refreshed — registry masked, drive signature blurred into the noise floor. It matched the way it had looked before: present, but unwilling to be seen.

The ship ahead of them brightened as its drive came up under sequencing control, nudged toward the gate in a clean, obedient arc.

Mosby's voice dropped, steady and matter-of-fact. "When it enters the gate, we break out of lane and file the second flight plan."

Sael's eyes stayed on the display, tracking the other ship's slow glide toward the luminous geometry of the gate. "They'll see the vector change."

"There are a couple of ships between us and them," Mosby said. "Once they cross the threshold, they're committed. They have to complete transit before they can even think about turning around."

Sael understood immediately. That would put them far ahead by the time anyone on the other side could even begin to guess where they had gone.

The distant ship crossed the outer approach boundary, its transponder pulsing brighter as the gate's field began to build around it.

A faint vibration thrummed through the deck — not from their own drives, but from the gate cycling up for transit.

"Timing will be critical," Ted said.

Mosby flexed his fingers once over the controls. "Good thing we're not in a hurry," he said.

Ahead of them, the gate shimmered, distortion spreading like heat haze across the stars as spacetime bent around the departing vessel.

Mosby's thumb hovered over the authorization tab for the second flight plan. Waiting.

Ted glanced at his display, claws moving lightly across the interface. His head tilted.

"Friend Mosby," he said, "the filed destination is not accurate."

Mosby didn't look away from the canopy. "Nope."

Ted studied the numbers a moment longer. "It indicates Dawn Hold."

"Sure does."

Sael's eyes flicked toward him. "You're putting a false destination on record."

"Just keeping paperwork happy," Mosby said. "If anyone checks, we were heading somewhere nice and ordinary. If our friends out there check, they'll be looking for us in the wrong places."

Ted made a quiet sound of understanding. “A decoy trail.”

“That’s the idea.”

The gate’s glow intensified ahead of them as the departing ship slid deeper into the field.

Sael’s voice stayed low. “No traffic control. No one knows where we are.”

“No one coming if it goes wrong,” Ted added quietly.

Mosby gave a single nod. “Yeah,” he said. “That’s the idea.”

The ship ahead — the one they had seen at Aureline — vanished in a flare of distorted light.

“Now,” Mosby said.

His thumb came down on the console.

The second flight plan transmitted — clean, routine, logged for Dawn Hold.

Then his other hand moved.

The Farther Star rolled hard out of the navigation lane.

Warning tones chirped as proximity buffers protested. Transponder traffic spiked — automated queries, routing challenges, system confusion rippling through the local net.

Mosby ignored it all.

“Vector plotted,” Ted said, voice suddenly sharp. “Window is narrow.”

“I see it.”

The ship’s nose swung toward a gap between traffic flows — not the gate corridor, not any declared route, but open black where no outbound vessel was supposed to be accelerating.

“Inertial dampers to full,” Mosby snapped.

“Dampers holding.”

The drive began to spool, a rising hum building through the deck plates and into their bones.

Behind them, the gate flared again as the next ship in sequence advanced, its transit wash blooming bright across sensors. For a few critical seconds, every watchful system would be focused forward.

“Field is building,” Ted said.

Sael gripped the edge of her seat, eyes fixed ahead. “Commit.”

Mosby didn’t hesitate. “Jump.”

CHAPTER START: Space Folded

Space folded.

Stars flared white and vanished as the *Farther Star* drove into FTL, slipping free of the ordered lanes and their watching systems. No one spoke.

The cockpit lights flickered while the field geometry settled. Numbers streamed across the panels. The harsh shudder of entry eased into a deep, steady vibration that lived in the bones more than the ears. The sound of it wasn't loud so much as intimate — a pressure in the teeth, a tremor in the seat frame, the ship's mass agreeing, reluctantly, to be somewhere it had no business being.

"Field integrity holding," Ted said. "Thermal load within margin."

Mosby gave a short nod but kept his hands near the controls. He didn't fly the ship so much as **wait beside it**, ready to catch it if it slipped.

Sael rose and moved to the navigation console. She had known they were bypassing the gates. That had been clear the moment Mosby broke from the departure queue.

Direct to Sol. Risky, but reasonable.

She studied the projected course.

Her eyes narrowed.

The display was alive with interference — shadows forming and dissolving, vectors bending where no mass should have been. Data ghosts flickered in and out of solution. The predictive line refused to stay straight; it wandered, corrected, wandered again, as though the computer were arguing with the space ahead.

"What is this?" she asked.

"Gravimetric instabilities," Ted said. "Radiation shear. Stellar fragment fields."

Mosby kept his gaze forward. "Shortest line between here and Sol. Most ships don't take it. Most ships aren't trying to disappear."

Ted tilted his head slightly. "Most ships," he said, "also prefer not to die."

The deck trembled faintly as the field compensated for uneven space ahead, then lurched. It wasn't a shove so much as a momentary absence of support, like a stair step that wasn't where you expected it to be. Sael's fingers tightened on the console edge before she could stop them.

Ted adjusted a control by a fractional degree. “Stress variance elevated,” he said. “Still tolerable.” **His voice stayed mild. His hands did not.**

Sael studied the distorted starfield a moment longer. The wavering threads of light ahead no longer seemed distant or abstract. They suggested motion without pattern, structure without stability. A place that looked calm until you tried to lay a ruler across it.

For the first time since the jump, unease stirred beneath her composure.

The urgency of escape faded. In its place came the long, suspended tension of a difficult crossing — the kind where the danger lay not behind them, but ahead.

The ship rode the hum of FTL like a small boat on a long, invisible swell. Beyond the forward ports, space was no longer space but a soft distortion — stars stretched into faint, wavering threads that slid past without ever seeming to move. Sometimes the threads thickened, brightening as if the field were scraping too close to something massive and unseen; sometimes they thinned, leaving the glass looking almost empty. Mosby watched those changes the way a sailor watches the texture of water.

The cockpit lights were dimmed for long watch. Instrument panels cast steady color across the consoles and the tired faces gathered there. Time in transit did what it always did: it made the ship smaller, the air drier, the muscles stiffer, **the thoughts sharper at the edges.**

Sael stood behind the pilot’s chair, one hand resting lightly on the back of it, bracing against the subtle turbulence.

“There is something you should know,” she said.

Mosby didn’t turn. “That usually means I’m not going to like it.”

Ted’s gaze shifted toward her, reflective eyes catching the panel glow.

Sael took a breath. “About who might be reading our traffic. About why I didn’t say anything sooner.”

Now Mosby glanced back. “Figured you’d get around to it.” His tone was casual; his eyes weren’t.

“There’s a group,” she said. “They don’t hold territory. They don’t fly under a flag. But when they take an interest in a system... things change.”

Ted made a soft sound of recognition.

“Got a name?” Mosby asked.

“Intelligence says they call themselves Ascendants,” Sael continued. **“They don’t conquer. They cultivate.”** She swallowed once. “They believe civilizations evolve through pressure. That stagnation is more dangerous than upheaval. If a society is shielded from hardship too long, it weakens. Collapses later. Worse.”

“So they let the bad things happen,” Mosby said.

“Sometimes they remove the things preventing it,” Sael replied, lowering her head. “Sometimes they cause them.”

Ted tilted his head. “They attempt to restore what they consider natural selection at scale.”

Mosby let out a low breath. “People die.”

“Yes,” Sael said softly. No defense. No excuse. The admission landed without flourish, which made it heavier.

“They see war, famine, collapse as a fire,” she said. “Something that tempers what survives. If a civilization can’t endure that, they believe it wasn’t viable to begin with.”

Silence settled in the cockpit, heavier than before. Even the ship seemed to listen, the steady vibration continuing beneath their feet like a reminder that survival was never abstract out here.

“And you?” Mosby asked. “You buy that?”

Sael watched the warped starlight ahead. “I understand how someone could. That’s not the same as agreeing.”

“They mistake resilience for worth,” Ted said softly.

“They break things to see what survives,” Mosby muttered, “like children knocking down their toys.”

No one argued.

After a moment, Mosby leaned back in his seat. He rolled his shoulders once, as if settling himself under a weight he’d decided to carry anyway.

“This means we stop acting like we’re in traffic. Ted?”

Ted straightened slightly. “Yes, Friend Mosby.”

“How ugly is it going to be to push the field harder than she likes?”

Ted hesitated. “Inadvisable. Inefficient. Structurally impolite to the drive.” His eyes flicked to a temperature band that was already inching upward.

Mosby's mouth twitched. "But possible."

Ted studied him. "What do you intend to do, Friend Mosby?"

Mosby kept his eyes forward. "I'm tired of people breathing down our necks. Tired of being one step behind."

His fingers tapped lightly on the console. Not impatience — counting.

"We can't change lanes," he said. "But we can open the throttle. Put some distance between us and whoever's watching."

Sael frowned. "You're talking about overdriving the field."

"I'm talking about getting there first."

Ted considered that. "The stress load will not be trivial in this space. **This corridor bites back.**"

"Neither is being hunted," Mosby said.

A quiet moment passed, filled with the steady hum of the drive. The ship answered the silence with a faint, restless shiver, as if it disliked being discussed in front of strangers.

Then Ted inclined his head. "Very well. I will attempt to persuade the drive to cooperate."

Mosby gave a faint smile. "That's why you're here."

He reached for the controls, beginning the careful process of nudging the field parameters beyond their comfortable margins. Not a shove — a series of small thefts from the safety envelope, each one bought with heat and wear.

Without looking at her, he added, "You'd better be straight with us, Sael."

She stiffened slightly. "I am."

"I knew you weren't telling me everything," he said. "But this? This is the kind of thing I should've known up front."

Sael held his gaze. Her voice, when she spoke, was calm — and distant.

"I can only tell you what I'm authorized to. And when it becomes necessary."

Ted's eyes moved between them, silent.

Mosby looked at her for a long moment. Measuring. Reassessing. The way a pilot judges weather: not by what it is, but by what it's about to become.

"Fine," he said at last.

The word wasn't agreement. It was a line being drawn.

"We'll play it that way."

Sael inclined her head once, accepting the terms — and the cost.

The hum of the drive deepened as Ted fed more power into the field. The vibration changed pitch, climbing into something tighter and less forgiving, and the hull answered with a low complaint that came up through the soles of their feet.

The jump hadn't changed.

But the way they were riding it had the ship shuddering under strain.

And something between them, once easy and unspoken, now carried weight.

A hairline crack.

Not broken.

Not yet.

But there.

Time stretched.

The *Farther Star* drove on through the warped dark, her engines carrying that deeper, strained tone that never quite faded now. The ship felt alive underfoot — not in the easy, balanced way of a clean run, but like something enduring a burden it would rather not bear. Panels stayed loose. Tools stayed out. The air smelled faintly of hot insulation and recycled water.

Watches turned over quietly. Rarely were less than two in the cockpit at once. Ted moved through the ship in restless circuits, opening panels, tightening tolerances, making minute adjustments before small complaints could grow into serious ones. He ate standing up. Slept in snatches with one hand still on a diagnostic lead.

Sael spent long hours at the navigation console, silent, watching the projected corridor ahead worsen by degrees. The farther they went, the less the charts meant. She learned the ship's new language: the slight flicker in a readout that meant nothing now but would mean everything ten minutes later; the tiny delay between a tremor and Ted's correction.

Mosby stayed in the pilot's chair more often than he slept. When he did rest, it was shallow and brief. When awake, he watched the forward distortion or the readouts — and not Sael. He accepted food and drink without looking away, as if turning his head might invite the universe to take advantage.

They were nearly halfway through the crossing when the rhythm changed.

Ted felt it through the deck before the instruments confirmed it. A subtle shift in vibration. A wrongness in the engine note. The hum lost its steady center and began to hunt, wavering as if the field could not decide where to hold.

He was already leaning over the console when the first numbers began to drift.

Ahead, the distorted geometry tightened.

The smooth lensing of FTL twisted into knots.

The ship didn't shudder.

It slammed.

A brutal lateral shock tore through the hull, hard enough to rattle teeth and snap heads sideways. Consoles flared white, then red, as field harmonics ripped out of alignment. Somewhere aft, something heavy broke loose with a metallic crash. A second sound followed — lighter, faster — tools or fittings skittering across deck plates.

Sael was thrown into the console edge. Pain flared along her shoulder as she caught herself too late. Her breath came sharp and fast, discipline cracking under the sudden violence.

Ted staggered, caught himself, and lunged for the controls, claws scraping metal as he dumped load from one emitter bank to another before the cascade could run away. Warnings overlapped: thermal, drift, emitter imbalance, dampers protesting at their limit.

The readouts went wild.

Gravitational variance spiked off scale. Radiation noise screamed across the sensors. The navigation display filled with phantom returns — ghost masses blooming and collapsing like reflections in shattered glass.

The *Farther Star* yawed hard. Inertial dampers whined in protest. A second impact followed, upward this time, a gut-wrenching heave that made the deck seem to fall away beneath them. For an instant Sael's stomach rose as if gravity had forgotten its job.

Sael dropped to one knee, hands braced against the plating. Her breathing lost rhythm, each inhale a sharp pull as the scale of what they had entered finally broke through her training.

Mosby did not fight the motion.

He rode it.

Hands steady on the controls, he let the ship run before the storm the way a seasoned captain runs before a hurricane swell — never trying to outmuscle the sea, only keeping the bow aligned with the least deadly path. He fed small, measured corrections into the helm, feeling the rhythm beneath the chaos. His eyes were half on the instruments and half on the way the distortion leaned, reading it by instinct the way he once read smoke and tracers.

Ahead, the distortion coiled into a visible rupture — a warped fold in the flow, like a breaking wave frozen in space.

They drove straight into it.

Ted cut power sharply, bleeding energy into the lateral stabilizers. The engine note dropped to a strained, uneven growl.

The rupture hit.

The ship convulsed. A deep, tearing groan rolled through the structure, felt more than heard. Every light in the cockpit died for a fraction of a second, leaving only motion and the sickening sensation of falling sideways through nothing.

Then the backups caught.

Dim emergency lighting snapped on. Systems clawed their way back into coherence. The violent motion eased to heavy turbulence... then tremors... then the deep, labored hum of an overworked drive. The smell of overheated circuitry drifted from somewhere behind the panels, sharp and chemical.

Numbers crawled back from the edge.

Radiation noise fell. Phantom contacts thinned and vanished. The twisted knot of distortion ahead slowly unwound into the familiar, uneasy flow of FTL.

Ted stayed bent over the console, breathing hard as he made one last, delicate adjustment.

“She’s still with us,” he said quietly.

Sael pushed herself upright, face pale, composure stripped down to effort alone. She kept her eyes on the forward glass as if looking away would make it happen again.

Mosby kept his eyes forward, hands light on the controls, listening to the ship the way a sailor listens to a hull in heavy seas.

They had just run before the storm — and lived.

The last tremor faded into the deeper, uneven hum of the drive.

“Ted,” Mosby said sharply.

“Already going, Friend Mosby.”

Ted was in motion as he spoke, hands moving across the controls, isolating stressed systems and easing the field back into a sustainable geometry. The warning tones diminished, one by one, until only a low diagnostic murmur remained.

Mosby glanced sideways. “You all right, Sael?”

She was still braced against the console where the shock had thrown her. One hand gripped the edge hard enough to whiten her knuckles. Her breathing was steadying, but not yet steady.

“I’m fine,” she said, and this time she almost made it sound true.

She straightened slowly, rolling her shoulder once as if testing it, then returned her attention to the navigation display. Her posture was controlled again, movements deliberate — but a fraction too deliberate.

Ted straightened from his console. “Drive integrity remains within operational tolerance,” he said. “She has endured worse.”

Mosby allowed himself the faintest nod. The *Farther Star* had seen combat, hard burns, and things no shipping registry would ever hear about. It would take more than one bad stretch of space to break her.

Maybe.

He looked forward again, hands light on the controls, listening to the ship. The vibration had changed — rougher, but stable. A hull with stories always sounded that way.

Then, without turning his head, he let his gaze shift just enough to catch Sael in the reflection of the forward glass.

She was staring at the distorted starfield as if it had personally offended her. Her jaw was set, but he saw the delay in her reactions, the careful stillness of someone forcing control back into place.

She wasn’t used to this kind of space.

He said nothing.

Didn’t soften his tone. Didn’t offer reassurance. Didn’t call attention to it.

He just logged it away, the way a captain notes a change in weather or a new sound in the rigging.

Something to remember.

Outside, the warped starlight flowed on, vast and indifferent. The Star drove forward through it, battered but unbowed. And inside the cockpit, the silence carried a little more weight than it had before.

Mosby kept his eyes forward a moment longer, then spoke without looking at her.

“Why don’t you have the autodoc run a scan,” he said. “No point finding out later you cracked something.”

Sael started to wave it off, then stopped. She gave a small nod instead.

“Good idea,” she said quietly.

She stepped out of the cockpit with careful control, not rushing, not limping — but not moving quite as easily as before.

Mosby watched her go only long enough to make sure she cleared the hatch without stumbling.

Ted was already pulling up engineering schematics, his brow plates drawn tight in concentration.

“I want to check engineering,” he said. “Some of the structural readings are... concerning.”

Mosby grunted. “Go.”

Ted paused at the hatch and looked back.

“Friend Mosby, warn me if there is another gravity shear.”

Mosby gave a short nod. “You’ll hear it before I do.”

Ted inclined his head and disappeared down the passage at a quick, efficient pace.

Mosby was alone in the cockpit now. He rested his hands lightly on the controls and listened to the ship — to the vibration in the deck, the pitch of the engines, the faint groans of metal under stress.

The *Farther Star* sounded tired.

But she was still running.

The corridor lights seemed brighter than usual.

Sael told herself it was only the contrast after the dim cockpit, but she didn’t slow her pace until she reached the small medical bay aft of the galley. The hatch slid open with a soft pneumatic sigh.

The autodoc cradle waited where it always did, indifferent and patient.

She sat on the edge of it and let out a breath she hadn't realized she was still holding.

Her hands were steady now. That surprised her. It irritated her a little, too — as if steadiness were supposed to mean she hadn't been frightened, and she knew better than to confuse the two.

She rolled her shoulder carefully. A dull ache flared, nothing sharp. Nothing broken. Just the memory of the impact lingering in muscle and bone.

"Begin scan," she said.

The machine hummed to life, cool light passing slowly over her. She stared at the ceiling while it worked, listening to the distant vibration of the drive through the deck. Somewhere forward, very far away in the ship's geometry, Mosby was still holding a line through unstable space. She could feel that effort as a constant pressure, like a hand placed lightly at the base of the spine.

She had read reports about corridors like this. Hazard zones. Unstable regions. Statistical anomalies.

Words on a screen.

None of them had prepared her for the way space had moved — not empty, not passive, but violent and unpredictable, as if the universe itself had shrugged and nearly thrown them off.

She closed her eyes for a moment.

Training said to catalog the fear. Name it. Reduce it to information.

Her pulse had spiked. Breathing irregular. Cognitive narrowing under sudden threat.

All manageable.

Still, when the ship had lurched the second time, she had not thought of protocols or contingencies.

She had thought, very clearly:

This is how people vanish.

The autodoc chimed softly, announcing the end of its scan.

"Minor soft tissue trauma," it reported in its calm, neutral voice. "No fractures. No internal bleeding. Recommend rest and anti-inflammatory."

"I'll take the medication," she said. "Skip the rest."

The dispenser clicked, offering a small capsule. She swallowed it dry and sat there a moment longer, hands folded loosely in her lap. The capsule tasted faintly of chalk and citrus, as if the designers wanted pain relief to feel polite.

Mosby had told her to come here without making it an order.

She knew what that meant.

He had seen.

She wasn't sure whether that comforted her or unsettled her more.

After a while, she slid off the cradle and straightened her jacket. Her expression, when she caught it in the reflection of a darkened panel, was composed again.

Not the same as before.

But steady enough.

She dimmed the lights in the bay before leaving, letting the quiet hum of the autodoc fade behind her as she made her way back toward the cockpit. The ship felt different in the passageways now — still tense, still strained, but no longer being physically shaken apart. The deck no longer tried to buck her. The vibration had settled into a tired, persistent thrum, like an animal that had stopped fighting and was simply enduring.

As she moved forward, she passed an open access panel where someone — Ted, almost certainly — had left a tool kit half-unpacked. A strip of diagnostic tape fluttered with the ship's breath of recycled air. The smell of warm insulation was still there, but it was fading, diluted by the ordinary odors of metal, lubricant, and stale coffee.

By the time she reached the cockpit hatch, the emergency lights had been cut back and the main illumination restored to its low watch setting. The panels still wore their amber cautions like bruises, but the screaming alarms were gone.

Mosby let out a slow breath he hadn't realized he was holding. He did it through his nose, carefully, like a man afraid that if he exhaled too hard the universe would notice and take another swing.

"We still in one piece?"

"Yes," Ted said. "For certain definitions of 'one piece.'"

"Later," Mosby muttered. His hands stayed on the controls, but the grip had loosened; he could afford to let the ship fly for a few seconds without expecting it to betray him. "Where are we?"

Sael leaned forward, studying the forward display as the sensor returns stabilized. The distortion outside the ports was still there, but it had smoothed. The threads of warped light no longer kinked and snapped; they ran in long, uneasy curves, as if the corridor had finally decided to behave.

The view resolved into a dense tapestry of motion. Not the violent, impossible clutter from the storm's heart, but **the old clutter of danger** — old lanes, stray debris, radiation blooms that pulsed and faded like heat lightning. The kind of mess a busy, dangerous region accumulated over decades. The kind of mess you could navigate, if you respected it.

Mosby's eyes flicked once to the chronometer. Long enough. Not forever. He shifted in the chair, spine cracking faintly, and for the first time in hours let his shoulders drop.

Ted was already moving again, quiet in the background, making notes, rebalancing loads, treating the *Farther Star* the way you treated a battered machine you loved: with blunt honesty and careful hands.

And Sael, looking at the now-legible chaos ahead, understood the difference. The storm had been something that could kill you without meaning to. What lay in front of them was worse in a different way. It could kill you because it didn't care at all — and because people had been careless here, long before they arrived.

CHAPTER START: Sol

Sol.

The inner system was alive with traffic.

Dozens—no, hundreds—of transponder signatures threaded across the display, moving in layered corridors of light and velocity that stacked over and under one another in disciplined patterns. Gate flares winked in and out of existence around the system’s periphery, each arrival and departure briefly bending starlight into impossible angles before snapping back to normal — distortions so common here they barely warranted a second glance.

Freight convoys crawled along assigned lanes like glowing beads on invisible wires, mass and momentum managed by systems refined **over generations**. Passenger liners glided in stately arcs toward orbital hubs large enough to be cities in their own right, their approach vectors adjusted by fractions of a degree to avoid ripples that could propagate for thousands of kilometers. Military patrol craft held quiet positions near the major junctions, their transponders crisp and unmistakable — present not to threaten, but to remind.

And threaded through it all was the constant murmur of traffic control. Overlapping channels of clearances, advisories, routing adjustments — voices calm, precise, endlessly patient. The sound of a system that never slept because it could not afford to.

Sael exhaled softly. “All gates lead to Sol.”

“Yeah,” Mosby said. “And everybody shows up eventually.”

Ted tilted his head, watching the traffic density map update as new arrivals folded seamlessly into the flow. “We are not conspicuous,” he observed.

“Let’s keep it that way,” Mosby replied.

He nudged the maneuvering controls, easing the *Farther Star*’s velocity down into the lower end of the local traffic band. The ship settled into the stream without protest, one more tired freighter among hundreds that had crossed too much distance and seen too much vacuum. **Here, even exhaustion had a bracket and a code.**

“File a minor systems stress report,” Mosby said. “Nothing dramatic. We’re a hauler that pushed her drive too hard and needs a breather. That’s a story Sol hears every hour.”

Sael’s hands moved over the comm panel, her voice steady and professional as she transmitted the report. “Requesting low-priority inspection window and temporary berth. No hazardous cargo. No passenger services required.”

Ted glanced at the drive readouts again, eyes lingering on a stubborn amber indicator. “A pressurized berth would be... appreciated.”

Mosby gave him a sideways look. “You mean for the ship, right?”

Ted’s gaze shifted toward him. “Primarily.”

Traffic control responded a moment later, voice calm, almost bored. A berth assignment. A projected delay measured in hours, not days. A routing corridor to follow, already overlaid on their display.

Routine. Unremarkable.

Exactly what Mosby wanted.

The *Farther Star* slid deeper into the system, swallowed by the organized chaos of humanity’s busiest crossroads. Behind them, the FTL jump — the gravity shear, the storm — was already just another line item in a log that would be archived, indexed, and forgotten.

Ahead, five gates burned steadily, each one a controlled wound in spacetime leading somewhere else. Old gates. New gates. Gates rebuilt after wars, expanded after famines, reinforced after mistakes no one wanted to repeat.

“Sol’s Grand Central Gates,” Mosby remarked. “More tonnage goes through there in a day than most systems see in a year.”

He watched the flow of ships around them, hands light on the controls.

“Stay small,” he said quietly. “Stay boring.”

Sael glanced at him, then back out at the impossible sprawl of motion and light. For the first time since leaving New Horizon, she allowed herself to believe no one was chasing them.

For the moment, they were just another ship in the crowd.

And Mosby knew that was as close to safe as the galaxy ever got.

CHAPTER: Sol Arrival

The berth wasn't glamorous.

A rotating service drum bolted onto the spine of one of Sol's older orbital yards, its interior lined with docking cradles that had seen decades of tired freighters and overworked haulers. The *Farther Star* settled into one of them with a soft, hollow thud that carried through the deck as the clamps engaged.

External power umbilicals extended and locked into place. A moment later, the ship's systems **sighed** as station load replaced strain, the constant tension in the deck easing just enough to be felt.

"Finally," Mosby muttered.

Ted was already moving before the dock seals finished cycling.

By the time Mosby reached engineering, two access panels were open and a diagnostic lead snaked deep into the drive housing. The smell of hot metal and polymer sealant hung in the air, sharp and familiar — damage, but manageable.

"How bad?" Mosby asked, leaning in the hatchway with a mug of something that claimed to be coffee.

Ted did not look up. "We remain spaceworthy," he said. "Define 'proudly.'"

Mosby grunted. "You'll tell me when it gets expensive."

"It already is."

Mosby reached past him to tap a readout. "You gonna need help?"

Ted paused, considering the display as if the answer might still change. "Yes," he said simply.

He keyed a short transmission, voice low and precise.

Within an hour, three Talari arrived.

They came without uniforms, insignia, or visible affiliation. One carried a tool case older than the *Star*. Another had a sling of diagnostic filaments looped over one shoulder like climbing rope. The third moved with the careful gait of someone whose joints had been replaced more than once and expected to be replaced again.

They did not introduce themselves.

They did not need to.

Ted inclined his head in greeting. Subtle shifts of posture passed between them — information exchanged faster than language, acknowledgments without ceremony.

Mosby watched from the corridor. “You just... call people?”

“I indicated assistance would be efficient,” Ted said.

“And they just show up?”

“Yes.”

“Do they want paying?”

Ted considered. “Not in the way you mean.”

The Talari slipped into the open compartments with quiet competence. One began recalibrating a warped field bracket. Another laid fresh sealant mesh along a stressed conduit. The third connected to the diagnostic bus and began reading logs, eyes unfocusing briefly as data streamed through him.

They worked without chatter. But now and then one would pause, head tilting slightly — receiving, considering, passing something along.

Sael noticed.

“They’re sharing,” she said quietly.

Ted glanced at her. “We are not good at keeping what we learn to ourselves.”

Mosby folded his arms. “About the ship, I hope.”

Ted did not answer immediately.

“Primarily,” he said at last.

Mosby left them to it.

In the galley, he scrolled through the delayed message queue. Most of it was routing chatter and automated confirmations that had tried to follow them along standard trade paths. A few invoices. One mildly irritated note from a broker wondering why a shipment acknowledgment had originated from the wrong system.

No new contracts. No fresh jobs.

“Shortcut,” he muttered. “Saves time, costs everything else.”

He closed the display and pulled on a jacket that had seen more ports than he had.

Sael found him at the hatch.

“Going somewhere?” she asked.

“Salt broker,” he said. “Renew the Helion. Then food. Real food. I’m not eating another tube of protein medley unless it apologizes.”

She hesitated only a moment. “I’ll come.”

Mosby shrugged. “Suit yourself. It’s not glamorous.”

“I didn’t expect it to be.”

Sol’s yard concourses were never quiet.

The corridor outside the berth opened into a wide service spine crowded with cargo haulers, dockhands, traders, and crews on short leave. Overhead displays flickered with arrival schedules and berth rotations. The air smelled faintly of ozone, machinery oil, and a dozen different cuisines competing for attention.

They moved through it side by side, not touching, not speaking at first.

Mosby stopped at a fuel services kiosk wedged between a parts recycler and a stall selling fried noodles from a vat that had probably outlived several empires. He leaned on the counter, exchanging quiet words with a clerk who looked like he’d been born tired.

“Salt renewal slot in twelve hours,” Mosby said as they stepped away. “We’ll top off before we leave.”

Sael nodded. “Good.”

They found a food stall with actual vegetables — a luxury by spacer standards — and carried their trays to a narrow counter overlooking a wide viewport.

Beyond the glass, ships drifted in layered motion, tugs guiding freighters into cradles, shuttles flitting between platforms, traffic lights blinking in silent choreography.

For a while, they just ate.

Mosby watched the traffic. Sael watched him watching it.

“You don’t seem impressed,” she said at last.

“By Sol?” he asked.

“Yes.”

He shrugged. “Big is just big. Means more ways to get lost. More ways to get stepped on.”

Sael considered that. “Most people see opportunity.”

“Most people aren’t trying not to be noticed.”

She studied him a moment longer. “You’ve been doing this a long time.”

“Long enough.”

“Do you ever think you should have done more?” she asked quietly.

Mosby didn’t look at her. “Doing the job in front of you is already more than most manage.”

She let that sit between them.

Traffic flowed past in silent arcs of light.

Neither of them said what they were thinking.

But the distance between them had changed — just a little.

They stayed at the counter longer than the food required.

Beyond the viewport, a bulk freighter rotated slowly under tug guidance, its hull scarred and layered with paint from a dozen ports. Smaller craft moved around it in careful arcs, every motion measured, anticipated, approved.

Sael rested her elbows lightly on the counter, fingers curled around the edge of her tray.

“You said most people aren’t trying not to be noticed,” she said.

Mosby took a slow sip from his cup. “That’s the trick.”

“Staying small?”

“Staying alive.”

She watched the freighter drift past. “You make it sound like those are the same thing.”

“Usually are.”

A pause.

“And when they’re not?” she asked.

Mosby’s gaze shifted, not to her, but to a patrol cutter sliding along a distant traffic lane, its transponder crisp and official.

“Then you pick the one you can live with afterward,” he said.

Sael was quiet for a moment.

“You’ve had to make that choice before.”

“Everyone has,” Mosby said.

“Not like you.”

That made him glance at her.

She didn’t look away.

“You disobeyed a direct order.”

Mosby’s thumb rubbed once, slow and unconscious, along the old scar over his eye before his hand stilled.

Mosby’s mouth twitched faintly. “That’s one way to put it.”

“You chose people over the mission.”

“I chose the people in front of me,” he said. “The mission was somewhere else.”

Sael absorbed that.

“In my line of work,” she said slowly, “we’re taught that the bigger picture matters more than any one piece of it.”

“Must make it easier,” Mosby said.

She looked down at her hands. “It’s supposed to.”

The noise of the concourse swelled and faded around them — footsteps, voices, the distant whine of docking clamps cycling.

“You don’t believe that,” he said.

Sael didn’t answer right away.

“I believe systems matter,” she said at last. “Structures. Stability. Without them, everything falls apart.”

“Yeah,” Mosby said. “But when something’s breaking right in front of you, you don’t get to tell it to wait for the system to catch up.”

Her lips curved slightly. Not quite a smile.

“You make it sound simple.”

“It isn’t,” he said. “It’s just immediate.”

Sael studied him openly now.

“You don’t seem to want anything,” she said.

Mosby snorted. “I want my ship to hold together and my food not to come out of a tube.”

“I mean beyond that.”

He looked back out at the traffic web.

“I had my turn at wanting big things,” he said. “Didn’t go great.”

“That doesn’t stop most people.”

“I’m not most people.”

“No,” Sael agreed quietly.

The words carried more weight than she intended.

For a moment neither of them spoke.

A transport liner drifted past the viewport, its hull lights tracing a slow, graceful curve toward an inner dock. Thousands of people aboard, each with somewhere to be, something they believed mattered.

Sael’s voice, when she spoke again, was softer.

“Do you ever get tired,” she asked, “of being the one who carries it?”

Mosby didn’t ask what it was.

“Yeah,” he said. “But dropping it doesn’t make it lighter.”

She held his gaze a second longer than she meant to.

Something shifted there — not dramatic, not declared. Just an awareness, newly sharpened.

Then she looked away first.

“We should get back,” she said. “Ted will have taken half the ship apart by now.”

“Only half?” Mosby said. “He’s slipping.”

She let out a quiet breath that might have been a laugh.

They stood, trays in hand, and rejoined the flow of the concourse — two figures among thousands, carrying more between them than either had planned to.

They didn’t speak much on the walk back.

The noise of the station wrapped around them again — cargo carts whining past, dock crews arguing in three languages at once, announcements chiming overhead with the patient indifference of infrastructure that outlived empires. The smell shifted every dozen meters: oil, ozone, spice, hot metal, recycled air breathed by a million strangers.

Sael moved through it smoothly, not hurried, not hesitant. But Mosby noticed she watched everything. Reflections in viewport glass. Security patrol patterns. The way people avoided certain corridors without looking like they were avoiding them.

Mosby watched her for another few steps, then said, “That intelligence training?”

Sael didn’t look at him.

“Which part?”

“The way you check exits without turning your head.”

A beat passed.

“Logistics teaches you where people get trapped,” she said. “Intelligence teaches the rest.”

Mosby gave a quiet grunt.

“Yeah,” he said. “It does.”

They reached the service spine leading back toward their berth. Traffic thinned here, shifting from transient crowds to crews who knew exactly where they were going and had no interest in conversation. A maintenance drone hummed past at shoulder height, trailing fiber cable like a tail.

The *Farther Star* came into view around the curve of the drum — hull panels open, work lights glowing inside her like a ship laid bare on an operating table, mid-procedure **but no longer screaming**.

Except there were fewer lights than before.

One of the Talari was sealing a panel. Another disconnected a diagnostic filament and coiled it with precise, economical movements. The third stood still for a moment, head tilted, eyes unfocused — receiving, considering, concluding.

Ted emerged from beneath the forward housing just as Mosby and Sael stepped onto the docking gantry.

“We are ahead of projection,” he said.

Mosby blinked. “That so?”

“Yes. Cooperative cognition improves efficiency.”

“Translation,” Mosby muttered, “you worked fast.”

“Yes.”

Sael looked over the hull. “How much fast?”

Ted glanced at a readout pad. “Structural grace restored. Thermal tolerances improved. I am now only mildly offended by the drive’s behavior.”

Mosby nodded toward the open bay. “She gonna hold together?”

“Yes,” Ted said. Then, after a fractional pause, “With personality.”

“Wouldn’t be my ship without it,” Mosby replied.

He checked the time on his wrist display. “Helion top-off window’s in six hours. We don’t miss that.”

“We will not,” Ted said. “I have already requested line access and pre-flush clearance.”

Mosby stopped mid-step. “You what?”

Ted tilted his head. “Efficiency.”

Sael hid a small smile.

Inside the ship, the air smelled like warm metal and solvent instead of strain and overheated composites. The Talari moved through the compartments one last time, hands brushing panels, verifying work without tools — like musicians tuning by ear.

One paused near Mosby as he watched.

Dark eyes met his.

A subtle nod.

Work complete.

No words exchanged. None needed.

Mosby looked over the cargo bay one last time — crates seated, straps tight, nothing shifted that shouldn't. The *Farther Star* didn't feel fresh. She didn't feel new.

She felt settled.

Ready.

He let his breath out slowly.

“Good,” he said. “We refuel, we file departure, and we get small again.”

Sael's gaze drifted past the gantry toward the station's layered traffic, ships sliding through light and shadow in endless, practiced arcs.

“For how long?” she asked.

Mosby didn't answer at first. His eyes stayed on the bay, on the ship, on the small inventory of things that could still be controlled.

“Long enough,” he said at last.

Ted, halfway up a ladder, paused. He didn't look at either of them. He looked toward the open corridor beyond the hatch, where station lights strobed across passing hulls.

“Attention,” he said quietly.

Both of them turned.

“Not on us,” Ted added after a moment. “Yet.”

The *Farther Star* sat silent in her berth, systems resting, tanks soon to be full again. Outside, Sol turned on — vast, indifferent, and never truly asleep.

Inside, they prepared to leave it behind.

CHAPTER Gate

Sael closed the billing pane with a controlled exhale. The numbers did not linger because she did not let them.

Helion replenishment fees for the FTL alone eclipsed what most independents spent on fuel in a year. Line access surcharges. Purity certification. Containment flushing. The price of having pushed the drive hard enough to anger the salt.

Kryseum for the maneuvering thrusters barely registered by comparison, topped off as a matter of routine. Even that carried Sol's quiet tax: pricing scaled to traffic priority, not need.

She understood, intellectually, why the galaxy ran on gates. Direct FTL left scars—on ships, on accounts, on people.

Another set of confirmations scrolled in.

Cargo manifests.

Not bulk freight. Not contracts worth advertising. Small consignments pulled from different vendors, routed through maintenance depots and medical suppliers that didn't bother asking where the ship was headed. Emergency ration packs rated for long shelf life and short temperature excursions. Medical sealant cartridges. Auto-suture kits. Broad-spectrum injectables. Water recyclate filters small enough to fit in a locker, valuable enough to keep a crew alive when things went wrong.

None of it took much space.

All of it mattered.

Sael frowned slightly, scanning the list. "This isn't trade cargo."

"No," Mosby replied from the cockpit. "It's insurance."

She looked up at him. "You're planning to be unreachable."

"I'm planning to need what we've got," he said. "Out there, the wrong shortage kills you faster than an enemy."

Ted's voice came softly over the internal channel. "Medical supplies are... prudent."

Sael tagged the last crate for intake and authorized the transfer.

The deck vibrated beneath her feet as departure readiness propagated through the hull. Departure felt routine. That was what made it believable.

Traffic control slotted them into outbound flow without hesitation. Their transponder became just another identifier in a sea of ships leaving humanity's busiest crossroads. Voices layered over the comms—clearances, advisories, queue acknowledgments—crisp, professional, endless. Sol did not rush. Sol did not hesitate. Sol simply absorbed ships and released them again.

Mosby kept the chatter minimal. His responses were short, correct, forgettable. Ted stayed in engineering until the last possible moment, coaxing tolerances tighter than the ship had any right to maintain. Sael watched the traffic density map and did not look at the numbers again.

The Dawnreach Gate filled the forward display: a luminous ring wrapped in scaffolds, fuel depots, maintenance arms. Ships fed into it in steady arcs. Bulk cruisers dominated the inner lanes, their mass claims bending the queue geometry around them like gravity made visible.

A passenger liner slid into an adjacent corridor.

Long. Graceful. Bands of viewport lights traced its hull in soft gold, like a floating city at dusk. Sael recognized the class immediately—not that ship, but the design. She had traveled on one like it before. Wide promenades. Observation decks. Families who paid extra so their children could watch stars stretch and bend during transit.

She tracked it for a few seconds longer than necessary.

“Eight-point-one-five light-years,” Mosby said. “Short hop.”

Ted made a faint sound.

Not disagreement. Not agreement.

Mosby didn't ask.

Ted emerged into the cockpit just before sequencing lock, posture precise, movements economical. He stared at the lane geometry longer than necessary, head tilting by fractions as the flow resolved around them.

“Pattern density is correct,” he said slowly. “Timing is correct. But—”

“But what?” Sael asked.

Ted didn't answer right away. His gaze drifted across the parallel lanes, the synchronized acceleration curves, the perfect obedience of motion.

“I do not like it,” he said at last. “The gate is restless.”

Mosby snorted softly. “This is Sol. They iron the wrinkles out before you ever see them.”

The liner ahead adjusted its position, thrusters whispering as it aligned perfectly within its corridor. Everything about it was smooth. Predictable. Safe.

Before either of them could respond, the sequencing tone chimed.

The Farther Star slid into the corridor.

Transit space formed around them—structured light, distant silhouettes of ships in parallel lanes, all motion guided and precise. The gate’s control systems took hold with firm confidence.

The vibration through the deck was faint.

Too faint.

Sael felt it then—not fear, not yet—just a mild, inexplicable tension. Like standing on ice that hasn’t cracked, but might.

For a moment, everything aligned too perfectly.

Ted’s claws tightened once on the edge of the console.

“Friend Mosby,” he said quietly, “if the flow shifts suddenly—”

“It won’t,” Mosby replied, eyes forward.

Ted did not look convinced.

The Farther Star held her line. Guidance solutions updated and re-updated, each accepted without correction. No flags. No cautions. The vibration smoothed into a confident hum.

The kind of hum that lets you relax by accident.

For hours, it was almost peaceful.

Then the exit chime sounded.

Routine.

Ahead, ships began making micro-adjustments as the corridor end neared.

The cargo hauler in front of them drifted.

Just enough.

Not a maneuver.

A correction that came a fraction late.

Mosby's brow furrowed. "Huh."

Sael leaned forward. "They'll correct."

The hauler's guidance lights flickered. New vectors fed in. Thrusters nudged.

One of the outer containers brushed the corridor boundary.

It didn't scrape.

It caught.

For a heartbeat, nothing happened.

Then the hauler's forward section slowed as if it had struck resistance.

The rest of the ship did not.

Ted inhaled sharply. "That is not acceptable."

The stern whipped down and struck the opposite wall. Restraints failed in cascading sequence.

Containers vanished in flashes of distorted light—not explosions.

Absence.

The hauler bent.

Then it broke.

Inertia snapped it in two.

Loose containers scattered across lanes.

One clipped a ship two corridors over.

Its field flared once.

Then it was gone.

Alarms detonated across the Farther Star's cockpit.

More cargo tore loose. A long cylindrical tank spun end over end.

It struck another vessel.

The discharge was blinding—white light folding the corridor like heated glass.

“What was that?!” Mosby shouted.

“Kryseum fuel tank!” Ted replied. “Ignition under gradient stress!”

The shockwave hit.

The Star bucked. Mosby’s shoulder slammed into the restraints. Consoles flashed red. Somewhere aft, something heavy broke loose with a metallic shriek.

A panel burst beside Ted. Sparks sprayed. He hissed as molten fragments scored his arm. Blood darkened the deck.

“I remain functional,” he said tightly.

The corridor filled with spinning metal.

Mosby was already moving.

He rolled the Star hard to port, sliding under a rotating slab of cargo that would have sheared the cockpit away.

“Just like dodging AA coming in hot,” he muttered.

Sael slammed a hand against the console as another slab of debris screamed past.

“I swear to every saint on this ship’s hull,” she snapped, white-knuckled on the edge of the board, “if we live through this I am never taking a gate again!”

Another violent twist.

Mosby cut thrust for half a second, let debris outrun them—then punched it back in.

A container filled the canopy.

“Mosby—!”

He rolled knife-edge and dropped half a lane.

The container tore past close enough to ring the hull.

Something detonated two lanes over.

The shockwave punched them sideways.

The corridor twisted.

A passenger liner flickered into view—sideways.

For a heartbeat, Sael didn't understand what she was seeing.

Then the windows resolved.

Bands of warm light streaked past the canopy.

Inside—motion.

Silhouettes tumbling.

Hands reaching.

Bodies striking glass as gravity betrayed them.

Children.

The recognition landed whole.

She had stood behind windows like those.

Watched stars stretch while people laughed.

“Mosby—”

She had nothing else.

The liner separated.

Not violently.

Cleanly.

A smooth division, as if a hand had drawn a line through it.

The halves peeled away.

Internal lights flared once.

Then tore free into darkness.

Sael went silent.

Not screaming.

Not frozen.

Empty.

“Field collapse propagating!” Ted shouted. “We must exit now or not at all!”

Mosby didn’t answer.

He drove.

The corridor walls flickered. Structured light fractured into raw gravitational noise.

The tunnel convulsed.

Then came apart.

Ships were spat back into real space without alignment.

“Inertial dampers to maximum!”

“Already at limit!”

The Farther Star was thrown sideways—

And slammed back into real space.

Chapter

Silence didn't arrive with them.

Alarms did — layered tones that fought each other for priority while the Farther Star came out of the collapse spinning like a wheel that had lost its axle.

“Report!” Mosby barked, hands locked on the controls.

Ted didn't hesitate. “Multiple structural stress warnings. Port maneuver cluster offline. Kryseum flow unstable.”

Sael was already at the sensor panel, forcing her fingers into motion before her nerves could decide they were done. The scope was a smear of returns: hard fragments, hot fragments, objects so large they cast whole cones of interference around them. “Debris everywhere,” she said, the words clipped because breath was something she had to remember. “I'm not seeing the gate. Mosby... the gate is gone.”

“What do you mean, *gone*?”

“It's just—” She swallowed hard and made herself look again. “Wreckage. The ring's missing a section. Like something took a bite out of it.”

Mosby didn't answer. He was still fighting the roll. The Star wasn't flying so much as being carried by her own ruined momentum, turning slowly, heavily, her mass thrown off by a dead thruster cluster. It wasn't a violent spin — not the kind that slammed you into straps and turned stomachs inside out — but it was relentless. It promised that if they didn't fix it, they'd stay that way until the universe decided to finish the job.

“I can't counter it,” he growled. “Thrusters aren't responding.”

Outside, ships were still spilling out of the broken aperture at wrong angles. Some came out trailing atmosphere in pearly ribbons that froze into glittering fog. Some were already dark, tumbling with the calm inevitability of dead things. Others spun helplessly while open-band collision alarms shrieked across the comms, every voice on every channel trying to claim the same small slice of order.

The gate itself flickered in and out of coherence, and each time it resolved Sael saw it more clearly: the jagged absence where the inner ring should have been, the way the structure looked unfinished, wrong — as if physics had taken a chisel to it and then walked away.

Emergency beacons began to saturate every frequency.

Sael stared at the display, hands still on the panel as if her grip could keep the icons from vanishing. “How many...” she managed.

Traffic markers blinked and reappeared. Some never returned.

“That liner,” she said, and her voice thinned around the word. “There were people—”

“Yes,” Ted said quietly, and in the softness of it she heard the thing he was not saying: *and there still are, and there are not, and it’s already too late for some of them.*

She had not realized they’d stopped moving until Mosby said her name — once, low and sharp — and she didn’t answer.

“Sael!” he snapped.

She flinched as if struck, eyes snapping to him.

“I need you *here*. Right now.”

One beat passed, the kind that could ruin a ship. She dragged in air and forced her hands back into their work.

“I’m here,” she said, and she got control into the words even if she couldn’t yet get it into her pulse. “Reading debris vectors. Updating collision envelopes.”

Mosby nodded once and went back to the controls as if the nod itself were a contract. “We’re not dead,” he said. “That’s step one.”

Behind them, the wreckage of a highway between stars continued to spread into the void.

Ted’s eyes moved across the warning stack, precise and merciless. “External damage to the port reactionless array,” he said. “We are venting Kryseum.”

Sael felt the cold before she understood why. “We’re leaking fuel?”

“Yes,” Mosby said. “And if we don’t stop it, either it ignites... or we end up dead in space with no way to move.”

He was already out of the chair, moving toward the suit locker with the brisk certainty of a man who’d made ugly choices before and didn’t waste time pretending they were pretty. “We’ll have to go out and fix it. Or shut off the flow.”

“You’re going outside?” Sael heard the edge in her own voice and hated it — not fear, exactly, but the sudden awareness that all her training had been built for rooms with floors.

“I will assist,” Ted said, pushing himself up.

He made it halfway to standing before his legs betrayed him. He caught the console edge and a thin breath slipped out of him before he could trap it. The tear in his suit liner had soaked

through; the dark patch along his left side spread with each heartbeat, and the arm bracing him did not move correctly — the joint too loose, the angles wrong.

Sael was beside him instantly. “Ted. You’re hurt.”

“I am... aware.”

Mosby took one look — the kind of look that measured damage the way he measured thrust — and made the decision. “You’re not going anywhere except the autodoc.”

“I can still function.”

“You can supervise,” Mosby said. “From a padded drawer.”

“I object to the term *drawer*,” Ted managed, because even bleeding he was still Ted.

He didn’t resist when they guided him toward the ladder. The ship rolled again, slow and nauseating; warning lights strobed along the corridor, and somewhere aft a relay popped like a nail snapping under strain.

In the medbay Mosby brought the autodoc online and the lid irised open with patient indifference.

Ted regarded it like an insult given physical form. “I dislike this machine.”

“Yeah,” Mosby said, easing him into place. “It’s not thrilled about you either.”

Sael secured the restraints while Mosby pulled up external feeds and tied them into the autodoc display. “You can still see what we see,” Mosby told him. “Talk me through it.”

“...Very well,” Ted said, and even then there was a pause, as if he were choosing the least humiliating way to be right. “Friend Mosby... you will need assistance.”

The lid lowered. Pale blue light filled the chamber.

Which left two of them.

Sael sealed into her pressure suit beside the airlock while diagnostics crawled across her visor, one line at a time like a slow confession.

“I have not performed external repair under rotational drift,” she said.

Mosby checked her tether himself — not because he didn’t trust her, but because the universe had already proven it didn’t care. “You’ve done worse.”

“I have not.”

“Then today’s your day.”

The outer hatch opened.

Vacuum took the sound away at once, but it couldn’t take the motion. Stars slid in a slow, sickening curve as the Farther Star turned beneath them; each step with the mag boots was a negotiation with inertia, each movement something that had to be paid for in careful, controlled thrust.

In the distance, Dawnreach hung pale and shattered.

For a moment Sael forgot the repair. The broken ring held her attention the way a wound holds the eye; her mind kept trying to complete the missing arc, to make it whole, to pretend it hadn’t happened. Around it, wreckage drifted in slow, obscene grace, catching sunlight in dull flashes.

Her visor magnified a debris cluster without being asked.

She let it.

The liner’s hull rolled through the frame, a piece of it anyway — too cleanly cut, too recognizably *civilian*, too full of ghosts she could almost see through the metal.

“Sael,” Mosby’s voice said in her ear.

She didn’t answer.

“Eyes on the job.”

She blinked and the magnification collapsed. “On it.”

They worked deliberately: clamping the damaged vane, cutting away twisted conduit, securing a temporary brace while the ship continued its slow roll beneath them, as if it were trying to shake off the memory of what had touched it.

A warped panel came free as Mosby cut the final bolt.

“I’ve got it,” he said.

He didn’t.

The panel slipped, caught his thruster pack, and yanked him off the hull in a clean, ugly jerk that turned him into a swinging weight on his tether.

“Caleb!” Sael shouted, and the name came out of her without permission.

He swung outward, rotation turning him into a pendulum. “Thruster’s misaligned! Can’t counter!”

Her training rose cleanly: secure debris, prevent further damage, do not compound the emergency.

Instead she pushed off.

Short bursts. Hard angle. No elegance — only timing.

“Sael—don’t—” Mosby began.

She caught his arm. Impact spun them both.

“Brace!” she snapped.

She fired against their shared momentum. It wasn’t perfect, but it was enough. Their lines snapped tight and dragged them back into the ship’s rotation until plating filled her visor; they hit together, magnets catching with a jarring thud that she felt all the way up her teeth.

For a moment neither of them moved.

“You still in there?” Mosby asked, voice rough.

“Yes,” she said, and made it sound like an answer instead of a prayer.

They re-anchored and finished the brace.

When they got back inside, Ted was conscious in the autodoc, his image ghosting on the cockpit display.

“You survived,” he observed.

“Barely,” Mosby muttered.

The comm panel was alive with overlapping emergency traffic. Sael brought up the long-range view again and forced herself to look at what she already knew.

The Dawnreach Gate hung dark. A section of its inner ring was missing. There was no transit glow, no emergence flares, no orderly stream of ships turning into dots and vanishing.

No ships coming through.

“It’s gone,” she said.

“Gate aperture collapsed,” Ted replied. “No further transit possible.”

Mosby leaned back slowly, as if the chair might give him one second of weightless denial. “So the system’s cut off.”

“Yes. Mass traffic will require sublight or relay.”

Sael pulled up the news band. The headlines were already forming a narrative, as if catastrophe couldn’t exist until it had a ticker.

DAWNREACH GATE CATASTROPHIC FAILURE
EMERGENCY RESPONSE OVERWHELMED
MILITARY ASSETS DEPLOYING TO SECURE TRAFFIC LANES

The feed refreshed.

She froze.

“Mosby...”

A highlighted alert crawled across the channels.

TRADER VESSEL FARTHER STAR WANTED FOR IMMEDIATE DETENTION
CREW BELIEVED TO HAVE BEEN IN CLOSE PROXIMITY TO INITIAL FIELD
DISTURBANCE
AUTHORITIES REQUEST ALL STATIONS AND VESSELS REPORT SIGHTINGS

Sael read it aloud, because silence would have made it worse.

From the autodoc bay, Ted paused as if considering the shape of the problem. “That is... inconvenient,” he said.

Mosby exhaled. “We’re not getting a friendly debrief.”

“They think we caused it,” Sael said.

“Or they need someone they can point at,” Mosby replied, and the bitterness in it was old.

Outside, emergency beacons pulsed among drifting wreckage; rescue craft moved in tight patterns that looked disciplined only because the scale was so obscene that anything less would have been meaningless.

Inside the cockpit, the Farther Star sat wounded in the shadow of a broken gate.

They were no longer witnesses.

They were suspects.

CHAPTER: Drift and Decision

The Farther Star eased into a slow arc through the outer traffic band, her rotation finally damped to something that resembled flight. Every system readout carried some shade of caution—nothing red, nothing settled. Mosby flexed his fingers over the controls as if reminding himself they still belonged to him.

“We’re not dead,” he said. “That’s step one.”

Sael did not answer. She had the long-range view expanded again—farther than it needed to be—because looking away felt like letting it happen twice. The debris field no longer looked chaotic. It was beginning to organize under shared momentum: clusters drifting into loose families, fragments tracing arcs that would take years to disperse. She tracked one large piece as it moved against the stars. It would clear the primary lanes in weeks. Smaller fragments would not. The wreckage continued to spread, not violently now but steadily, with the patient confidence of physics.

It would not fix itself.

“Where are the rescue lanes forming?” Mosby asked.

Sael widened the overlay. Emergency vectors converged with grim efficiency. Military transponders multiplied by the minute, threading into the traffic like stitching closing a wound.

“They’re locking down the core corridors,” she said. “Any vessel without clearance is being told to power down and wait.”

“Inspection leads to questions,” Mosby said.

“Questions lead to us sitting still,” Ted replied faintly from the autodoc, his voice thinner but still sharp at the edges.

Mosby muted the external comms. The cockpit fell quieter at once, not calmer—just more private. “Alright,” he said. “Hit me.”

Ted’s image flickered onto the display. The autodoc’s light made his features look even more carved than usual, as if the machine was turning him into a diagram.

“There is a facility,” he said carefully. “It does not officially exist. It will not ask questions it cannot afford to hear.”

“A station?” Mosby asked.

“A structure. Former logistics node. It is reachable.”

“Distance?”

“Under standard conditions, several hours.” Ted paused. “Under our current condition... one to two days.”

“Two days in a damaged ship, in a system full of patrols.”

“Yes.”

Mosby studied the traffic map in silence, letting the answer finish itself. The system was tightening: rescue turning into control, control turning into a net. If they stayed where the authorities wanted them, they would be found quickly—and they would not get to decide what story came next.

“And the alternative?” he asked anyway.

No one answered.

“Alright,” Mosby said at last. “We go where we’re not supposed to exist.”

He nudged the Star off the main emergency flow into a slower orbital plane, shaving their profile down to something boring. Their transponder shifted to low-priority maintenance status. On the external cameras, hull lights reflected faintly off scarred plating, insignia burned into ghosts. Manny’s paintwork had suffered for it: one of the stylized eyes was gone entirely, and the other had warped into something that looked less like protection and more like warning.

“Plot me a path that looks tired,” Mosby said. “Slow. Broken.”

“I will guide you,” Ted said. “When I lose coherence, follow the highlighted route.”

“Comforting.”

The Farther Star eased into a long, shallow burn. Every vibration traveled through the deck now, and every adjustment carried the subtle protest of stressed metal. Behind them, Dawnreach flickered like a failing star. Ahead, empty space waited—never safe, merely unclaimed.

Sael watched the rescue lanes shrink behind them until they were only lines and cones on an overlay, too clean to match what she’d seen through the glass.

“When we get there,” she said quietly, “what do we tell them?”

Mosby didn’t look at her. “Nothing they didn’t already know.”

“And if the Ascendants are looking for the same place?”

“Then we get there first.”

The Star crawled onward, paint burned, systems strained, three lives and a thousand unanswered questions riding inside her hull.

The cockpit was quieter now, but it wasn't calm. Mosby trimmed their drift rate a fraction at a time, making them look less like a ship with somewhere to be and more like one trying not to be in anyone's way. Ted's guidance returned over the internal channel at intervals—faint but focused, the mind still working even while the body lay strapped under the autodoc's light.

"Adjust starboard vector point-two degrees. There is a patrol corridor forming along your current projection."

Mosby nudged the controls. "Got it."

On the edge of the scope, a new string of military transponders blinked into being, sliding into organized positions around the wreckage zone. Rescue had become security.

Sael saw it too. "They're locking it down."

"Yeah," Mosby said. "And we don't want to be inside the lock."

The Star rolled gently, altering course by a margin small enough that no automated traffic system would flag it as evasive. Just another tired freighter correcting drift. Inside, the ship felt smaller as Mosby powered down noncritical sections at Ted's prompting. Lights faded aft. The Farther Star shrank into herself to conserve strength.

"We should rest in shifts," Sael said.

"Soon," Mosby replied. "Let's get clear of the main sensor cones first."

Minutes stretched into an hour. The system's inner glow dimmed behind them as they climbed into a higher orbital band, traffic thinning to scattered long-haul freighters and automated tankers running deep loops. Ted's voice came less frequently now, but it came.

"Vector correction in six minutes."

"Reduce thrust for thermal balance."

"Maintain attitude. Do not yaw further."

Sael studied the starfield ahead, the emptier dark that always looked honest until you learned what lived in it. "How do you know this place still exists?" she asked.

A pause, long enough to feel like pain.

"Because things like it rarely die," Ted said. "They become... unofficial."

Mosby snorted. “That’s one word for it.”

Another quiet stretch passed—quiet the way a room is quiet when everyone is listening to the same distant noise and pretending they aren’t. Sael’s hands rested on the console exactly where they always did—neat, controlled, professional—but they weren’t doing anything. Not even hovering.

“When I saw the liner,” she said suddenly.

Both of them turned.

“I recognized it,” she went on, and her voice stayed level in a way that didn’t quite hold. “The configuration. The window bands. I’ve been on ships like that. Families take those routes. Children.”

She swallowed once, a small, tight motion.

“I keep thinking... if we’d been ten seconds slower. If Mosby hadn’t pushed the Star the way he did. If Ted hadn’t felt the pattern before the instruments did—” Her voice faltered. Not broke. Faltered. “And I keep seeing the windows,” she finished. “Not when it broke. Before. When it was still a ship.”

Then she stopped talking. Not as a choice. As if the sentence had simply run out of strength.

For a long moment no one filled the space. The Farther Star drifted on, systems whispering, hull still radiating residual heat. Outside, the broken geometry of the gate had faded into distance, but not into irrelevance.

Mosby didn’t rush her. He rested one hand on the console edge, grounding himself before he spoke.

“You didn’t cause that,” he said—not gentle, not harsh. Certain.

Sael shook her head once. “I was part of what brought us there.”

“So was I,” Mosby said. “So was Ted. So were a thousand captains who trusted that gate.”

The intercom clicked softly before Ted spoke. “Responsibility is not the same as causation,” he said. “They diverge more often than most people are comfortable admitting.”

Sael let out a breath she’d been holding since the corridor came apart. It wasn’t a sob. It wasn’t even loud.

It was just... tired.

For a while after that, no one spoke.

The Farther Star held her shallow burn, limping outward in a profile so unremarkable it bordered on invisible. Behind them, Dawnreach continued to flicker against the inner system like a wound that refused to close. Patrol geometries tightened. Rescue lanes hardened into cordons. The official story would already be forming.

Ahead, the stars thinned.

Somewhere in that dark lay a structure that did not officially exist—an old logistics node turned unofficial harbor, if Ted’s memory and hope were still aligned. It would not appear on public traffic maps. It would not advertise docking clearance. It would not welcome trouble.

And they were bringing trouble with them.

Mosby kept his eyes on the forward display, hands steady on the controls as the Star crept deeper into unclaimed space. Whatever waited at the end of that slow burn—repair, refuge, or another trap—they would meet it without a beacon and without permission.

The Farther Star slipped farther from the light.

Chapter Kelpoint (Revised — changes in bold)

Ahead, a faint blip appeared on the long-range scope — too small for a station, too stationary for debris.

Mosby leaned forward. “That it?”

Ted took a moment to answer. “Yes,” he said. “That is it.”

The facility resolved slowly as they closed distance — not a gleaming port, not a beacon of traffic, but a dark lattice of old trusses and mismatched modules tucked into the shadow of a dead comm buoy. No running lights. No broadcast.

Just presence.

Sael watched it grow on the display, shoulders drawn slightly inward now, as if bracing against something she could finally feel. “This is where we’re going to hide?” she asked.

“For a little while,” Mosby said.

The Farther Star crawled toward the forgotten structure on thrusters alone, her scarred hull reflecting faint starlight while her systems whispered their strain and bled fuel into the void. The station didn’t look abandoned. It looked tired. Long docking arms jutted from a central spindle like broken fingers. Sections of the outer ring were dark, hull plating patched in mismatched panels that didn’t quite line up. Old company markings — gas mining consortium logos, Kestrel-

Morrow among them, half-burned away — ghosted the metal in pale scars. A few lights burned. Not many. **Even those looked like they were lit out of habit, not confidence.**

“Getting transponder pings,” Sael said, leaning over her display. Her voice was steadier now. Not because the weight was gone — but because she had accepted it. “Short range. Low power. Civilian.”

Mosby nodded. “Good.”

Ted’s voice came again, not through the intercom this time but from behind them in the cockpit, quieter now. “Tired places often understand tired ships.”

Sael didn’t reply. But for the first time since the gate, her hands moved again — purposeful, precise — and that mattered more than anything she could have said.

Mosby muttered, more to himself than either of them, “Good. Means someone’s home.”

Ted leaned forward, eyes narrowed at the passive returns. “They are observing us. No weapons lock. No organized traffic control.”

“Translation?” Mosby asked.

“They are deciding whether we are trouble.”

Mosby huffed softly. “Fair.”

He eased the Star closer, fighting the slow tumble still lurking in her mass distribution. The ship answered sluggishly, attitude jets firing in uneven pulses; every correction cost fuel they didn’t really have. **He flew like a man balancing a cup he couldn’t afford to spill.**

“Open channel,” he said.

Sael keyed the transmitter. “Station traffic, this is independent trader Farther Star. We’re in need of temporary berth and minor assistance. No hazardous cargo. No passengers. We can compensate with supplies or services.”

Static filled the cockpit for a long breath.

Then a voice came through, older, roughened by recycled air and long years. “Trader, you look like you got into a fight with a gate and lost.”

Mosby allowed himself the faintest smile. “Feels about right.”

A pause. Quiet voices in the background.

“You armed?” the voice asked.

“Sidearms,” Mosby said. “Standard. Nothing heavy.”

Another pause. Longer this time.

“You leak anything that’ll poison us?”

“Not if I can help it,” Mosby said. “We’re nursing a bad fuel tank. That’s about it.”

More muffled discussion.

Finally: “Docking arm six. Slow. Real slow. We don’t have the parts to fix what you break.”

Mosby let out a breath he hadn’t realized he’d been holding. “Appreciate it.”

“Don’t,” the voice said. “We’re not doing this for you.”

The channel cut.

Sael glanced sideways at Mosby. “Encouraging.”

“Means they’re honest,” he said. “I’ll take that.”

Docking arm six extended in fits and starts, guidance lights flickering uncertainly. It took two attempts to get the alignment right. On the third, the docking collar met the Star’s scarred flank with a dull, hollow clunk that traveled through the hull like a tired concession.

Seals took longer than they should have. When the pressure light finally shifted from amber to green, the cockpit felt quieter than it had since the disaster.

“Atmosphere on the other side,” Sael said.

Ted lowered himself carefully into the copilot’s seat, movements stiff. “I would prefer not to return to the autodoc immediately,” he said.

Mosby shot him a look. “You just got stitched back together.”

“Yes,” Ted said. “Which is why I would like to remain that way.”

Sael almost smiled despite everything. “You’re not walking alone.”

“I am not,” Ted agreed.

Mosby powered down non-essentials, leaving the Star on a low, watchful hum. For a moment he just sat there, hands resting on the controls, as if the stillness itself were something he did not entirely trust. Then he stood.

“Alright,” he said quietly. “Let’s go meet the neighbors.”

The cargo ramp lowered with a tired whine. Cold station air spilled into the bay — dry, metallic, carrying the faint smell of old machinery and recycled life support. Not unpleasant. Just... worn. **It smelled like something that had been repaired too many times and still hadn’t been forgiven.**

They stepped down together.

They weren’t met by guards.

They were met by people.

A loose semicircle had formed beyond the docking collar — two dozen figures in patched suits and work clothes, some with tools still in their hands, others leaning on crates or railings. Thin faces. Weathered expressions. Eyes that had learned to measure strangers fast.

No one spoke at first.

They took in the Star’s scorched hull, the missing paint, the scar along her flank where metal had been replaced with something that only vaguely resembled original plating. Then they looked at Mosby, Sael, and Ted, and Sael felt the assessment settle on her skin like grit.

She saw the children first — only three of them — standing close behind an older woman with a respirator hanging loose around her neck. One of the kids stared openly at the Star like it was a myth come to life.

Mosby raised one empty hand, slow and visible. “Afternoon,” he said. “Didn’t mean to drop in uninvited. We’re running on fumes and bad luck. Figured we’d try knocking instead of drifting.”

A murmur passed through the group — not unfriendly, not welcoming. Just... measuring.

Then someone stepped forward.

He was broad-shouldered once, though time had taken some of that. Gray threaded through his beard, and the patch on his sleeve still bore the faded insignia of a gas extraction company long gone. His left leg moved stiffly, old injury or bad surgery. Authority without a uniform.

He stopped ten meters from them and planted his boots.

“I’m Hardin,” he said. “Welcome to Kelpoint Processing Station. Or what’s left of it.”

His voice was steady, not loud — the kind of voice used to being listened to in small, serious rooms. “This station doesn’t get visitors unless something’s gone very wrong.”

Mosby nodded once. “Mosby. Captain of the Farther Star. And yeah... that sounds about right.”

Hardin's eyes flicked to Ted, then Sael, then back to Mosby. "You armed?"

"Sidearms on the ship," Mosby said. "Didn't seem polite to come out carrying."

That earned the faintest shift in the crowd — tension easing by a hair.

Hardin's gaze lingered on the Star again. "You look like you came through the gate mess."

Mosby didn't answer immediately. "We were in the neighborhood," he said at last.

Hardin held his eyes, weighing the half-truth, then looked past them toward the open cargo bay. "What do you want?"

"Time," Mosby said. "Docking. Maybe a few parts if you've got scrap that still remembers what it used to be. We can trade."

Hardin's expression didn't change. "Trade what?"

"Food," Mosby said first. "Nothing fancy. But it's sealed, shelf-stable, and not protein paste pretending to be something else." He jerked a thumb back toward the Star. "Medical consumables. Filters. Nutrient packs. A few crates of things that are small enough to be ignored on a manifest and valuable enough to matter when you don't have them."

A murmur passed through the group — quieter this time, sharper. Not hope. Calculation.

"Also work," Mosby added. "We fix things. Haul things. Lift heavy stuff that doesn't want to move anymore. And we don't ask why it broke in the first place."

A few heads tilted at that. Practical. Useful. Still not enough. People here already knew how to work. They'd been doing it without help for a long time, and the kinds of help that arrived from outside usually came with strings.

Sael wasn't looking at Hardin anymore.

She was looking past him.

At the woman with the loose respirator whose hands shook when she adjusted the seal. At a man with a collarbone that had healed wrong and never been corrected. At a boy trying very hard not to limp. At the gray in too many faces that should still have had color.

Twenty-seven people, she counted without meaning to.

Maybe fewer in full health.

This wasn't a crew.

This was what was left.

“We have an autodoc,” she said.

The word didn’t echo.

It moved.

Like a pressure change. Like something everyone felt at once and no one wanted to believe too quickly.

Hardin’s eyes snapped back to her. “You actually mean that?”

“Full diagnostic and treatment capacity,” Sael said, voice steady because it had to be. “Surgical assist. Infection control. Bone alignment. Internal repair. We don’t have infinite supplies—” she didn’t soften that, didn’t dress it up “—but we can help.”

She heard herself say it and understood, with a calm that felt almost separate from her body, what she was spending. Each treatment would be a choice; each choice would make leaving easier for them and harder for her. **And once you started healing strangers, you didn’t get to pretend you’d only stopped for fuel.**

Someone inhaled sharply behind Hardin. The woman with the respirator took a step forward before she seemed to realize she had moved.

Hardin didn’t look at her. He kept his eyes on Sael, searching now, not for leverage, but for cost.

“You’d do that,” he said. Not a question. A test.

Sael nodded once. “Yes.”

Mosby glanced at her, surprised, but not objecting. He’d seen that look before — the one that had nothing to do with orders.

Hardin studied the three of them for a long moment. Then he jerked his chin toward the ship.

“Let’s see who needs that machine of yours first.”

He paused, eyes narrowing slightly.

“And if this is a lie,” he added, letting the words hang between them.

Mosby gave a short nod. “Fair.”

The crowd didn’t part so much as shift, a narrow path opening through patched coats and worn boots.

That was when Ted went very still.

Sael felt it beside her — not fear, not pain.

Recognition.

From near the back of the group, someone moved forward slowly, leaning on a narrow metal cane that had been repaired so many times it was more weld than original structure.

She was Talari.

Age showed differently on her kind, but it was there all the same — in the slight tremor of her upper limbs, in the faded vibrancy of the markings along her throat and hands. The patterns, once sharp and intricate, had softened with time, like ink left too long beneath unforgiving suns.

Her eyes fixed on Ted.

Not curious.

Hungry.

Ted stepped forward before Mosby or Sael could speak.

“Elder,” he said softly.

His voice had changed. The cadence was deeper, the resonance fuller — formal in a way neither of them had ever heard from him before.

The old Talari made a faint sound, somewhere between a breath and a laugh. “It has been a long time,” she said. Her voice carried a subtle harmonic underlayer, the sound of someone unused to speaking her own language aloud. “I had begun to think I would not see another of my people again.”

Ted inclined his head, a gesture Sael now recognized as respect.

“I am—”

He spoke his name in full, the sound hanging in the air like a remembered chord.

“But Ted will serve,” he added. “I did not know anyone remained here.”

“Nor did I,” she replied.

Her gaze shifted briefly to Mosby and Sael, then back to Ted. Something in her posture eased — not fully, but enough.

She turned her head slightly toward Hardin.

“They are not here to take,” she said. “They are... frayed. Like us.”

Hardin studied her for a moment, then nodded once. Whatever history lay between them, he trusted her judgment.

“Alright,” he said. “We start with the sick and the broken. Then we talk trade.”

Sael exhaled quietly. She hadn’t realized how tight her chest had been.

Ted stepped closer to the old Talari, lowering his voice. “You have been without exchange,” he said gently.

“For too long,” she replied.

Sael didn’t understand the full meaning, but she saw what it did to Ted — the subtle straightening, the return of a steadiness he’d been forcing since the disaster. For the first time since the gate collapsed, he didn’t look alone.

The old Talari studied him another moment, then inclined her head with quiet formality.

“My name is Rheva,” she said, using the simplified cadence meant for human tongues. “Once of the Third Weft. Now... of here.”

The last words held no self-pity.

Only fact.

“Ted,” Mosby said gently, stepping in beside them, “you wanna translate that for us, or is this one of those we’ll explain later moments?”

Ted kept his gaze on Rheva. “It means she has been separated from her people for a very long time,” he said. “Long enough that the patterns of shared memory... fade.”

Rheva’s eyes softened slightly. “We do not do well alone,” she said. “We remember together.”

Sael glanced between them, something tightening in her throat. “You haven’t seen another Talari in all this time?”

Rheva made a small motion that might have been a shrug. “Ships pass. They do not stop. Or they stop, and leave quickly.”

Her gaze flicked to the Farther Star’s scarred hull. “You look like you do not have the luxury of leaving quickly.”

A faint ripple of dry humor moved through the nearby listeners. Even Hardin's mouth twitched.

Mosby spread his hands. "We specialize in poor timing."

Hardin grunted. "Good. You'll fit right in."

He turned toward the inner corridor. "Autodoc first. Then we talk about what you need — and what we can spare."

Rheva lingered beside Ted as the others began to move.

"You carry noise," she said quietly, eyes half-lidded. "Pain. Shock. But also... threads that do not belong only to you."

Ted went still for a fraction of a second, then inclined his head.

"Yes," he said simply.

She studied him once more, then nodded as if confirming something to herself.

"Good," she said. "Then perhaps we are not finished yet."

Sael didn't know what that meant, but she felt it settle into the air between them — not hope exactly, but something that hadn't been there before.

Hardin clapped his hands once, the sound sharp in the worn corridor.

"Alright," he said. "If we're doing this, we do it before my people start pretending they're not lining up already."

They were.

Word had spread fast. By the time they reached the docking collar, a loose cluster had formed in the passageway — men and women trying to look casual, older folks leaning on rails, three children pressed close together near the bulkhead. **They stood like people waiting for news they'd trained themselves not to expect.**

Sael stopped short. "We can't bring the autodoc out," she said. "But we have a field scanner."

Ted paused at the foot of the ramp, breathing a little too carefully. **His pride got him halfway up before his ribs reminded him he was not metal.** Sael caught his elbow.

"I'll get it," she said.

He started to protest; Mosby cut him off with a look.

Sael went up into the Star and returned a moment later with a hardened case about the size of a small suitcase, setting it down carefully on a cargo crate. The lid opened with a soft click, revealing a compact array of articulated sensors and a palm-sized interface panel.

Hardin eyed it. “That thing actually do anything?”

Sael knelt beside it. “Vitals, internal imaging, fracture mapping, infection detection. It tells us who needs real treatment first.”

“And the real treatment?” Hardin asked.

“On the ship,” Mosby said. “One at a time.”

Hardin nodded once. “We’ll keep them moving.”

The first patient was the woman with the respirator. She waved off help, stubborn, until Sael guided her gently to sit on a crate. The scanner’s arms unfolded with a faint mechanical whisper, passing slow bands of light across her chest and neck.

Numbers flickered across the display.

“Chronic lung scarring,” Sael said quietly. “Low oxygen saturation. We can help, but she needs the autodoc.”

Hardin didn’t hesitate. “You heard her,” he said, gesturing to two nearby men. “Careful. Don’t make her regret this.”

Sael directed the men as they helped the woman up the ramp into the Star, moving like they were handling something fragile and valuable.

Mosby looked away.

After that it became a rhythm: scan, decide, move. Some people only needed antibiotics or splints. Those stayed. Others were scheduled by need, and when their turn came they were escorted up the ramp into the Farther Star’s med-bay. The crowd didn’t talk much. They only watched. Not with gratitude, but with something closer to disbelief — **as if the whole arrangement might evaporate if anyone named it too loudly.**

A boy went next because his grandmother pushed him forward and refused to meet Sael’s eyes. The scanner hummed softly over his leg.

“Hairline fracture,” Sael said gently. “Old. Healed wrong. That’s why it hurts.”

The grandmother’s hands trembled. “Can you fix it?”

“We can try,” Sael said, and meant it.

Further down the corridor one of the children edged closer, staring at the glowing bands of light like it was something out of a story. Sael caught the look and softened her voice.

“You next,” she said gently.

The kid didn’t smile.

But he stepped forward.

Mosby slipped back onto the ship while the line continued. He returned a few minutes later carrying a sealed case and lowered it onto the deck. The crate had no branding, no slogans, but was clearly marked: food.

No announcement followed. Curious, several came forward and opened it. Someone cracked a package open.

The smell carried — warm protein, preserved vegetables, something spiced enough to feel intentional. Real.

That changed the room. A woman reached out, hesitated, then took one pack and stepped back as if afraid it might vanish if she moved too quickly. Others followed, careful and restrained, people used to scarcity.

Sael watched the food disappear into hands that tried not to shake, and felt the practical trap of it close another notch. You could treat a stranger and still leave; you could feed a starving station and pretend it was only trade, but the memory of it would travel with you either way. **And it would travel with them, too — which meant it could be used against the station as easily as it could be remembered as mercy.**

Hardin watched it happen, jaw tightening just a little. “You didn’t say you were carrying this.”

Mosby shrugged. “Didn’t think it needed selling.”

Behind them, the low hum inside the Farther Star shifted pitch as external power came online. Indicator lights along the cargo bay bulkhead flickered from amber to steady green.

Ted, standing just inside the ramp now, glanced up toward the ceiling, listening. “They have given us station power,” he said. “Crude, but stable.”

Mosby nodded. “Good. Means we’re not draining what little we’ve got left.”

Ted’s gaze shifted to Sael, then the scanner. “Continue triage,” he said. “I will begin evaluating the damage.”

“You’re supposed to be recovering,” Sael said.

Ted tilted his head slightly. “This is how I recover.”

Rheva made a soft, approving sound beside him. “Purpose is a form of repair.”

Mosby jerked a thumb toward the ramp. “Don’t wander too far. I’d like the ship to still be here when we’re done.”

Ted’s eyes flicked toward the station conduit running along the docking collar. “I will not go far. The ship’s systems are... distressed.”

“That’s one word for it,” Mosby muttered.

Ted moved back up the ramp, one hand trailing along the scarred bulkhead as if reacquainting himself with an old friend. Once inside, he paused at a wall panel and opened it, exposing a tangle of patched conduits and temporary bypasses. He stood there a moment, listening to the Star’s internal rhythms through the metal.

Then he began to work.

Outside, the line of patients thinned slowly. Those needing full treatment disappeared into the ship one at a time, returning later quieter, steadier, disbelief replaced by cautious relief. Hardin watched it all with his arms folded, jaw tight.

“You keep this up,” he said quietly to Mosby, “my people are going to start thinking you’re the best thing that’s happened to this station in ten years.”

Mosby didn’t look at him. “We’re feeling the same about you folks here.”

Hardin huffed, not quite a laugh. “That’s because you haven’t tried to fix our water recyclers yet.”

Mosby glanced toward the open ramp, where another patient was being helped inside. “Give us a day,” he said. “We’ll disappoint you.”

Hardin’s expression softened by a fraction. “Good,” he said. “Wouldn’t trust you if you didn’t.”

He pushed off the bulkhead and turned back toward the remaining cluster of watchers. “Alright, that’s enough standing around. If you’re not sick, you’re working. Same as always.”

The corridor began to break apart, motion returning in slow, practical currents. Tools got picked up. Panels opened. Someone dragged a cart of scrap past the docking arm. **Somewhere deeper in the station a motor kicked, coughed, and decided — grudgingly — to keep living.**

Over the next hour the Star settled deeper into her berth, umbilicals locking home with tired clanks as station power bled into her systems. The hum aboard shifted — less strained, less desperate — like a runner finally allowed to lean against a wall.

Ted was already half-disassembled into the guts of engineering when Mosby climbed down from the cockpit.

“Dockside power is dirty,” Ted called without looking up. “But within tolerance. I am rebalancing load so we do not cook anything important.”

“Appreciated,” Mosby said. “How bad are we?”

A pause. Tools clinked.

“We are alive,” Ted replied. “Which is not the same thing.”

Mosby snorted softly. “Story of the week.”

Hardin was waiting near docking arm six, leaning against a battered tug whose paint had once been orange and now mostly remembered the idea of it. **Two stationers stood with him — already suited, already tired, already committed.**

Mosby nodded toward them. “Where you need me?”

“Salvage tug is going out,” one of the stationers said. “With what happened we have more work than people. We have to get what we can while we can.”

Mosby nodded once. **He didn’t look back at the ramp; he didn’t trust himself to.** He followed Hardin toward the airlock.

“You ever run recovery?” Hardin asked without preamble.

Mosby looked the tug over. External grapples. Patchwork thrusters. A cockpit blister that had been replaced with something from an entirely different ship class.

“Not pretty recovery,” Mosby said. “But yeah.”

Hardin jerked his head toward the airlock. “We’ve got word of a shuttle still drifting from the gate mess. Life signs faded, but not gone last sweep. Tug’s slow, but she’ll get there.”

Mosby didn’t hesitate. “Let’s go.”

The tug smelled like old coolant and recycled air that had given up trying to be fresh. Two other stationers were already strapped in — a woman with oil-blackened hands and a teenager whose boots didn’t quite fit.

They didn’t ask Mosby who he was. They just handed him a tether line and pointed at a console that had to be coaxed into life with a slap.

Out in the debris field, the stars were broken by drifting wreckage — twisted cargo frames, fragments of hull plating, a child's plastic toy tumbling end over end. **The toy spun without end, as if the universe had forgotten what it was for.**

The shuttle came into view half an hour later, one side peeled open like a bad memory.

“Easy,” Mosby murmured, guiding the tug in while the others worked the grapples.

Inside, they found three survivors.

One conscious. Two not.

Nobody cheered when they sealed the hatch and turned back for the station.

They just worked.

It was later — after the Star's loads had been stabilized, after the last patient scheduled for that shift had been guided into the med-bay — that Rheva returned to the edge of engineering and watched Ted work.

He was careful with his movements, not because he feared pain, but because he respected it. Every twist and reach was economical, as if waste were a kind of sin.

Rheva stood for a long moment without speaking. When she finally did, her voice stayed low enough that it did not invite an audience.

“You have bound your ship to theirs,” she said. “Now they will ask what they have not asked in a long time.”

Ted didn't look up. “They have already asked.”

“Not with words,” Rheva said. “With eyes.”

Ted's claws paused on a coupling. He inclined his head, the smallest admission.

Rheva's gaze drifted to the station conduit beyond the docking collar. The insulation was old. The patchwork repairs were not mistakes; they were survival.

“Kelpoint is thin,” she said. “If certain systems fail, there will be no second attempt.”

Ted's eye ridges twitched. “Which systems.”

Rheva made a faint sound that might have been humor, if there had been any ease left in it. “The ones that keep breath in lungs and water in pipes.”

Ted closed the panel he was in, not with resignation, but with decision. “If Hardin permits.”

Rheva's markings shifted subtly as she turned. "He already has."

Ted went to Hardin anyway, because that was what respect looked like when you meant it. Hardin listened without changing expression, then nodded once, the nod of a man who did not waste words when agreement was already the only sensible thing left.

"Do what you can," he said. "Don't break what we can't replace."

Ted inclined his head. "I will be careful."

Hardin's gaze flicked, briefly, toward the Farther Star. "You already have been."

Ted worked for sixteen straight hours.

Station schematics were a palimpsest of dead corporations and stubborn survivors — original layouts overwritten by a decade of improvisation. He patched a failing life-support recycler in one compartment, rerouted power around a burned conduit in another, rebuilt a magnetic latch assembly using three parts that had never belonged together and one that had been holding a door closed with hope.

Rheva remained nearby, watching in a silence that wasn't quite silence — low clicks and subharmonic tones passing between them in Talari cadence. Not instruction. Not supervision.

Witness.

By the time Ted turned his attention back to the Farther Star, the station cycle lights had dimmed twice.

He opened the fuel diagnostics out of habit, not concern.

The Helion Salt registers were clean. Containment stable. No radiation bloom. No contamination residue from the overburn.

The Kryseum system feeding the maneuvering drives was not as fortunate.

Ted traced the diagnostics along the fuel cells—where the Kryseum rested in its dense, obedient state until energized, when magnetic fields coaxed it into flow—and followed the distribution paths toward the port thruster cluster. Halfway through the trace his hands slowed, then stopped, as if the interface had resisted him.

The containment mesh showed fractures.

Not a gross breach. Not yet. A hairline discontinuity along the edge of a magnetic seam, the kind of defect a system could live with right up until the moment it could not. The stabilization coils were already compensating, flexing in constant micro-adjustments too small to trip alarms and too patient to be mistaken for danger.

But the defect was real, and it was not sealed.

Under load, Kryseum would begin to vaporize at the margins, bleeding out in quantities the system would insist were tolerable. Ted knew better. He pulled the projected stress curves forward—hard maneuvering, evasive thrust, atmospheric insertion—and watched the compensations multiply until the graph became less a line than a slow insistence toward failure.

In vacuum it would be inconvenient: loss of efficiency, reduced control, a ship that no longer answered cleanly. In atmosphere it would be catastrophic, because there was no graceful way for that kind of blue fire to fail.

Ted ran the analysis again. Then again, stripping assumptions, isolating variables, forcing the system to justify itself as if it might be shamed into honesty.

The answer did not change.

When Mosby returned from salvage—exhausted, suit streaked with vacuum dust and old paint—Ted was waiting at the foot of the ramp. **He had cleaned his hands. He had not cleaned the look in his eyes.**

“We have a complication,” Ted said.

Mosby closed his eyes for a moment. Not in frustration. In preparation.

“Of course we do.”

“The Kryseum tank feeding the port maneuvering cluster has developed microfractures in its field containment,” Ted said. “It will function for controlled thrust in deep space.”

Mosby opened his eyes. “Define controlled.”

Ted’s eye ridges twitched. “We can reach Ael-Ruun.”

“And after that?”

Ted did not answer immediately, and in that pause Mosby heard what the words had not yet said. He exhaled slowly.

“Say it.”

Ted’s voice stayed quiet, careful. “Blue burns quietly,” he said, “until it does not.”

Mosby nodded once. “So we might get there.”

“Yes.”

“But lifting off again...”

Ted inclined his head. “Uncertain in atmosphere. Probability of catastrophic failure is high.”

Sael, standing just inside the cargo bay hatch, asked the question the way she might have asked about spare parts. “Can we fix it?”

“The containment tank requires facilities not present,” Ted said. “A complete replacement would be preferable.”

“Could we add another tank?” Sael asked. “Carry it in the cargo hold. Use that instead.”

Ted returned his gaze to the diagnostics, as if the machine itself deserved the courtesy of his refusal. “I would prefer not to die inside a solvent vapor cloud.”

Mosby scratched the back of his neck. “Fair.”

Hardin, who had been listening from a short distance away, shifted his weight, as if deciding whether to offer help or simply admit the shape of the world.

“We don’t carry them inside,” he said. “Not if we can help it.”

They all looked at him.

“When our tugs run long-range salvage,” Hardin continued, “sometimes farther than they were ever meant to go, we bolt an auxiliary Kryseum tank to the outside. Separate containment. Independent feed.” He gestured vaguely, like someone who had welded the solution together more than once. “Transfer line runs external. Ugly. Slow. But it keeps the bad stuff out of the hull.”

Ted turned slightly now, attention fully engaged. “You isolate the flow until transfer?”

“Always,” Hardin said. “Vacuum does the forgiving. Hulls don’t.”

Mosby exhaled through his nose. “You’re saying we could carry fuel without carrying the risk.”

Hardin nodded once. “You’d still be gambling,” he said. “Just not inside your ship.”

Silence followed—not doubt, but calculation.

Ted inclined his head. “This reduces the probability of immediate catastrophic failure,” he said. “It does not remove it.”

Mosby glanced at Sael. “Story of our week.”

Sael didn’t smile. “We wouldn’t be stealth anymore. Not like this.”

“No,” Mosby agreed quietly. “Not even close.” He looked back at the schematic, at the ghosted outline of external tanks riding the Star’s spine. “We’d have to fly careful. Stay out of the main lanes. Keep the tanks pointed away from anyone who might take an interest.”

Hardin snorted softly. “Anything bolted outside a ship looks like something worth asking questions about.”

“I don’t think we have a choice,” Mosby said. “Can we take a look at these tanks?”

The tanks were attached outside a neglected maintenance spur—massive industrial cylinders that had once fed mining rigs large enough to make asteroids flinch. The pumps and piping were a hodgepodge of salvage parts and improvisation.

“Ugly,” Mosby said. “But they’ll hold.”

Ted studied the tank’s structure, eyes unfocusing as he modeled stress paths and field interactions. “Three would suffice,” he said. “Four would provide margin.”

“And how do we fill them?” Mosby asked.

Hardin jerked his chin toward the outer lanes. “Couple of tugs. They’re already running rescue and cleanup. Nobody questions a ship dragging wreckage and bodies.”

He paused, then added, “They make one more stop at a depot on the way back. Bring what they can. Bolt these on and pray nobody looks too hard.”

Sael stared at the tanks. She could already see the silhouette of the ship they would become — less a trader now, more a question mark moving through space with its answer strapped to the outside. **And she could see the part no one was saying: if the patrols decided to look hard, Kelpoint would pay for it first.**

“That’s... insane,” she said.

Hardin gave her a sideways look. “Welcome to survival.”

Ted’s claws traced an invisible schematic in the air. “We can strap them along the dorsal spine and aft support trusses,” he said. “Tie them into a staged transfer system. Pump the Kryseum over gradually to the starboard tank once we reach Ael-Ruun.”

Mosby grimaced. “Ugly.”

“Dangerous,” Ted added.

Hardin nodded once. “Possible.”

That was enough.

So they began preparing.

CHAPTER START: The Thing Outside the Windows

Hardin was standing over a crate of stripped avionics when the stars changed.

He had a grease pencil in one hand and a half-cleaned circuit board in the other, arguing with Lira about whether the guidance wafer could be salvaged or if it was only worth its lattice-grown quantite substrate. Around them, the old logistics hub lived the way it always did—slow rotation humming through the deck plating, someone in the galley corner reheating ration bricks salvaged from a cracked freighter, two welders arguing about the bracket Ted had reinforced the night before and whether it would hold another season of stress cycles.

The “ops board” wasn’t a room. It was a section of bulkhead near the long eating tables where someone had bolted three mismatched display panels and wired them into the original sensor spine the company had abandoned when it pulled out years ago. The spine still worked—mostly. It showed traffic drift, salvage returns, hull integrity on Dock Two, and a running tally of parts worth selling once the markets stabilized.

Prices were down. That much was obvious. There was too much wreckage in orbit and too many hands pulling from it. But wreckage meant supplies—filters, regulators, intact storage cells, the occasional sealed med locker. Hardin was already thinking about what he could convince Ted to look at next. The Talari had added more life to this station in two weeks than it had seen in two years. Pumps that had been decorative now moved fluid. A cracked manifold that everyone had stepped around for months was now pressurized and humming.

He turned toward the board to mark the intake from Tug Three.

That was when he saw it.

At first he thought one of the panels had glitched. The starfield behind the docking arm cameras shimmered for a fraction of a second, like heat rising from fresh welds.

Then there was hull where there hadn’t been hull.

No approach vector. No flare. No deceleration burn.

Just mass.

Someone at the long table stopped mid-sentence. The galley unit chimed as if offended at being ignored. One of the welders swore softly.

Hardin didn’t move.

The external cameras tried to focus. The image sharpened and blurred in uneven pulses, like the optics couldn’t quite decide where the ship began. It was narrow, dark, almost elegant—if you liked your elegance predatory. Not patched. Not salvaged. Not cobbled together from three registries like everything else in this system.

Intact.

Weapon housings slid open along its flanks with mechanical precision. Not fast. Not dramatic. Just... ready.

The improvised sensor array stuttered. The classification script spat out UNKNOWN CONTACT and then tried to assign a transponder ID. It found nothing. No ping. No handshake. No broadcast challenge.

The ship did not hail.

It did not drift.

It held position beyond the docking arm as if it had always owned that patch of vacuum.

Behind Hardin, someone whispered, "That's not salvage."

No one laughed.

Hardin felt it in his gut before he let himself think it: this wasn't random traffic. This wasn't patrol. This was about the freighter docked two rings over with external tanks waiting to be bolted on and a Talari engineer who had already made too many things work.

He set the circuit board down very carefully.

"Get Mosby," he said. "And the Star's crew. Now."

He did the math the way he always did—field output versus their nonexistent shields, power density versus their patched reactors, weapon geometry versus a station built out of leftovers.

Twenty-seven souls.

Two salvage tugs currently out, hauling fuel tanks meant for the Star.

One crew member in the autodoc, nearly finished with treatment.

One freighter docked and half-fitted for a long run into empty space.

Hands that were very good at improvisation and very bad at fighting warships.

"Close the outer salvage doors," he said quietly. "Bring Tug Three in if they're within burn range. No panic calls."

"Should we challenge?" Lira asked.

Hardin looked at the display again.

The ship was close enough that he could see the way its hull swallowed the station lights. Close enough that if it fired, there would be no second decision to make.

“Challenge what?” he said, not unkindly.

The wall display blinked.

A docking request appeared in their system.

Not broadcast. Not transmitted across open bands. It simply populated the queue with the correct authorization tags, formatted to the station’s outdated protocol stack like it had been written from the inside. Whoever sent it knew exactly which modules the company had disabled before leaving—and which ones Hardin had re-enabled to keep the place alive.

Hardin felt something cold settle behind his ribs.

They hadn’t been scanned loudly.

They’d been read.

He glanced around the room—the tables, the patched bulkheads, the half-eaten meal trays, the salvage bins. This wasn’t a military outpost. It wasn’t even a real station anymore. It was a group of tired people making something livable out of catastrophe.

If he refused, what happened next would not be a negotiation.

“Cycle Dock Two,” he said.

Dock Two was the farthest working berth from the habitation cluster. The longest walk. The most bulkheads between the corvette and the people who actually lived here.

A few of the others looked at him.

“You’re letting it in?” someone asked.

“I’m not letting it do anything,” Hardin replied. “I’m making sure it doesn’t decide to.”

Outside, the docking arm extended. Its hydraulics whined louder than usual, embarrassed by their own age. The corvette adjusted by a fraction—no visible thrusters, no corrective jets—and slid into alignment with uncanny precision.

The clamps engaged.

The vibration traveled through the deck plating and into the soles of Hardin’s boots.

Only then did someone in the galley remember to breathe.

Footsteps pounded down the corridor behind him.

Mosby came in first, still in work boots, jaw tight. Sael a half-step behind followed by Ted.

“What’s up—” Mosby began.

He saw the screen.

“Oh.”

No one needed to explain it.

Hardin kept his eyes on the camera feed as the dark hull settled against patched metal.

Whatever this was about, it had not come for scrap.

The demand did not come over an open channel.

It arrived the same way the docking request had—quietly, directly, inserted into the station’s internal routing queue with the correct formatting and the correct authority tags.

HARDIN ELLIS VAR — ACTING STEWARD, LOGISTICS NODE K-27
SURRENDER CALEB MOSBY, REGISTERED MASTER OF TRADER VESSEL FARTHER STAR, AND SAEL VARENI
IR’ELISAND.

Hardin read it once.

Then again.

There was no threat appended. No countdown. No mention of weapons.

They did not need to say it.

On the wall display, the corvette remained steady beyond the docking arm. Weapon housings open. Power signatures climbing, then settling into a patient, sustainable plateau.

Mosby let out a slow breath. “Well,” he said quietly. “That’s personal.”

Sael said nothing. Her eyes moved once across the ops board—traffic drift, hull integrity, Dock Two status, the Farther Star’s outline with her racks still empty and her external pumps exposed. Calculations ran. None ended well.

“They want you,” Hardin said.

“Yeah,” Mosby replied.

Hardin didn't look at him. He looked at the room. Twenty-seven souls. Salvage bins. Half-eaten trays. The welders who had stopped arguing. The improvised bulkhead that kept the cold out.

"If I refuse," Hardin said carefully, "they don't argue. They demonstrate."

No one challenged that.

Sael folded her hands loosely behind her back. "They could have boarded already," she said. "They chose not to."

"They're making it clean," Mosby said.

Hardin's jaw tightened. This wasn't some stray patrol. He had let a damaged freighter dock. He had let them weld pumps to the hull. Bolt salvage tanks onto Dock Three. He had let trouble follow them home.

"I brought you in," Hardin said flatly.

Mosby met his eyes. "You gave us dock. Fuel. Time. That counts."

"It doesn't count against a corvette," Hardin snapped, more sharply than he intended.

Silence stretched.

The corvette's hull swallowed the station lights without reflection.

Hardin exhaled slowly, the anger draining into something steadier. "You don't step in front of this for me," he said. "You walk because you choose to."

Mosby nodded once. "I choose to."

Hardin's gaze hardened. "You'll walk from here to Dock Two. They've agreed."

Mosby's brow lifted slightly. "They did?"

The ops board blinked again.

DOCK TWO AUTHORIZATION CONFIRMED.
MOSBY AND SAEL — PROCEED ON FOOT.
NO ESCORT.

The formatting matched the first message. Integrated. Internal. As if it had always been part of the system.

Sael's gaze flicked once toward the Star's schematic—fuel racks empty, tank cradles half-welded into place, lines hanging open like veins waiting to be connected.

"They're confident," she said.

“They should be,” Hardin replied.

Ted spoke from across the room where he sat on an overturned crate, one sleeve rolled back from fresh sealant lines and still favoring his left side when he shifted.

“They are correct in their assessment,” he said calmly. “We cannot outrun them. And the station cannot withstand a demonstration.”

Hardin looked at him for a long moment. “I don’t want to hand you over,” he said. It came out rougher than he intended.

Mosby gave him a thin half-smile. “You’re not. We’re walking.”

It was a small distinction.

It mattered.

Behind them, Rheva had gone very still.

She wasn’t looking at the corvette. She was looking at the station schematic—Dock Two glowing amber, pressure doors marked in pale blue, clamp control nodes flagged in tired red.

She stepped closer to Ted.

“How much authority do they have inside our system?” she asked quietly.

“Enough,” Ted replied. “But not all.”

Hardin shot her a look.

She didn’t return it.

“If a docking arm were to experience mechanical latency,” she continued mildly, “would that be immediately traceable?”

Ted’s head tilted slightly—not confusion, not surprise. Recognition.

“Not if the fault originated in aging hydraulic relays,” he said. “Dock Two possesses several that predate the company withdrawal.”

Hardin understood then. Not the details. The direction.

“This is not a war,” he said sharply.

“No,” Rheva agreed. “It is leverage.”

Her gaze shifted to the bulkhead control cluster.

“Dock Two is the farthest functioning berth,” she said. “Between here and there are six pressure doors. Four still respond to remote override.”

Ted rose carefully this time, not fragile but aware of the stiffness in his side. He moved closer to the display. His eyes unfocused briefly—not from injury, but from that quiet Talari exchange that did not require raised voices. Data passed in glances. Timing. Load tolerances. Failure windows measured in fractions.

He nodded once.

Mosby watched without interrupting. He didn’t need the circuitry. He only needed to know something would happen if it had to.

“If something happens,” Sael said quietly, “it needs to look like it was an accident. No blowback onto the people here.”

Hardin stared at her.

“You’ve done this before,” he said.

“I’ve studied people who have,” she replied.

The ops board blinked again.

COMPLIANCE STATUS — UPDATE.

No escalation. No impatience.

Just presence.

Hardin stepped forward and keyed the response himself.

DOCK TWO CYCLING.
MOSBY AND SAEL EN ROUTE ON FOOT.
NO ADDITIONAL PERSONNEL.

The reply came almost instantly.

ACKNOWLEDGED.

Mosby adjusted his jacket as if heading into a routine inspection. “Guess we’re going for a walk.”

Sael fell into step beside him.

As they moved toward the corridor, Mosby paused long enough to murmur low to Hardin:

“Between here and Dock Two,” he said, “get your young and fast to clear people from the route. And make sure nobody stands under anything heavy.”

Hardin gave a tight nod.

He turned immediately. “Jace. Lira. Clear the corridor to Dock Two. Anyone not essential gets off the spine and into sealed compartments. Move.”

No panic. Just motion.

Behind them, Rheva was already slipping toward the maintenance access spine with a data slate in her hand.

Ted moved with her—measured, deliberate, not fully comfortable but steady.

“Friend Hardin,” he said softly, “I will require temporary access to Dock Two clamp control subroutines.”

Hardin looked at the dark hull outside the viewport.

Twenty-seven souls.

“Don’t break my station,” he said.

Ted’s expression did not change.

“I will attempt moderation.”

Down the corridor, Mosby and Sael walked toward the docking ring where the shadow ship waited.

Behind them, something quiet and deliberate had begun to move.

Mosby and Sael walked.

The corridor lights had been raised ahead of them. With only twenty-seven people aboard, clearing a path didn’t look like evacuation. It looked like neighbors stepping out of the way.

A pressure door sealed behind them with a solid, final click.

Metal rang under Mosby’s boots.

“What do you know about them?” he asked quietly.

Sael didn’t look at him. “They prefer outcomes to arguments.”

“That’s not helpful.”

“They are not a state. They are not a fleet. They are a network of aligned interests.” She kept her pace steady. “They influence markets. Infrastructure. Defense procurement. Insurance models. They do not take power publicly. They make power dependent.”

“And when dependence becomes permanent?”

“They call it stability.”

Mosby let out a breath. “And they’re here because...?”

Sael hesitated a fraction. “Because something has been disrupting their projections.”

That got his attention.

“Projections of what?”

She didn’t answer.

They reached the final stretch before Dock Two.

Two figures waited in the corridor.

They were not blocking the way. Positioned slightly to the side, as if this were a scheduled meeting in a municipal office rather than an armed corvette docked at the end of the spine.

Their clothing was structured and muted—charcoal fabric that shifted subtly with posture, tailored without visible seams. Future formalwear engineered to disappear into any room. No insignia. No weapons displayed.

They looked like senior auditors.

One inclined their head.

“Trader Caleb Mosby,” they said evenly. “Sael Vareni ir’Elisand.”

No accusation. No greeting.

“You asked for us,” Mosby said.

“Yes.”

A narrow projection pane flickered to life near the second agent’s wrist. Data scrolled—clean, sparse.

“You were present at the Dawnreach failure,” the first said.

“So were thousands of ships,” Mosby replied.

“Yes,” the agent agreed calmly. “But you were also present at Kelpoint Station three cycles prior.”

Mosby’s jaw tightened slightly.

“And within two hours of your departure,” the second agent continued, “a classified Concord inquiry team arrived. A Thalean intelligence liaison followed shortly thereafter.”

“That’s politics,” Mosby said. “Not physics.”

“Indeed,” the first replied. “And politics leaves patterns.”

Sael went still.

“In the last six standard years,” the second agent continued, “multiple intelligence services—Solarian, Thalean, independent—have mobilized rapid-response teams to sites of technological near-failure.”

“Near-failure?” Mosby said.

“Projects that approach destabilizing thresholds,” the first clarified. “Energy systems that do not scale. Materials that refuse tolerance under load. Field harmonics that collapse at deployment.”

“That happens all the time,” Mosby said.

“Not with that consistency.”

The projection pane shifted. Not images—just timing sequences.

“Each incident,” the second agent said, “appears isolated. Regulatory intervention. Funding withdrawal. Unexplained material fatigue. Personnel reassignment.”

Mosby frowned. “You’re telling me you track failed research programs.”

“We track trajectories,” the first corrected.

“And those trajectories,” the second added, “consistently bend away from cascade.”

That word again.

Mosby folded his arms. “Cascade into what?”

The agents did not answer directly.

Instead, the first said, “The previous war expanded faster than any projection supported. Escalation vectors aligned across three powers. Supply chains converged. Political barriers softened.”

Mosby stared at them. “Yeah. That’s what wars do.”

“Yes,” the agent agreed. “And then they do not stop.”

A pause.

“In that case,” the second said, “they did.”

Sael’s eyes flicked up.

Mosby’s narrowed.

“You’re saying someone ended it?” Mosby asked.

“We are saying,” the first replied carefully, “that escalation momentum exceeded survivability models. And yet collapse did not occur.”

Silence.

“You think something interfered,” Sael said quietly.

“We think,” the second replied, “that probability repeatedly resolves in favor of species continuity at specific technological inflection points.”

Mosby blinked. “That’s a long way of saying you think something keeps saving us.”

“We do not assign moral framing,” the first said. “We assign anomaly.”

“And we have reason to believe,” the second added, “that several intelligence services have noticed similar variance.”

Mosby looked at Sael now.

Properly.

“You want to explain that?” he asked.

She didn’t.

The first agent’s attention shifted to her.

“You have reviewed classified Thalean briefings,” they said. Not accusing. Stating.

Sael's posture tightened.

"Multiple retrieval attempts have failed," the second continued. "Containment scenarios collapse under improbable conditions. Investigative leads evaporate."

"We do not believe this anomaly belongs to any government," the first said. "But we believe certain actors have been closer to it than others."

"And that's why you're here?" Mosby asked.

"You were present at Dawnreach," the agent replied. "And Thalean and Concord intelligence assets were within hours of your location at Kelpoint."

Mosby's voice hardened. "You're tracking who talks to who."

"We are tracking convergence."

Sael finally spoke.

"It is not a device," she said.

Neither agent interrupted.

"It is not a research program. It is not a failed prototype." Her voice was controlled, but the edge was there now. "You are not chasing an artifact."

"Then clarify the model," the first agent said.

Mosby's gaze shifted between them. "Sael."

She ignored him.

"You attempt to force systems toward extremity," she said to the agents. "You believe collapse strengthens civilizations."

The second agent inclined their head slightly. "Stress reveals capacity."

"You cultivate cascade," she said evenly. "And something reduces it."

"We measure deviation," the first corrected.

"And you resent it."

A faint pause.

"We do not resent," the second replied. "We adapt."

Mosby's eyes flicked between them again. "Adapt to what?"

Sael held it one breath too long.

"It is not yours to accelerate," she said.

The agents did not react outwardly.

"But it has been slowing you," she continued. "For centuries."

The projection pane reappeared, silent.

"And what," the first asked, "is the name of this corrective force?"

Mosby turned to her fully now.

"Sael."

She closed her eyes for half a heartbeat.

Then opened them.

"It is called the Caretaker."

The word settled into the corridor like a weight placed carefully on a table.

No visible shock.

No triumph.

But something shifted.

A variable long described only in data now had a designation.

"That is useful," the second agent said softly.

The first regarded her with renewed precision. "Is it centralized?"

"No."

"Is it embodied?"

Mosby's head snapped toward them. "Embodied?"

Sael did not answer.

The agents' attention sharpened—not on Mosby.

On her.

“You believe it is preservational,” the first said.

“It is,” she replied.

Mosby's voice was low now. Controlled. Dangerous.

“You've known about this.”

She didn't look at him.

The second agent inclined their head once more.

“Thank you,” they said.

Not pleased.

Not gloating.

Relieved.

A statistical ghost now had a name.

And Mosby finally understood that whatever had followed them to this station had not come for scrap, or for revenge, or even for war.

It had come for a correction.

And Sael had just confirmed it existed.

Mosby did not move at first.

The corridor seemed narrower now, though nothing had changed. The overhead lights hummed. Somewhere behind the bulkhead, a pump cycled unevenly and then caught.

“You've known about this,” he said.

It was not accusation yet.

It was calculation.

Sael still did not look at him.

The first Ascendant studied her with renewed precision, as if a variable that had resisted definition had finally resolved into something measurable.

“The Caretaker,” the agent repeated, not as a question but as a catalog entry. “You assign it custodial intent.”

“I do not assign it anything,” Sael replied. “It assigns itself.”

“That is philosophically convenient,” the second agent said.

Mosby’s gaze shifted back to them. “You’re talking about it like it’s a piece of tech.”

“We are talking about it,” the first agent corrected, “as an interventionist force operating without accountability.”

Sael’s shoulders stiffened almost imperceptibly.

“Accountability to whom?” she asked.

“To consequence,” the agent replied.

There it was.

Not anger. Not fanaticism.

Conviction.

“We believe civilizations must confront the full weight of their own decisions,” the second agent continued. “When failure is prevented, growth is distorted.”

Mosby stared at them. “You’re upset something stopped a few disasters?”

“Disaster,” the first agent said evenly, “is a filtering mechanism.”

The words landed with clinical detachment.

Mosby felt the anger now, but he kept it banked. “You’re saying people dying is a feature.”

“We are saying selective pressure produces resilience.”

“And who gets selected?” Mosby asked.

The agent did not blink. “Those who endure.”

Sael finally looked at Mosby.

There was apology in it.
And something else.

Resolve.

“They believe collapse is refinement,” she said quietly. “They believe intervention weakens the species.”

Mosby’s jaw tightened.

“And you?” he asked her.

“I believe extinction is not a lesson.”

Silence settled between them again.

The agents did not seem offended.

They seemed... patient.

“We are not here to debate ideology,” the first said at last. “We are here because Solarian Concord assets and Thalean intelligence assets have repeatedly intersected with anomalous corrective events. You were present at the most recent.”

“And?” Mosby asked.

“And,” the second agent said, “the simplest explanation is that proximity is not accidental.”

They were not accusing him of wielding it.

They were accusing him of carrying it.

That was when the air changed.

Not metaphorically.

The corridor ventilation slowed for half a beat and then resumed.

An old station quirk.

Mosby had lived on enough broken platforms to recognize it.

Behind the Ascendants, a pressure door indicator shifted from steady green to flicker-amber and back again.

The agents did not turn.

But they registered it.

“Your station infrastructure appears unstable,” the first observed mildly.

“Salvage node,” Mosby said. “We don’t do polished.”

“We are prepared to escalate if necessary,” the second agent continued, as if discussing weather.
“This structure will not survive sustained engagement. Nor will its inhabitants.”

There it was.

Not shouted.

Not threatened.

Stated.

Mosby’s eyes did not leave them. “You planning to prove that?”

“If cooperation fails,” the first agent said, “we will retrieve you regardless.”

Retrieve.

Not arrest.

Not invite.

Retrieve.

Sael’s breath steadied.

“They cannot allow it to continue intervening,” she said quietly to Mosby. “Not if they believe it distorts evolutionary trajectory.”

Mosby did not look at her.

“What exactly,” he asked, voice low now, “have you been carrying into my ship?”

That was when the light above them dipped once.

Recovered.

Dipped twice more in quick succession.

To anyone else: failing ballast in a centuries-old fixture.

To Mosby: timing.

The Ascendants noticed the fluctuation.

“Environmental instability appears to be increasing,” the second agent remarked.

“Yes,” Mosby said. “Old places do that.”

He shifted his weight slightly — not retreating, not advancing — adjusting the distance between himself and Sael by half a step.

The first agent’s gaze flicked between them.

“We will not repeat the request,” they said.

And for the first time since the conversation began, there was the faintest tightening at the edges of their composure.

Not anger.

Urgency.

Somewhere deeper in the station, something heavy cycled out of sequence.

A relay misfired.

The corridor lights dimmed again — longer this time.

When they brightened, Mosby had already made his decision.

He did not answer the Ascendant.

He reached for Sael’s wrist.

And moved.

Mosby did not shout.

He pulled Sael with him and turned into the side passage just as the corridor lights dipped a third time.

Behind them, one of the Ascendants said, almost conversationally:

“That would be inadvisable.”

The first pressure door came down with a hydraulic cough.

Not a slam.

A tired, grinding descent that looked exactly like a relay timing fault in a station that had been patched too many times by too few hands.

The Ascendants moved instantly — not panicked, not scrambling — but precise.

The nearer one pivoted and slid a palm across the door seam just before it sealed. There was a brief, sharp pulse of light where skin met metal.

The door hesitated.

For a fraction of a second.

Then the opposing bulkhead at the far end of the corridor dropped.

This one did slam.

The sound reverberated through the spine like a struck bell.

The Ascendants were now between two descending pressure barriers, both moving on slightly misaligned tracks.

The first door finished closing.

The second locked with a deep mechanical thud.

Silence.

No sparks.

No alarms.

Just the distant whine of overtaxed hydraulics trying to correct for uneven load.

Inside the ops section, Hardin did not watch the camera feed.

He watched the station schematic.

Dock Two clamp control was flashing amber. Pressure rings cycling. Hydraulic latency warnings populating exactly where Ted had predicted they would.

“Seal the cross-spine,” Hardin said.

Jace already had his hand on the panel.

“Done.”

“Galley secure?”

“Secure.”

“Maintenance bay?”

“Sealed.”

Twenty-seven souls.

No one screaming.

No one running.

Just doors closing in sequence, isolating Dock Two from the rest of the habitat ring like a quarantined wound.

In the corridor, the Ascendants did not pound on the doors.

They stood still.

One of them tilted their head slightly.

“Mechanical irregularity,” the first said.

“Yes,” the second replied. “Localized.”

The wall panel beside them flickered.

Their access attempt failed.

Not because they lacked credentials.

Because the station had just fallen into an “unscheduled safety cascade.”

Power rerouted.

Authority layers dropped.

Dock Two became its own administrative island.

Plausible.

Ugly.

Entirely defensible in a salvage hub built from leftovers.

Mosby and Sael were already moving through the maintenance bypass Rheva had indicated.

The lights were lower here.

Pipes exposed.

Insulation half-replaced.

Mosby didn't slow.

"They're not going to sit there long," he said.

"No," Sael agreed.

Behind them, a low shudder traveled through the station.

Docking arm pressure spike.

Clamp strain.

Back in the control alcove, Ted's fingers moved over a cracked interface panel with surgical patience.

He wasn't rushing.

He was sequencing.

"Primary arm release... delayed by point-eight seconds," he murmured.

Rheva monitored the load graph.

"Secondary clamp?"

"Responds on schedule."

Hardin didn't look at them.

"Make it look old," he said.

"It already does," Rheva replied.

Outside, the corvette's engines came online to reposition.

The primary docking arm extended as commanded.

The secondary clamp lagged.

Not enough to look intentional.

Enough to matter.

Metal screamed.

The corvette twisted against asymmetric force.

Hull plating along its forward spine flexed, then buckled inward by centimeters, not meters.

Internal alarms would be cascading now.

Damage reports.

Structural stress.

Dock collar deformation.

No explosion.

No fireball.

Just the sickening sound of something expensive discovering it had trusted inferior hardware.

In the corridor between the sealed doors, the Ascendants felt the vibration.

The first agent closed their eyes for half a heartbeat.

"Dock arm instability," they said quietly.

"Yes," the second replied. "Unfortunate timing."

They attempted system override again.

The station's core returned:

LOCAL CONTROL FAILURE — MAINTENANCE CASCADE.

No hostility.

Just incompetence.

Mosby and Sael reached the Farther Star at a jog.

Hardin was waiting at the base of the ramp.

“You have to go,” he said.

No anger.

No ceremony.

“Two salvage tugs are inbound from shadow,” he added. “They’ll rendezvous once you clear the arm.”

Sael pressed a credit chit into his hand.

“For the fuel,” she said. “And the trouble.”

Hardin looked at it, then at her.

“You won’t need it where you’re going?”

She didn’t answer.

Ted arrived a moment later, breathing controlled, one hand braced briefly against the bulkhead before he straightened.

He looked at Rheva.

A pause passed between them — not long, not sentimental.

“You should replace the secondary pump coupler in thirty-six hours,” he said. “It will fail.”

Rheva nodded once. “Safe flight.”

There was more in that.

It did not need words.

The Farther Star lifted under low thrust.

No dramatic burn.

Just steady separation.

Behind them, Dock Two's clamp alarms were still echoing through the Ascendant corvette.

The salvage tugs drifted in beyond the station's shadow, guiding old gas tanks toward the waiting cradles.

Mosby went outside in a suit, boots locking to scarred plating, tightening straps with methodical force.

Ted supervised the fuel transfer from an access port, voice calm as he walked the tug crews through final connections.

No one waved.

No one saluted.

Just helmet nods in vacuum.

Farther out, the corvette finally broke free of the docking arm.

Not cleanly.

A fracture line ran along its forward spine where stress had exceeded tolerance.

Minor damage.

Repairable.

Humiliating.

By the time the Ascendants regained full system access, the salvage node was dark in Dock Two.

Systems nominal.

No unauthorized code detected.

No malicious entry traceable.

Just aging hydraulics.

Deferred maintenance.

Unfortunate timing.

And a freighter already disappearing into black.

The Farther Star was heavier now.

Scarred.

Lopsided.

And accelerating toward Ael-Ruun.

The jump to Ael-Ruun was long and narrow, the Farther Star riding a fragile line between distance and fuel exhaustion.

Ted lived in engineering, eyes on the transfer readouts, coaxing the borrowed tanks into behaving like they belonged there.

Sael spent most of the time pretending to review data she wasn't really seeing.

Mosby flew.

They spoke when necessary.

Course adjustments. System checks. Fuel margins.

Nothing else.

Twice, Sael started to say something.

Twice, Mosby answered a question she hadn't asked yet.

The third time, she tried anyway.

"Mosby..."

He didn't look at her. "We're on a tight burn."

"I know. I just—"

"We'll talk when we're not balancing on fumes and borrowed metal."

It wasn't anger.

It was postponement.

Which somehow hurt more.

Sael settled back into her seat and watched the distorted starlight slide past, feeling the distance between them stretch wider than the jump itself.

The Farther Star dropped out of transit on the ragged edge of the Ael-Ruun system, drives shuddering as realspace reasserted itself.

Before the distortion haze had fully cleared from the forward screens, Ted's voice came over the internal channel.

"Beginning fuel transfer."

Mosby didn't look away from the flight display. "Already?"

"The external tanks are not designed for extended storage under thermal stress," Ted said. "Neither, at the moment, are we."

Fair.

Outside, the jury-rigged lines running along the Star's hull came alive, pumps cycling up with a low, uneven vibration that traveled through the frame like distant machinery waking from a long sleep.

On the engineering board, new indicators bloomed to life — transfer pressure, line temperature, containment stability. Numbers that mattered more than almost anything else right now.

Sael watched the flow rate climb. "How long?"

"Forty-three minutes for primary transfer," Ted replied. "Assuming nothing ruptures, crystallizes, or decides to behave creatively."

Mosby snorted softly. "Aim high."

The Star coasted in cold and quiet, presenting as little drive signature as possible while Ted coaxed volatile fuel through hardware that had never been meant to carry it.

Every liter that made it inside was distance.

Every spike in pressure was a reminder of how thin their margin really was.

"Flow is stable," Ted said after a long stretch of silence. "For now."

Mosby nodded once, eyes still on the system map where Kethra's vast gravity well curved space like a warning. "Good," he said. "Let's not waste it."

Namar grew from a charcoal crescent into a scarred world of red-gray dust and ancient impacts, its surface pocked with craters that had never softened under weather or wind.

“No atmosphere,” Ted confirmed. “Surface pressure negligible. Radiation within acceptable limits for short exposure.”

“Comforting,” Mosby said.

They descended on a shallow vector, keeping drive output low while the last of the external fuel crept into the Star’s wounded tanks. The moon’s surface slid beneath them — broken ridgelines, collapsed mining pits, long-dead processing fields half-buried in regolith.

Then a signal reached out.

Not strong.

Not weak, either.

Careful.

Tentative.

Sael leaned over her board. “You seeing this?”

“Receiving,” Ted said. “Tight-beam transmission. Low power, but deliberate. Origin... surface-based.”

“Military?” Mosby asked.

“No,” Ted said after a moment. “Pattern irregular. Encryption old. Reused.”

“Reused how?”

“Like someone found a tool and decided it was good enough.”

Mosby adjusted their descent. “Alright. We follow.”

The signal led them toward the shadowed interior of a broad impact crater near Namar’s northern mid-latitudes. From orbit, it looked like every other wound on the surface — steep inner walls, a floor littered with ejecta and old debris.

Nothing moved.

No lights.

No visible structures.

“Are we sure this isn’t a ghost?” Sael asked.

"If it is," Mosby said, "it's a polite one."

They dipped lower, skimming the crater rim before easing down into its bowl. Dust kicked up in slow arcs beneath their maneuvering jets, drifting away in lazy, airless plumes.

That was when they saw it.

A seam in the crater wall.

Straight.

Too straight.

Half-buried by centuries of micrometeorite dust and slow collapse, a massive structure had been carved directly into the rock. Plating the color of old iron showed through where the regolith had slid away, its surface pitted but intact.

"It looks abandoned," Sael murmured.

"It looks," Mosby said, "like something that doesn't want to be noticed."

The signal strengthened as they approached, guiding them toward a section of wall that, at first glance, looked no different from the rest.

Then the rock moved.

A line appeared, then widened. Dust cascaded in slow, silent sheets as a massive door separated from the crater face and began to rise. Behind it, lights flickered on one row at a time, revealing a cavernous landing bay carved deep into the moon's crust.

It was big.

Big enough for the Farther Star to fit inside with room to spare.

Sael swallowed. "That's... not a mining shack."

"No," Mosby said quietly. "It isn't."

Ted's voice came over the channel, sharper now. "Detecting internal atmosphere. Pressure building behind the outer threshold. Composition... breathable."

Mosby glanced at him. "And the fuel?"

Ted hesitated only a fraction of a second. "Transfer must stop before we cross the pressure boundary. External lines are not rated for atmospheric exposure at current load."

"Do it," Mosby said.

Outside, the hum along the hull shifted as the pumps spun down, valves closing in careful sequence. The flow indicators froze mid-climb, leaving the Star heavier than before — but not yet full.

“Transfer paused,” Ted reported. “Remaining fuel secure. For now.”

The Farther Star drifted toward the waiting bay, scarred hull reflecting the steady interior lights. The open door yawned before them, carved from old stone and older intention.

Mosby eased the ship forward on a whisper of thrust.

“Let’s hope,” he said softly, “whoever’s home is friendlier than they are patient.”

And the Star crossed from vacuum into air.

The Farther Star settled onto the landing deck with a low, tired groan of stressed metal.

Inside the bay, the air was breathable — barely. Thin, cold, and carrying the dry, metallic taste of a system that had been running on minimum power for a very long time. Their suit sensors chimed soft cautions as the ramp lowered.

“Pressure stable,” Ted said. “Temperature... not.”

Mosby pulled his jacket tighter anyway. “Homey.”

They stepped down into the bay.

No welcoming crew.

No vehicles.

No fresh tracks in the dust that had settled in the seams of the deck plating.

The place felt less like a base and more like something left behind in a hurry — and then slowly forgotten.

Overhead lights flickered in uneven rows, some bright, some dim, some dead entirely. The far walls of the cavernous bay were lined with old equipment cradles and maintenance scaffolds, most empty, a few still holding shapes draped in gray sheeting stiff with age.

“It’s like those videos,” Sael said quietly, voice echoing more than she liked, “where people break into abandoned hospitals or factories.”

Mosby nodded once. “Yeah. Except those places don’t usually have airlocks the size of apartment buildings.”

Beyond the landing bay, a wide access corridor opened into the base proper. The walls bore old corporate stenciling, logos worn to ghosts by time and neglect. Directional arrows pointed toward sectors whose names meant nothing anymore.

Then, one by one, lights began to turn on.

Not all at once. Not bright.

Just a thin line of floor-level markers flickering to life along the corridor ahead.

A path.

Ted tilted his head, listening to something only he could hear. "Power routing is... selective," he said. "Localized activation. Someone is guiding us."

"Or herding us," Mosby muttered.

Sael glanced back toward the Star, then forward again. "We didn't come all this way to sit in the parking lot."

They moved.

Bootsteps echoed hollowly as they followed the line of dim lights deeper into the base. The air grew colder, thinner, the smell of dust and old insulation stronger the farther they went. Doors along the corridor stood half-open, revealing dark rooms filled with silent consoles and equipment frozen mid-use.

A rolling cart lay on its side in one doorway, tools spilled across the floor and never picked up.

Somewhere ahead, something hummed faintly — not machinery, not quite.

Then they heard it.

Music.

Soft.

Distant.

Tinny through old speakers, the sound warbling slightly as if the system playing it hadn't been serviced in decades.

Sael slowed. "Do you hear—"

"Yes," Ted said.

The melody drifted down the corridor toward them, gentle and almost cheerful, painfully out of place in the cold, forgotten corridors of a dead industrial moon.

Mosby didn't stop walking, but his shoulders tightened. "Well," he said quietly, "that's new."

They followed the lights.

And the music.

Deeper into the base.

They passed through another set of pressure doors, and the air changed.

Warmer. Cleaner. Carrying the faint scent of something herbal and unfamiliar.

The lights ahead weren't the dim emergency strips of the outer corridors. These were full-spectrum panels, soft and steady, casting real shadows instead of long gray smears.

And the music — it wasn't echoing anymore.

It was close.

They stepped through the final doorway.

The space beyond stopped all three of them in their tracks.

It was... lived in.

Rugs covered the metal deck, woven in patterns that looked hand-made. Real fabric, not station-issue composites. The walls were lined with shelves — not equipment racks, but books. Physical books. Spines worn, pages uneven. Between them hung framed photographs, sketches, star charts annotated by hand.

A small kitchenette hummed quietly to the right, steam curling from a mug left on the counter.

To the left, a sitting area: a low sofa, two mismatched chairs, a narrow table crowded with papers and datapads in various states of disassembly.

And at the center of it all, facing away from them, sat a high-backed chair.

For a moment, no one spoke.

Mosby's hand tightened slightly on the grip of his sidearm, though he didn't raise it.

Ted's eyes moved slowly across the room, absorbing everything.

Sael felt something she couldn't name — not fear, not relief. Recognition, maybe. Of intention.

The chair turned.

Dr. Ilyan Merrow twisted where he sat, one hand resting on the arm as he leaned to look at them around the edge. He was older than she expected, hair gone mostly silver, spectacles perched low on his nose. His clothes were comfortable, worn, patched with care rather than neglect.

He studied them for a heartbeat, gaze clear and alert.

Then he smiled — small and genuine.

“Ah,” he said, voice a little rough with disuse but warm all the same.

“Finally. Someone has arrived.”

Silence stretched.

Mosby didn’t lower his weapon. “You mind telling us who you are?”

Merrow blinked, as if surprised that needed saying.

“Of course,” he said, turning the chair fully now. “My name is Doctor Ilyan Merrow.”

His eyes flicked briefly to Sael, then to Ted, lingering there a fraction longer.

“I’ve been waiting for you.”

Sael felt the floor tilt beneath her, just slightly.

“Waiting,” Mosby repeated. “For us specifically?”

Merrow considered that, then gave a small, almost apologetic shrug.

“For someone,” he said. “But I had hoped it would be you.”

Ted stepped forward half a pace, head tilted.

“Friend Mosby,” he said quietly, “I believe this is the point at which our situation becomes... complicated.”

Merrow’s smile deepened, not unkindly.

“Oh,” he said. “It already was.”

Sael stepped forward before Mosby could speak again.

Her sidearm was still low, but her posture had changed — shoulders squared, voice steady in the way it only was when she slipped back into the habits of command.

“Doctor Merrow,” she said, “this facility is under emergency review authority of the Thalean Consular Service. I need to know what you’re doing here and what you’re guarding.”

Mosby glanced at her, just slightly.

There it was — the tone he'd heard before. The one that came out when she stopped being Sael and became something else.

Morrow didn't seem alarmed. If anything, he looked... tired.

"I live here," he said gently. "As for what I'm guarding—"

"That's not optional," Sael cut in. "We have reason to believe this site contains a classified construct of extreme strategic significance. If that's true, it needs to be transferred to secure custody immediately."

Ted's head turned toward her.

Mosby's jaw tightened.

Morrow studied her for a long moment, not offended, not defensive. Just... measuring.

"You believe it's an object," he said quietly.

Sael held his gaze. "I believe it's dangerous in the wrong hands."

"And you believe yours are the right ones."

A flicker in her expression — gone as fast as it came.

"I believe," she said carefully, "that it should be overseen by people who understand consequences."

Mosby let out a soft breath through his nose.

Morrow leaned back slightly in his chair, fingers folding together.

"I was a theoretical physicist," he said. "Specializing in gate field harmonics and exotic topology."

Mosby blinked. "You built gates?"

"I was trying to make them... faster," Morrow said. "More efficient. Reduce transit delay to near-zero across any distance."

Sael frowned. "That's not illegal."

"No," Morrow agreed. "It was catastrophic."

He looked past them, toward nothing.

"I was close. Too close. The math worked. The prototypes did not."

Ted stepped forward another half pace. "You were destabilizing spacetime boundaries."

Merrow nodded once. "I was about to succeed."

A quiet settled over the room.

"What stopped you?" Mosby asked.

Merrow looked at him. Then at Sael.

"I changed my mind."

Sael's eyes narrowed. "Just like that."

"No," he said softly. "Not like that."

He tapped two fingers lightly against his temple.

"I was... given time. Perspective. Context I did not have before."

Sael's breath caught, just slightly.

"The Caretaker," she said.

Merrow's gaze sharpened.

"Yes," he said. "That's what you call it."

Mosby looked between them. "Call what?"

Merrow's voice gentled.

"It's not a machine," he said. "Not a weapon. Not an artifact you can put in a box."

He held Sael's eyes now.

"It's a passenger."

Silence.

Sael felt the word like a physical blow.

"A... host?" she said.

Merrow nodded.

"It moves," he said. "From mind to mind. Never forcing. Only... advising. Slowing people down when they are about to do something the universe cannot survive."

Mosby stared. "You're telling me the thing the Ascendants are hunting—"

"—is a conscience," Merrow said quietly. "One that outlived the civilization that made it."

Ted's voice was almost reverent.

"My people speak of such a presence," he said. "A carried wisdom. A warning left behind."

Sael didn't look away from Merrow.

"If it's in you," she said, "then you need to come with us."

Mosby turned sharply toward her. "Sael—"

"He's not safe here," she said. "And if the Ascendants find him—"

"They won't get me," Merrow said gently.

Sael's voice tightened. "You can't be sure of that."

"I can," he said.

A quiet, knowing sadness touched his expression.

"Because it's already preparing to leave."

That stopped her.

"Leave?" she said.

Merrow nodded.

"It never stays long," he said. "Only until the crisis passes... or the next one begins."

His eyes flicked between the three of them.

"It's been waiting," he said softly.

"For someone new to listen."

The words seemed to settle into the room like dust motes in sunlight — small, almost weightless, and impossible to ignore.

No one spoke.

Sael felt her pulse in her throat.

Waiting.

For someone new.

Her gaze never left Merrow's face. "You mean... it chooses."

Merrow gave a faint, tired smile. "Not the way you're thinking."

"Then how?" she asked.

"It doesn't look for power," he said. "Or position. It looks for... inflection points. People standing where a decision might bend more than their own lives."

Mosby shifted his weight. "So it's picky."

"Very," Merrow said.

Ted's voice was quiet. "It requires a mind capable of holding contradiction without breaking."

Sael barely heard him.

"If it leaves you," she said to Merrow, "you won't have what helped you stop your research."

"That's true," he said easily. "I'll just have to live with the decision I already made."

She stared at him. "You're not afraid?"

Merrow considered that. "I was. Years ago. Now I'm mostly relieved."

Sael's jaw tightened. "Relieved."

"Yes," he said. "It's not meant to be carried forever."

Something in that struck her harder than she expected.

"You think no one should guide it," she said. "No one should direct it."

"I think," Merrow replied gently, "that the moment someone tries to control it... it stops being what it is."

Silence pressed in again.

Mosby looked at Sael, and this time there was no mistaking the question in his eyes.

Is that what you want?

She felt heat rise in her chest — not anger, not quite shame. Something more complicated.

“I’ve seen what happens when people with power don’t act,” she said, voice steady but tight. “Worlds burn. Systems collapse. Millions die because someone decided to ‘let history take its course.’”

Mosby didn’t interrupt.

Ted didn’t either.

Merrow watched her with deep, patient attention.

“If this thing can nudge events,” she continued, “slow down the worst disasters, stop the next catastrophe before it happens — how is it wrong to make sure it’s used responsibly?”

“Responsibly,” Merrow repeated softly.

“Yes.”

“And who defines that?”

Sael hesitated. Only a fraction of a second, but it was there.

“People trained to understand consequences,” she said. “People who know what’s at stake.”

“People like you,” Mosby said quietly.

She didn’t look at him.

“Yes.”

The word hung in the air.

Merrow leaned back slightly in his chair, studying her with something like sadness — but not disapproval.

“You would carry it like a command,” he said. “A mandate.”

“I would carry it like a duty.”

“That’s what I did,” he said.

Her eyes snapped back to him.

“And it nearly ended everything.”

The room felt smaller.

"I wasn't trying to destroy anything," Merrow continued gently. "I was trying to make life easier. Faster. Safer."

He met her gaze steadily.

"I was wrong."

Ted shifted, voice low. "The Caretaker does not prevent suffering. It prevents extinction."

Sael swallowed.

"That's not enough," she said.

"It has to be," Merrow replied.

A faint tremor passed through the lights overhead, so slight it might have been imagination.

Merrow's expression softened.

"It's close," Merrow said quietly.

"Close to what?" Sael asked.

"To deciding."

Sael's composure cracked a fraction.

"You're talking about letting this thing wander from mind to mind while people like the Ascendants use disasters to shape civilizations," she said. "You've seen what they do. They caused the gate collapse. Thousands of people are dead."

Merrow's head tilted.

"No," he said gently.

The word didn't land at first.

Mosby frowned. "No what?"

"The Ascendants didn't cause the gate incident," Merrow said.

Sael stared at him. "We saw their ship—"

"Yes," Merrow said. "They were there."

Her voice sharpened. "Then who—"

Merrow met her eyes.

“That was the Caretaker.”

Silence detonated in the room.

Mosby blinked. “I’m gonna need you to run that one back.”

Sael shook her head slowly. “That’s not possible.”

“It is,” Merrow said softly. “I felt it reach out from me. It touched the ship’s control systems — not directly, but through the minds guiding them. Confusion. Hesitation. Tiny errors at the worst possible moment.”

Sael stared at him. “You’re saying it made them lose control?”

“It nudged probabilities,” Merrow said. “Interfered with judgment. It was trying to stop the Ascendants’ operation before it reached a tipping point.”

Mosby’s voice went flat. “By turning a gate corridor into a graveyard.”

Merrow closed his eyes briefly. “It was trapped here. Isolated. It couldn’t move freely, couldn’t observe the whole chain of events. It saw one path leading toward something worse — something cascading beyond that system. So it acted quickly. Coarsely.”

Ted’s voice was low. “Imperfect information. Compressed timeframe.”

“Yes,” Merrow said. “It chose the disaster it believed was survivable over one it believed would not be.”

Sael felt the floor shift under her. “That’s not protection. That’s gambling with lives.”

“It is triage,” Merrow said quietly. “And triage is never clean.”

Mosby stared at the rugs at his feet. “So the Ascendants light fires on purpose...”

“...and the Caretaker sometimes sets a smaller one to stop a wildfire,” Merrow finished.

Sael’s hands curled into fists. “People died because it panicked.”

“No,” Merrow said gently. “Because it could not see enough to do better.”

Silence settled again — heavier now, edged with grief instead of mystery.

Mosby stared at the rugs at his feet.

“So the Ascendants light fires on purpose...”

“...and the Caretaker sometimes sets a smaller one to stop a wildfire,” Merrow finished.

Sael's hands curled into fists.

"People died because it panicked."

"No," Merrow said gently. "Because it could not see enough to do better."

Something in Sael went still.

Not shock. Not grief.

Alignment.

"Then it can't be left alone," she said.

Mosby looked up.

Merrow watched her carefully.

"If it's making decisions that big," she continued, voice steady now, "it needs oversight. Context. Someone who can see more than one moment in isolation."

"It already does," Merrow said softly. "It sees through the person carrying it."

"That's not enough," Sael replied. "One mind. One set of experiences. One set of blind spots."

She took a step closer — not aggressive, just certain.

"If it stays random, if it just drifts from host to host, then it's no different than the Ascendants. Still shaping the fate of civilizations without accountability."

Mosby's jaw tightened. "Sael—"

"I've seen worlds where no one stepped in," she said, not looking at him. "I've seen what happens when people who could act decide it's better not to."

Her eyes were bright now, but her voice didn't waver.

"This thing needs guidance. Structure. Someone who understands scale, consequence, restraint."

Merrow held her gaze.

"You mean control," he said.

"Yes," she answered.

The word landed clean and hard.

Ted shifted slightly. "Control alters intent."

“Control provides responsibility,” Sael countered.

Merrow’s expression was almost unbearably gentle.

“And who watches the one in control?”

Sael didn’t hesitate.

“I would,” she said.

Silence filled the room, heavy as gravity.

Mosby closed his eyes for a moment.

There it is.

Not ambition.

Not glory.

Burden.

And the certainty that she could carry it.

Merrow leaned back slowly in his chair, studying her like a teacher watching a student reach the wrong conclusion for the right reasons.

“That,” he said quietly, “is exactly the kind of mind it is careful of.”

The corridor lights were already red when the first internal bulkhead alarms began to howl.

“Multiple breaches,” Merrow said from the primary control station, hands moving with practiced familiarity across interfaces no one else understood. “They are bypassing outer security faster than expected.”

Mosby checked his weapon. “Story of our lives.”

Sael met his eyes for half a second — argument unfinished, trust strained — then nodded toward the exit corridor.

“We fall back to the ship,” she said. “Now.”

Ted sealed another bulkhead behind them. Somewhere deeper in the base, heavy doors slammed shut with bone-rattling force.

“They will adapt,” he said.

“I know,” Mosby replied. “We just need them to adapt slower than we run.”

[RUNNING BATTLE THROUGH THE BASE — PLACEHOLDER FOR ACTION SEQUENCE]

Close-quarters fighting in narrow industrial corridors. Slugthrowers, ricochets, failing lights, manual overrides, Mosby wounded in the shoulder but continuing. Ted manipulating bulkheads and pressure doors. Sael covering retreat while Merrow is protected and guided. The Caretaker remains with Merrow — present but not intervening directly. The group barely reaches the landing bay under fire.

The Farther Star’s ramp sealed just as the first Ascendant team reached the bay threshold.

Mosby hit the thrusters hard.

The ship tore out of the cavern on a ragged plume of exhaust, scraping past the crater lip with meters to spare.

“Corvette lifting!” Sael called.

“I see it,” Mosby growled.

Behind them, the Ascendant ship clawed skyward, scarred hull catching starlight as weapons ports glowed to life.

“External tanks still attached,” Ted warned. “Structural strain rising.”

“Not for long,” Mosby said.

He armed the emergency release.

“The last of the external tanks tore free.”

For a fraction of a second they hung between the Farther Star and the pursuing corvette — dull cylinders tumbling in slow silence.

Then the corvette’s forward guns fired.

The tanks erupted.

Not a neat explosion. A dirty, roiling bloom of fuel and debris that swallowed the corvette’s bow in flame and shrapnel.

“Hit!” Mosby barked.

The shockwave caught the Star a heartbeat later, slamming through the hull. Alarms howled as the ship lurched sideways, already unstable from the fuel imbalance.

Ted clung to the console. "Structural integrity is now... negotiable!"

"We don't have enough fuel," Sael said, eyes on the readouts. "Main tank's below jump threshold."

"I know!" Mosby snapped, wrestling the controls. "I just need—"

The FTL field stuttered.

On the display, the lattice geometry wavered like a reflection in disturbed water.

It should have collapsed.

Instead, something pushed back.

Merrow's voice cut through the chaos, calm and focused in a way that didn't belong to panic.

"Hold the field steady," he said.

Mosby shot him a look. "We don't have the fuel!"

"You have enough," Merrow replied. "If the path is shorter."

Ted turned. "That is not how transit works."

"It is," Merrow said softly, eyes unfocused now, as if listening to something far away. "If the topology cooperates."

The lights dimmed as power bled into the drive.

The hum changed — deeper, uneven, like an engine running outside its design limits.

Sael felt the pressure in her skull again, the sense of something vast pressing through a narrow space.

Merrow's hand tightened on the console.

"Now," he said.

Space folded wrong.

Not the smooth, practiced slip of a normal jump — this was violent, asymmetrical. Stars didn't stretch into lines; they tore sideways in jagged arcs. The ship screamed as the field geometry twisted under forces it had never been built to withstand.

Mosby gritted his teeth, fighting to keep them pointed anywhere but apart.

“Field containment failing!” Ted shouted.

“Just a little longer,” Merrow whispered.

Then the drive died.

Silence slammed into them as the Farther Star fell out of FTL like debris from a storm.

The ship spun, uncontrolled, emergency lights strobing across dark consoles.

Mosby killed rotation with the last of the maneuvering thrusters. The hull shuddered, then steadied into a slow drift.

“Report,” he rasped.

Ted’s hands moved over darkened panels. “FTL system is... gone. Salt reserves completely depleted. Primary fuel exhausted. We are on battery and auxiliary reserves only.”

Sael looked out the forward port.

Her breath caught.

They weren’t alone.

Ships dotted the black — dozens of them. Tugs, cutters, emergency craft moving in careful patterns around fields of drifting wreckage.

A fractured ring of metal hung in the distance, lit by work lights and beacon strobes.

Dawnreach.

The broken gate.

Mosby let out a hollow laugh. “You’ve gotta be kidding me.”

Sael reached for the comm. “Any vessel in range, this is trader Farther Star. We are adrift, minimal power, medical assistance required.”

For a moment there was only static.

Then a voice answered — tired, busy, very human.

“Farther Star, this is Dawnreach Recovery Control. We have you on scope. Sit tight. Help is on the way.”

Sael sagged back into her seat.

Behind them, the path they had taken through space had already vanished — a wound in reality that had closed, leaving no sign of how close they had come to not arriving at all.

The Farther Star drifted into the waiting arms of Dawnreach Recovery like a wounded animal too tired to resist.

Tugs locked on. Stabilizers fired in careful bursts. Floodlights washed over the scarred hull, picking out missing plates, warped seams, the ugly, empty mounts where the external tanks had once hung.

Inside, no one cheered.

They were too tired.

Docking clamps thudded home.

“Power transfer complete,” a voice announced over comms. “You are secure. Medical teams are inbound.”

Ted exhaled slowly. “Good. Because I am very nearly out of opinions.”

The airlock cycled.

Dawnreach personnel came aboard in waves — medics, engineers, officials in station gray with the clipped movements of people who hadn’t slept in days.

They took Ted first.

Then Mosby, who protested until someone reminded him he was bleeding through his bandage again.

Sael followed last.

She paused at the hatch, looking back once at the battered interior of the Star.

So much had happened in these corridors.

She stepped through.

Dawnreach Gate Control was not built for comfort.

It was built for scale.

Even damaged, even half its systems jury-rigged, it hummed with activity — crews coordinating rescue, triage, salvage operations around the shattered remains of the old gate.

They were escorted through it, past people who barely glanced at them.

Everyone here had bigger problems.

In the confusion — stretchers, shouted instructions, equipment carts rolling in every direction — Merrow slowed.

Just a step.

Ted, walking beside him, matched it instinctively.

Merrow looked at him.

Ted's head tilted.

Something passed between them — not words, not even thought as humans understood it.

Recognition.

Permission.

Relief.

Ted drew in a slow breath, eyes unfocusing for just a moment.

Merrow's shoulders sagged.

When Ted blinked, the weight was different.

He looked around at the chaos of Dawnreach, at the hundreds of people moving through grief and exhaustion and quiet determination.

"This is sufficient," he murmured.

A moment later, he stepped aside to let a team of stretcher-bearers pass.

When they cleared his line of sight, he didn't rejoin the group.

He turned down a side corridor, blending into the tide of workers, evacuees, engineers — just another tired being in a place full of them.

No one stopped him.

No one noticed.

Behind him, Merrow straightened.

For the first time in years, he felt only himself.

He smiled faintly.

They were taken to a temporary debrief suite — Mosby on a cot, shoulder sealed and wrapped; Sael standing by the viewport, looking out at the wreckage field.

An officer in Dawnreach gray spoke quietly with a medic near the door.

“...Farther Star crew will remain under observation. No formal charges. Too many unknowns. Too many witnesses.”

Sael barely heard him.

Her eyes were on the broken gate ring outside.

She felt it like a physical absence.

Not in the room.

Not in Merrow.

Not anywhere she could reach.

She knew, with a cold certainty, what had happened.

It had left.

Not to her.

She closed her eyes.

Mosby watched her from the cot.

“You gonna say it,” he asked quietly, “or am I?”

She didn’t turn.

“I thought,” she said, voice tight but controlled, “I could help guide it.”

Mosby nodded once.

“Yeah,” he said. “I know.”

“I still think someone should.”

He didn’t argue.

“That might be true,” he said. “But it wasn’t your choice to make.”

She finally looked at him.

Anger. Shame. Grief.

“I couldn’t let it just wander off,” she said.

Mosby met her gaze steadily.

“Looks like you never could.”

Silence stretched between them — not broken, but changed.

Outside, the recovery ships moved like slow insects around the carcass of the gate.

Inside, the *Farther Star* sat in drydock, stripped, cracked, barely holding together.

Alive.

But only just.

And now, for the first time, they had no mission.

No cargo.

No destination.

Just a broken ship in a wounded system — and the long work of deciding who they were without the weight of something greater riding with them.

When the debriefings were finally done, Mosby walked back to the berth alone.

No escort. No ceremony. Just another spacer released back into a shipyard full of damaged vessels and tired crews.

He saw the *Farther Star* before he reached her.

She didn’t look like a ship anymore.

She looked like a project.

Hull plates missing. Scoring along her flanks where debris had torn past. The drive housing warped and discolored, access panels hanging open like exposed ribs. Her paint — the saints, the sigils, the eyes — burned away in great, ugly swaths.

He stopped at the bottom of the ramp.

For a long time, he didn't move.

"She held together," he said quietly.

Ted's voice came from just behind him.

"Yes," he agreed. "With enthusiasm rather than structural integrity."

Mosby huffed once. It might have been a laugh.

He climbed the ramp and stepped into the cargo bay. The place felt smaller now. Empty. Every dent and scorch mark told a story he wished he could forget.

"I can't fix this," he said finally. "Not like this."

Ted moved past him, running a hand along a warped support beam as if greeting an old friend.

"Not quickly," Ted said. "Not cheaply."

Mosby leaned against the bulkhead, staring at the open access hatch to the engine compartment.

"I don't have the credits," he said. "Not even close."

Ted tilted his head. "That is... unfortunate."

Mosby let out a slow breath.

"She deserves better than this," he said.

Ted looked at the ship, then back at Mosby.

"Yes," he said simply.

Dinner was quiet.

Dawnreach had reopened one of its larger communal spaces for recovery crews and displaced travelers. Long tables. Recycled air. Food that tasted like it had been designed by committee.

Sael sat across from him, hands folded loosely around a cup that had long since gone cold.

She looked different without urgency driving her. Smaller, somehow.

"I was promoted," she said after a while.

Mosby raised an eyebrow. "Congratulations."

"I'm someone now," she said.

He waited.

She gave a faint, humorless smile. "It doesn't feel like I thought it would."

"No," he said gently. "It usually doesn't."

She looked at him then — really looked.

"I thought I was doing the right thing," she said. "I still think someone needs to... guide things. But I didn't trust you. I didn't trust anyone else to help carry it."

Mosby held her gaze.

"I know," he said.

She swallowed.

"Can you forgive me?"

He didn't answer right away.

"Yeah," he said at last. "I think I already did."

Her breath caught, just a little.

"And... us?" she asked. "Could we... try again? When this doesn't feel like a battlefield?"

Mosby looked down at his hands.

"Not now," he said quietly. "Maybe someday. But not now."

She nodded once. Accepting it. Hurting, but not surprised.

"I arranged for your payment," she said. "Full contract. Hazard bonus. Ted too."

"That'll help," he said.

"It won't fix the Star," she replied.

"No."

They sat in silence for a moment more.

Then she stood.

“Goodbye, Mosby.”

“Yeah,” he said. “Goodbye, Sael.”

She left without looking back.

Ted was in the engine compartment when Mosby returned.

Panels open. Tools laid out in careful rows. He’d already started.

“She paid us,” Mosby said, leaning in the hatch.

Ted made a thoughtful sound. “Yes. I have received the transfer.”

He paused, then frowned slightly at his wrist display.

“Friend Mosby,” he said, “I am observing an additional deposit.”

Mosby blinked. “What?”

Ted turned the display toward him.

“I do not recognize the source,” Ted said. “It is... substantial.”

Mosby pulled up his own account.

There it was.

A second transfer. Anonymous. Clean. Large enough to make his pulse jump.

He stared at the number.

Ted looked at him.

“Do you suppose,” Ted said carefully, “this is coincidence?”

Mosby let out a slow breath.

“No,” he said.

He looked around the battered engine bay, at the torn plating and scorched conduits.

Then back at the numbers.

“Maybe,” he said softly, “we’re not done yet.”

Ted's eyes brightened just a fraction.

"That," he said, "would be agreeable."

Days later, Mosby stood alone by an observation window.

A Thalean transport was preparing to depart, and Sael was aboard, returning to the world she had come from.

He watched as the mooring clamps disengaged and the transport's thrusters nudged it gently away from the facility. Beyond it, framed against the black, hung the temporary gate the Solarian Navy had erected — a skeletal ring of light and scaffolding, already busy with cautious traffic as trade crept back into the wounded system.

He felt the sadness before he put a name to it.

Not regret. Not exactly.

Just the quiet ache of a path that had closed.

Would he have done what Sael did, if their positions had been reversed?

He didn't know.

That was the part that stayed with him.

The transport joined the outbound queue, gliding toward the shimmering threshold. For a moment it hung there, small and bright against the dark — then slipped through and was gone.

Mosby let out a slow breath he hadn't realized he was holding.

Then he turned and made his way back toward the repair bay.

The Farther Star had been stripped almost to her frame. Hull plates stacked nearby, conduits exposed, the drive assembly half-disassembled in a cradle of scaffolding and support arms.

She looked worse than she had in space.

But she was still here.

Ted stood on an elevated platform, directing a repair team — mostly Talari, with a few humans woven among them. They moved with careful coordination, tools flashing, voices low and focused.

Ted paused when he saw Mosby and climbed down the ladder with deliberate care.

"Friend Mosby," he said, "she was a remarkable individual. But conflicted."

Mosby nodded once.

“Yeah,” he said. It was all he had.

Ted tilted his head slightly, studying him.

“You will need to consider your feelings for her.”

Mosby gave him a sideways look. “Oh?”

Ted clasped his hands behind his back.

“People, and places, and even moments,” he said thoughtfully, “sometimes become... intertwined. If this is so, it will reveal itself in time.”

Mosby looked past him at the skeleton of his ship, at the scars and the work still ahead.

“Guess we’ll see,” he said quietly.

Ted inclined his head once, satisfied, and turned back toward the waiting hull.

Mosby stayed where he was a moment longer, listening to the steady rhythm of tools on metal.

By the time the Farther Star was declared spaceworthy again, Mosby and Ted were more than ready to leave Dawnreach behind.

She didn’t look like herself yet — new plates in mismatched shades, drive housing still showing the faint ripple scars of stress — but she was sealed, stable, and humming with the low, familiar vibration of a ship that could move under her own power again.

That was enough.

Mosby was in the cargo bay supervising the final pallet load when a familiar voice echoed up the ramp.

“Captain Mosby,” Dr. Ilyan Merrow called, a small travel case in one hand, coat slung over his shoulder. “I was told you might still be accepting last-minute passengers.”

Mosby looked down from the lift platform. “Depends,” he said. “You bring your own gravity?”

Merrow smiled faintly. “I travel light. Professionally and philosophically.”

Ted appeared beside Mosby, wiping his hands on a rag. “Friend Merrow,” he said. “You have been released?”

“Yes,” Merrow replied. “After an impressive number of scans, interviews, and psychological assessments designed to confirm that I am exactly as harmless as I look.”

Mosby snorted. "That must've taken a while."

"They were very thorough," Merrow said dryly. "In the end, the official conclusion was that I am a retired academic with poor taste in real estate."

Ted tilted his head. "Accurate, if incomplete."

Merrow's eyes flicked to him with quiet amusement. "I've been cleared to return to Lurien. The Helion Institute has decided that exile was... excessive in hindsight."

"Metric physics still your game?" Mosby asked.

"It is," Merrow said. "Though I suspect I'll be encouraged to keep my research safely theoretical from now on."

Mosby leaned on the railing. "So what's this about a ride?"

Merrow shifted the case in his hand. "Brightwater lies reasonably close to my route. I thought I might trouble you for passage that far."

Ted's gaze sharpened slightly. "You wish to continue our conversations?"

Merrow met his eyes. "Very much."

Mosby looked between them. "You two planning to rewrite the laws of the universe in my engine room?"

"Not this trip," Merrow said. "I've done enough rewriting for one lifetime."

Ted made a thoughtful sound. "We will confine ourselves to discussion."

"Discussion I can handle," Mosby said. "You pay in stories or credits?"

Merrow considered. "I have both."

Mosby jerked his thumb toward the ramp. "Then welcome aboard, Doctor."

Merrow paused at the foot of the ramp, looking up at the patched hull, the fresh weld lines, the places where old paint had been sanded away.

"She's endured," he said quietly.

"Yeah," Mosby replied. "So have we."

Ted gestured toward the interior. "You will find the guest berth unchanged. Mostly."

Merrow climbed the ramp, moving a little slower than before but with steady steps.

As he passed Ted, he lowered his voice. "Did it feel... loud to you?"

Ted's eyes flicked toward the ceiling, toward nothing visible.

"For a moment," he said. "Then it found somewhere else to be."

Merrow nodded once, understanding more than the words carried. "Good. That's the important part."

Mosby watched them disappear into the ship, then glanced back at the bustle of Dawnreach one last time.

"Alright," he muttered. "Let's go home."

Moments later, the Farther Star eased free of the docking arms, turned her scarred nose toward open space, and began the long burn toward Brightwater.

Brightwater rose from the horizon under a pale blue sky, cloud bands drifting lazily over the warm ocean below.

Mosby brought the Farther Star down on manual, easing her through atmosphere with the careful touch of someone who knew every complaint in the hull. She shuddered a little on entry, drive housings still carrying the scars of hard use, but she held together.

She always held together.

The pier stretched out over the water like an old hand.

He settled her onto the landing pads with a soft thud of struts and a sigh of venting air.

For a moment, he just sat there in the cockpit, hands resting on the controls.

Home.

The cargo ramp lowered with its usual tired whine.

Manny was already halfway down the pier, rag in one hand, squinting up at the ship.

He stopped, hands on his hips, and just looked.

The mismatched plates. The fresh weld seams. The long scars down her sides. Whole sections where the old paint had burned clean off.

Manny let out a slow breath through his teeth.

"Well," he said. "That's new."

Mosby came down the ramp and joined him.

“She get you back,” Manny added, nodding at the hull. “Counts for something.”

“Yeah,” Mosby said.

Manny stepped closer, running a hand along a scorched seam. “You know how much paint this’s gonna take?”

Mosby gave a small nod. “Yeah.”

He turned and walked back up the ramp without another word.

Manny frowned slightly and followed, curiosity winning out.

Inside the cargo bay, Mosby popped the latch on a stack of sealed containers and peeled one open. Manny leaned in, reading the labels.

He blinked.

“Heat-rated?” he said. “Vacuum-rated?”

Mosby shrugged. “Figured we do it right this time.”

Manny looked at him for a long second.

Then he nodded once. “Alright.”

They stood there a moment, looking at the stripped metal and scarred plating.

Mosby rested a hand on the bulkhead.

“She’s still got more in her,” he said.

Manny snorted. “Yeah. So do we.”

He jerked his chin toward the shoreline. “C’mon. Lemme show you something before we start arguing about primer.”

They walked down toward the water, the late sun throwing gold across the waves.

Manny pointed out past the shallows.

“Terraformers finally got the temps right,” he said. “Beach’s holding better too.”

Mosby followed his finger.

A small dark head lifted above the water, then another.

"Turtles," Manny said. "First nesting tracks showed up last month."

Mosby watched them move through the surf, slow and steady.

"Good," he said.

They stood there for a while, quiet, the ship behind them and the tide coming in.

It was late.

No moon, just a low ceiling of clouds swallowing the stars. Far out over the water, lightning flickered inside a moving storm, silent at this distance, like a thought that hadn't decided to become a sound yet.

Mosby sat in the old chair outside the workshop, boots up on a crate, watching the horizon.

Thinking.

Or maybe not thinking at all.

He told himself it was the weather he was waiting on. The storm. The shift in the air before rain.

He didn't look up when he heard footsteps in the sand.

Korrin came down the beach with his pants legs rolled to his calves, barefoot, shoes hooked through two fingers. He carried a pair of bottles by the necks, condensation beading in the warm night air.

He didn't look like a colonel.

He didn't look like anything official at all.

He looked like a man who'd stepped out of a life for a few hours.

Korrin handed him a bottle without a word and sat on the overturned crate beside him, feet digging into the sand.

"I finally got some leave," Korrin said. "You created a lot of paperwork in my agency."

Mosby took a sip. Cold. Bitter. Perfect.

"That's what I do," he said.

Korrin nodded, like that tracked.

They watched the storm for a while — waves moving in the dark, wind shifting, carrying the smell of rain and salt.

Then Korrin exhaled slowly.

“When Thalean Intelligence traced the Caretaker’s last location,” he said, voice quieter now, “they were going to send a retrieval team.”

Mosby didn’t turn his head.

“Yeah,” he said.

“I steered them toward you instead.”

That got a glance.

Korrin shrugged slightly, still watching the water.

“Sael was... ambitious,” he said. “Smart. Capable. But she believes in systems. In levers. I wasn’t sure what she’d do if she got there first.”

He paused.

“I’m not sure I would’ve done any better.”

Mosby took another drink.

“And me?”

Korrin’s mouth twitched, just barely.

“You,” he said, “have a history of doing the right thing for the wrong reasons. Or the wrong thing for the right ones.”

Korrin stood.

“You do the right thing,” he added. “Last time, I was wrong.”

He started back up the beach, swallowed quickly by the dark.

Mosby listened to the surf, to the low roll of distant thunder.

Then Korrin’s voice carried back to him, almost lost in the wind.

“But this time—”

A beat.

“—this time I was right.”

Mosby didn’t answer.

He just watched the storm come in.

The End.

Asdf